

CM holds pre-budget talks with gig workers, farmers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday held a series of pre-budget consultations with gig workers, farmers, rural representatives, and labour groups ahead of budget 2026. The meetings, held at the Delhi Secretariat, aimed to gather direct inputs from different sections of society.

The Chief Minister said the Government would prioritise these suggestions while preparing the upcoming Budget to ensure it reflects "the aspirations of every section". Labour Minister Kapil Mishra and Delhi Gram Vikas Board Chairman Raj Kumar Chauhan also attended the consultations.

Gig workers, including drivers, raised concerns over job security, lack of social protection and poor working conditions. They demanded safe and adequate parking spaces, expansion of electric vehicle infrastructure, and subsidies for women to purchase EVs. Several participants called

for linking gig workers to provident fund systems and health schemes. They also urged the Government to recognise gig workers as "employees" instead of "partners", arguing that this would ensure better legal and social protection.

Participants proposed setting up a dedicated task force for gig workers. They also demanded rest facilities, more public toilets, and practical reforms in traffic regulations. Some flagged inconsistencies between Central and State labour laws and called for better coordination to ensure benefits reach workers.

In separate discussions, farmers and rural representatives highlighted gaps in agricultural infrastructure and village amenities. They sought improvements in irrigation systems, rural roads, and mandi operations.

Farmers also demanded formal recognition of their status in Delhi and asked for subsidies and incentives for agricultural activities. Issues related to land pooling and consolidation were raised,



with calls for more farmer-friendly policies.

Participants urged the Government to revise the circle rates of agricultural land through a fresh survey and ensure fair compensation mechanisms. They also demanded better access to Kisan Credit Cards, easier loans for farm equipment, and effective implementation of crop insurance schemes.

Farmers stressed the need to upgrade basic facilities in villages, including drainage, sanitation, drinking water, and electricity. They also called for planned urbanisation of villages and improvements in school infrastructure and access to education.

Labour groups, meanwhile, focused on issues related to wages, housing, healthcare, and workplace safety. They

demand labour offices in every district and increased staffing in the labour department. Workers also called for wider implementation of schemes such as ESIC and PPF, and proposed setting up a Labour Welfare Board. They suggested training centres for women workers and technology-driven skill development programmes for labourers. The Chief Minister said the

Government is committed to addressing these concerns. She said agriculture and rural development will receive special attention in the upcoming budget. She added that a study to revise circle rates has been underway for six months, and a decision will be taken soon.

The Chief Minister said the Government is also working on improving access to tractor loans, Kisan Credit Cards, and land consolidation, along with implementing central schemes effectively. She highlighted the importance of gig workers in the economy and said the Government will work to ensure their rights and security. "We will address their concerns and provide necessary facilities," she said.

Mishra said the consultations reflect a shift towards inclusive governance. He claimed that villages and farmers were neglected earlier, but are now a priority. He said development work worth ₹2,000 crore is underway in 366 villages across 13 districts under various initiatives.

1 dead, 3 injured in Bawana gang-related shooting



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A suspected gang-related shooting inside a house in Delhi's Bawana area left one man dead and three others injured, including a child, after armed assailants opened fire late Thursday. The deceased has been identified as Ravi. His father is in critical condition, while a 10-year-old child sustained a bullet injury to the leg. Another injured person is undergoing treatment.

According to initial reports, three unidentified men arrived on a motorcycle and forced their way into the

house. They opened fire indiscriminately, hitting multiple people inside before fleeing the spot. Police said the attack took place within minutes, giving the victims little time to respond. Four people suffered bullet injuries in the firing.

Teams from the Delhi Police reached the scene soon after receiving information and shifted the injured to nearby hospitals. Ravi later succumbed to his injuries during treatment. Officials said preliminary investigation points to a possible gang-related motive, though no angle has been officially confirmed so far.

CM Rekha offers Navratri prayers at Jhandewalan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday visited the Jhandewalan Temple to mark the first day of Chaitra Navratri. The Chief Minister offered prayers and announced the Government's continued push to promote cultural and spiritual events across the city.

The Chief Minister performed special rituals at the temple and prayed for the well-being, prosperity, and happiness of Delhi's residents. The visit comes at the start of the nine-day festival dedicated to Goddess Durga, a significant occasion for devotees across the country.

Speaking after the puja, the Chief Minister said Navratri reflects India's cultural strength and spiritual heritage. She said the festival inspires people with positive energy and a sense of service towards society.

"Navratri is a symbol of devotion and strength. It gives people inner energy and encourages them to



work for society," she said. She added that she prayed for peace and prosperity in every household in Delhi and hoped that the blessings of Goddess Durga would guide families across the city.

Soon after the temple visit, the Chief Minister attended a devotional music programme titled 'Bhajan Clubbing', organised near the temple premises. The event fea-

tured live bhajan performances and drew participation from devotees and local residents. Officials said the event aimed to blend traditional devotional practices with contemporary formats to attract wider participation, especially among younger audiences.

The Chief Minister appreciated the artists and performers at the event, saying such gatherings help bring communities together.

Kapil Mishra marks Hindu New Year with cultural push

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi's Art, Culture and Language Minister Kapil Mishra on Thursday outlined the Government's push to promote cultural identity alongside modern development, as the city marked the Hindu New Year and Chaitra Navratri with a cultural programme at the Delhi Secretariat.

The event, organised by the Sahitya Kala Parishad under the Department of Art, Culture and Language, featured classical and folk performances dedicated to Goddess Durga. Mishra said

such initiatives form a key part of the Government's broader cultural policy.

Extending greetings on the occasion of the Hindu New Year, Vikram Samvat 2083, and Chaitra Navratri, Mishra said Delhi is working towards a model where cultural heritage and urban development progress together.

"Balancing modern development with cultural identity is our priority," he said, adding that India's identity lies in its traditions, beliefs, and cultural legacy.

The programme included a series of performances centred on devotion and tradition.



Speaker launches AI-enabled chatbot

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Thursday launched AI-enabled chatbot 'Vidhan Sathi', an AI-enabled chatbot, ahead of the upcoming Budget Session. The app was launched on the occasion of the Hindu New Year and the auspicious festival of Navratri. Gupta said the Artificial Intelligence (AI) tool will function as a legislative research assistant for members of the House.

"The Vidhan Sathi app can be accessed by all MLAs of the Assembly. This will be the country's first legislative assembly to have such an AI-enabled tool," he added. The platform is available in both Hindi and English, and also offers voice-enabled features for ease of use during proceedings. The app can be accessed via QR code.

The chatbot is integrated with existing AI tools and will assist legislators in fact-checking, accessing parliamentary rules, and making debates more tech-friendly, the Speaker said.

Describing the app as a step towards a "tech-friend-



ly" legislative Assembly, he said it draws upon the Rules of Procedure, past debates, committee reports, and legislative records, ensuring that the information provided is relevant and institutionally grounded.

The support tool will be incorporated with the National e-Vidhan Sabha (NeVA) platform soon, he added. Its primary objective is not merely to provide access to documents, but to assist Members in analysing complex issues and presenting well-informed, evidence-based arguments in the House.

Gupta also informed that the Budget Session of the Eighth Delhi Legislative

Assembly will commence from 23 March (Monday), with the agenda to be finalised in the Business Advisory Committee on Friday.

The session will include key legislative business such as discussions on reports of the Committee of Privileges, the Public Accounts Committee, and matters relating to CAG reports, along with opportunities for Members to raise issues and participate in short-duration discussions. Further, the full rendition of "Vande Mataram" will also form part of the proceedings, reinforcing a sense of collective purpose and institutional spirit, Gupta informed.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Mahaveer Singh, Father of No.16016830H Hav Rohit Tomar, R/o- Vill & PO- Naglakhangar, Teh- Shikohabad, U.P- 205135, declare that in my Son's service record my name is wrongly recorded as Shri Mahabeer Singh whereas my correct name is Mahaveer Singh, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(552)C I, Munni Devi, Mother of No.16016830H Hav Rohit Tomar, R/o- Vill & PO- Naglakhangar, Teh- Shikohabad, U.P- 205135, declare that in my Son's service record my name is wrongly recorded as Muuni Devi whereas my correct name is Munni Devi, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(553)C I, Shakuntla Devi, W/o No.16017589N Hav Hariom, R/o- Vill- Amba, PO- Malakpur, Teh- Anupshahar, Dist- Bulandshahar, U.P., have changed my name from Shakuntla Devi to Shakuntala Devi, vide dated 19/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(554)C I, Ram Kumar Rajak, Father of JC-386068F Sub Maj(OCC) Manoj Kumar Rajak, R/o- Vill & PO- Baikunthpur, Teh- Sirmour, Dist- Rewa, M.P.- 486441, have changed my name from Ram Kumar Rajak to Ramkumar Rajak, vide affidavit dated 19/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Gulbadan, Mother of JC-386068F Sub Maj(OCC) Manoj Kumar Rajak, R/o- Vill & PO- Baikunthpur, Teh- Sirmour, Dist- Rewa, M.P.- 486441, have changed my name from Gulbadan to Gulabvati Rajak, vide affidavit dated 19/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(556)C I, Laxmi, W/o JC-386068F Sub Maj(OCC) Manoj Kumar Rajak, R/o- Vill & PO- Baikunthpur, Teh- Sirmour, Dist- Rewa, M.P.- 486441, have changed my name from Laxmi to Laxmi Devi Rajak, vide affidavit dated 19/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(557)C I, Ramnarian Yadav, Father of No.14660849M Hav (ATOELB) Ravinder Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Tumbaheri, Teh & Dist- Jhajjar, Haryana- 124109, have changed my name from Ramnarian Yadav to Ramnarayan, vide affidavit dated 19/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(558)C I, V Bhaskaran, Father of No.2615590L Sep Vipin B, R/o- Ottapilavilayil, Thekkum Bhagom Kollam, Kerala- 691584, have changed my name from V Bhaskaran to Bhaskaran Vasu, vide affidavit dated 19/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(559)C I, Kala Devi, Mother of No.14660849M Hav (ATOELB) Ravinder Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Tumbaheri, Teh & Dist- Jhajjar, Haryana- 124109, have changed my name from Kala Devi to Kalawati, vide affidavit dated 19/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Susheela Bs, Mother of No.2620787L Sep Bopanna B S, R/o- East & West Nemmale, Kodagu, Karnataka- 571249, have changed my name from Susheela Bs to Susheela B S, vide affidavit dated 19/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(562)C I, N Ambili, Mother of No.2615590L Sep Vipin B, R/o- Ottapilavilayil, Thekkum Bhagom Kollam, Kerala- 691584, have changed my name from N Ambili to Ambili, vide affidavit dated 19/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(563)C I, Bandana Anand, W/o JC-835512M NsSub Anand Shankar, R/o- Vill- Raghepura, PO- Laheriasarai, P.S- Bahadurpur, Dist- Darbhanga, Bihar - 846001, have changed my name from Bandana Anand to Bandana Kumari, vide affidavit dated 19/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(564)C I, Hitherto known as Rupasree Poddar alias Rupasree Saha W/o Dr. Biswajit Saha residing at 504, CS 10, Supertech Capetown, Sector 74, Noida, 201301, have changed my name to Rupasree Poddar Saha for all purposes.

PD(564)C I, Kala Devi, Mother of No.14660849M Hav (ATOELB) Ravinder Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Tumbaheri, Teh & Dist- Jhajjar, Haryana- 124109, have changed my name from Kala Devi to Kalawati, vide affidavit dated 19/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

**Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot**
Ph: 01639-256232, 256236

AdvT. No. BFU-26/07

VACANCIES

Online applications are invited wff 24-03-2026 to 13-04-2026 from eligible candidates through University website i.e www.bfuhs.ac.in for the recruitment to the posts of **Professor & Assistant Professor (Pharmacuetics, Pharmacological Chemistry, Pharmacology, Pharmacognosy)** Under Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot.

For Application form, fee, specialty wise detail of posts, Category wise distribution and other terms & conditions, visit University website: www.bfuhs.ac.in

Sd/-
REGISTRAR

3108/12/2025-26/9683 Dated CHD - 19/03/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

Shares of JB Chemicals & Pharmaceuticals Pvt. Ltd., Regd. Off.: Akashdeep Bldg., Barakhamba Rd., New Delhi, in name of Late Smt. C. Vijayalakshmi @ Vijayalakshmi Chemudupati & Sh. Varaha Narasimham Durvasula, not received by legal heirs C V Indira, C Padma, D Satya & C U Shiva, who have applied for duplicate shares & transmission. Folio: V005044. Cert. No.: 000200375, Dist. No.: 154814811. Shares: 3000 of Re.1/- each. Any claim within 15 days to company, failing which transmission & duplicate shares will be issued without further notice. Address: D-702, Anandok Society, Mayur Vihar Phase 1, Delhi-110091. Dt: 19/03/2026. Place: Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that Mrs. Poonam Rani is the owner of Flat no. 104, on Upper Ground Floor, without roof right, area measuring 64 Sq. Yds., i.e. 7023 Sq. Mtrs. Plot no. C-2, out of Khasra no. 1009, Situated at Residential Colony Mahendra Enclave, Village Razapur, Pargana Dasana, Tehsil & District Ghaziabad, UP through Sale Deed dated 16.01.2026 as doc. no. 3475 executed by Mr. Vinod Kumar in favour of Mrs. Poonam Rani in respect of said flat.

Mrs. Poonam Rani is in the process of mortgaging the said plot with SBI India Credit Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 07 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 07-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 07-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline: +910120-40499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

**AXIS BANK LTD.**

Retail Asset Centre of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) rules 2002, issued demand notice upon the Borrower(s) / Co-Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagee(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the demand notice hereby given to the Borrower(s) / Co-Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagee(s) and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/ her under Section 13(4) of the said Act

The Borrower(s) / Co-Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagee(s) in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of Axis Bank Ltd. The Borrower(s) / Co-Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagee(s) / attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Sr. No	Name Of Borrower/Co-Borrowers/Guarantor	Date of Demand Notice (As On Date Of Notice)	Date of Possession
1.	Late Mr. Rahul Jain Through Its Legal Heirs, 1. Mrs. Snehlata Jain W/o Late Mr. Rahul Jain Flat No. 2205, Tower- 2, 21st Floor, Lotus, Zing Sector 168, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Near Golden Palm, Noida, Uttar Pradesh - 201301 (Co-Applicants & Legal Heir) Also At- Mrs. Snehlata Jain W/o Late Mr. Rahul Jain Flat No-1408, Tower-9, Purnachal Royal Park, Sec-137, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301 (Legal Heir)	27-Nov-2025	18-Mar-2026
Rs. 58,01,770/- (Rupees Fifty Eight Lakh One Thousand Seven Hundred Seventy Only)			
Details of Properties:- Unit 2205, Tower-2, 21st Floor, Lotus Zing Plot No. Gh 01A, Sec 168, Noida, Uttar Pradesh - 201301 And Bounded As Under, - East: As Per Title Deed, West: As Per Title Deed, North: As Per Title Deed, South: As Per Title Deed			
The above-mentioned Borrower(s) / Co-Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagee(s) are hereby given a 30 days' Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold on the expiry of 30 days' from the date of publication of this Notice, as per the provisions under the Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.			
Date: 20.03.2026, Place: Noida		Sd/-, Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.	

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed that my client Smt. Saroj Devi W/o Sh. Kamal Singh R/o H.no. Wz-54/4A, Palam Village, New Delhi-110045, has sever all their relations with her son Mr. Rohit Sharma and his wife Sheetal Kumari due to their bad behavior towards my client, as well as they are not under control of my clients. It is further noted that my client has disowned, debarred her son and his family from all their movable and immovable properties. It is further informed that Whosoever dealing with her son Mr. Rohit and His family will do at his/her own risks and responsibility. My client will not be responsible for any debt or dealing done by Mr. Rohit and His Family. SHIVAJI TIWARI (ADVOCATE) Ch-352, western, wing, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi-110054

PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client Hemlata Ramola owner of the First Floor Back R.H.S, Property No. F39/3, Pvt. No. 3, Old No. F39, area 62.02 sq yds, Khara no.787 as documents 306, North-A Block, West Vinod Nagar, Delhi-92, and My Client Purchase aforesaid property from Anjali Thakur vide Notarized GPA, ATS and Will Dated 10.04.2013, Now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. It is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim/right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 08 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760- Dwarika Court Sector-10, Dwarika, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public Mr. Abhishek Sharma and Mrs. Priyanka Sharma are the Owners of Entire First Floor, without roof right, "said Floor", Plot no. 627, area measuring 286 Sq. Mtrs, situated in the Residential Colony Known as Sector - 45, Gurugram, Haryana, through Sale Deed dated 07.02.2025 Doc.No.21088 executed by Mrs. Anshula Dhammi in favour of Mr. Abhishek Sharma and Mrs. Priyanka Sharma.

The owner has misplaced the (3) Original Transfer Deed in blood relation dated 19.10.2022 as doc. no. 13971, executed by Mrs. Pushpa Yadav in favour of Mr. Varun Yadav in respect of Entire First Floor, without roof right, Plot no. 627, area measuring 286 Sq. Mtrs., for which complaint is regd. vide Application No.- 036, registered at P.S. DLF Gurgaon Sector-29 on 30.12.2024. Anyone who finds the above-mentioned documents, kindly handover the same to the Manager of ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd., Janakpuri.

Mr. Abhishek Sharma and Mrs. Priyanka Sharma are the process of mortgaging the said Property with ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 15-days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 15-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 15-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline: +910120-40499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

Date: 20th March, 2026

INVITATION TO THE STAKEHOLDER MEETING

DMRC is carrying out Environmental Studies for new corridor and is pleased to invite the Stakeholders for a meeting as per the following schedule:

31st March: 3 pm onward, at The Bharat Scouts and Guides, National Headquarters, Lakshmi Mazumdar Bhawan, 16, M.G. Marg, Indraprastha Estate, New Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby notified to the public that Sweta Estates Private Limited and Apoorva Promoters Pvt. Ltd., having their corporate office at The Median, Central Park Resorts, Sector-48, Sohna Road, Gurugram-122018, have lost the following original land documents:-

S. No.	Name / Nature of Land Document
1	WILL of Sh. Dalesh Singh in favour of Sh. Sanjay Kumar, Sh. Anil Kumar (2/3 Share), Sh. Rohit, Sh. Jatin, Smt. Kavita Devi (1/3 Share) duly executed on 13.09.1996 and stamped and registered in the office of sub-registrar, Gurgaon as Vasika No. 1057 on dated 13.09.1996.
2	Sale Deed duly executed on 09.08.2004 and registered in the office of sub-registrar, Gurgaon as Vasika No. 2151 on dated 09.08.2004 (Mutation No. 1586) executed by Smt. Bharto Devi in favour of M/s Apoorva Promoters Pvt. Ltd.
3	Sale Deed duly executed on 09.08.2004 and registered in the office of sub-registrar, Gurgaon as Vasika No. 10158 on dated 09.08.2004 (Mutation No. 1587) executed by Sh. Dharambir in favour of M/s Apoorva Promoters Pvt. Ltd.
4	Sale Deed duly executed on 09.08.2004 and registered in the office of sub-registrar, Gurgaon as Vasika No. 10159 on dated 09.08.2004 (Mutation No. 1588) executed by Sh. Mahender, Sh. Romotar, Sh. Radhey Shyam, Sh. Krishan Lal in favour of M/s Apoorva Promoters Pvt. Ltd.
5	Sale deed duly registered in the office of sub-registrar, Gurgaon as Vasika No. 9041 dated 26.08.2009 executed by Sh. Dharamender Yadav in favour of Smt. Pushpa.
6	WILL duly registered in the office of sub-registrar, Badshahpur as Vasika No. 151 on dated 01.02.2018 executed by Sh. Sardar Singh in favour of Sh. Rajesh Kumar, Sh. Sunil, Sh. Krishan.
7	Sale Deed duly executed on 23.05.2018 and registered in the office of sub-registrar, Gurgaon as Vasika No. 1922 dated 23.05.2018 executed by Sh. Gulab Singh in favour of M/s Sweta Estates Pvt. Ltd.
8	Sale deed duly executed on 05.07.2018 and registered in the office of sub-registrar, Badshahpur as Vasika No. 3698 on dated 05.07.2018 executed by Smt. Bhagwati Devi in favour of M/s Sweta Estates Pvt. Ltd.
9	Sale Deed duly executed on 01.08.2018 and registered in the office of sub-registrar, Badshahpur as Vasika No. 4814 on dated 01.08.2018 executed by Smt. Pushpa Devi in favour of M/s Sweta Estates Pvt. Ltd.
10	Sale Deed duly executed on 01.08.2018 registered in the office of sub-registrar, Badshahpur as Vasika No. 4821 on dated 01.08.2018 executed by Smt. Jagmurti in favour of M/s Sweta Estate Pvt. Ltd.
11	WILL duly registered in the office of sub-registrar, Badshahpur as Vasika No. 4 dated 05.04.2019 executed by Sh. Amit Yadav in favour of Smt. Binla wife of Sh. Hari Kishan.
12	Sale Deed duly executed on 12.07.2018 and registered in the office of sub-registrar, Badshahpur as Vasika No. 4881 on dated 16.07.2019 executed by Smt. Binla wife of Sh. Hari Kishan in favour of M/s Sweta Estates Pvt. Ltd.
13	Collaboration Agreement which duly registered in the office of sub-registrar, Badshahpur as Vasika No. 6507 on dated 29.01.2018 executed between Sh. Sardar Singh, Sh. Ram Niwas, Sh. Ramesh, Sh. Sanjay Kumar, Sh. Anil Kumar and Smt. Kavita Devi and M/s Sweta Estates Pvt. Ltd.

Further, the above-mentioned companies intend to create an equitable mortgage by deposit of title deeds in favour of Lender, for securing credit facilities sanctioned/to be sanctioned by the said bank.

Any person(s), company, authority, or institution having any claim, right, title, interest, or objection with respect to the aforesaid property or any part thereof is hereby requested to submit their objections, if any, in writing along with supporting documentary evidence to the undersigned within 7 (seven) days from the date of publication of this notice.

Failing which, it shall be presumed that no objections exist, and the proposed mortgage shall be completed accordingly.

For and on behalf of Sweta Estates Pvt. Ltd. and Apoorva Promoters Pvt. Ltd.

Authorized Signatory
Address: The Median, Central Park Resorts, Sector-48, Sohna Road, Gurugram-122018
Email ID: Rajeshwar.khurrana@centralpark.in
Mobile No: +91 9911292938

Sood orders city-wide fire audit after Palam tragedy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Minister Ashish Sood on Thursday ordered a city-wide fire safety audit covering all establishments, including those operating in residential areas, in a move aimed at closing gaps in enforcement and preventing accidents.

This comes after the blaze at a building which claimed nine lives, including three children, in Palam on Wednesday. The directive mandates third-party experts to map and audit establishments across the city to ensure compliance with standard fire safety norms.

Sood directed third-party experts to be engaged to map and audit all establishments in the city for fire safety compliance. "The move aims to identify gaps in safety measures and ensure adherence to prescribed norms across commercial units operating in mixed-use areas," he said.

"Every worker and every family deserves to feel safe, no matter where they are," Sood said, adding that the Government intends to eliminate gaps in safety coverage and strengthen preventive measures. Officials said the exercise will go beyond traditional checks that often focus only on commercial zones. Sood said the Government will no longer allow "blind spots" in safety oversight. "Every worker and every family deserves to feel safe, no matter where they are," he said. "We are ending gaps in enforcement and ensuring that safety rules apply everywhere."

The decision expands the scope of fire safety inspections to include small businesses and commercial activities running within residential neighbourhoods. These areas often escape routine checks despite housing workshops, storage units, and informal enterprises.

Officials said the involve-

ment of third-party experts aims to ensure speed, accuracy, and independent assessment. The experts will conduct mapping and on-ground audits of establishments to identify violations and recommend corrective measures. The minister said the focus is on prevention rather than response.

"We are not waiting for accidents to happen. We are working to stop them before they start," he said. The move comes amid growing concerns over fire risks in densely populated areas where commercial activities operate in proximity to homes. Narrow lanes, poor access for emergency vehicles, and a lack of safety equipment often increase the risk in such zones.

Officials said the audit will help identify high-risk locations and ensure that safety norms are followed across the board. The exercise will also create a detailed database of establishments in the city, which authorities say



Forensic team and Delhi Police personnel inspecting the building to collect evidence in New Delhi on Thursday

will improve monitoring and future enforcement.

Sood said the initiative is part of a broader effort to build a safer urban environment. He described the plan as a step towards a "secure and future-ready Delhi" where safety is not compromised. The Government said strict compliance will follow the audit, with action likely against establishments found violating safety norms.

According to Delhi Fire Services (DFS) data, 2,716 fire calls were received between January 1 and March 15 this year, down from 3,352 in the corresponding period of 2025. The city is currently reporting an average of around 36 fire calls per day. Despite the dip, casualties remain a concern, with 13 deaths and 111 injuries reported so far this year, compared to 18 fatalities and 109 injuries during the same period last year.

Reflecting the magnitude of fire-related emergencies in the national capital, the 2025

data revealed that the DFS responded to a total of 18,670 fire calls, while the overall number of emergency calls, including rescue operations, stood at 35,865. According to the data, last year, at least 76 people lost their lives in fire incidents, and 565 were injured. In addition, the fire personnel carried out 2,278 rescue operations, along with 3,892 animal rescues and 3,251 bird rescues.

A senior fire officer, while highlighting that more than 80 per cent of fire incidents are linked to electrical faults, said, "The increasing load on old wiring systems, coupled with poor maintenance, often leads to short circuits. This remains one of the biggest causes of fires in the city," the officer said. He added that the presence of combustible materials such as furniture, fabrics and stored goods further worsens the situation, allowing fires to spread rapidly.

The issue has come into sharp focus after the March 18

blaze in Palam, where nine members of a family were killed after a fire engulfed a residential building with commercial use on lower floors. The incident exposed multiple risk factors, including high fire load, limited ventilation and access constraints in congested areas.

The officer said such mixed-use buildings are particularly vulnerable, as storage of flammable materials such as clothes and cosmetics can intensify fires within minutes, leaving little time for evacuation. Seasonal patterns also emerge from the data. In 2025, fire calls peaked during April (2,991 calls) and October (1,867 calls), suggesting a link with weather conditions and increased electrical usage.

Authorities have stressed the need for stricter enforcement of fire safety norms, especially in residential buildings and commercial establishments operating without clearances.

Grieving father alleges systemic negligence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A day after a devastating fire claimed nine lives in southwest Delhi's Palam, a grieving father returned to the charred remains of his home on Thursday, alleging that systemic negligence had taken away everything he held dear.

Rajender Kashyap, who lost nine members of his family in the blaze, entered the gutted structure near Ram Chowk Market along with police and forensic science laboratory (FSL) teams as part of the ongoing investigation. Overcome with grief after stepping out, he broke down and blamed the authorities. "This is the system's failure. Had there been a timely response, my family would have been alive," Kashyap claimed.

The four-storey building, located in a congested lane near Palam Metro Station, housed a cloth and cosmetics business in the basement, ground and first floors, while the family lived on the upper levels.

The fire broke out around 6.15 am on Wednesday, spreading rapidly through the structure and killing nine people, including a 70-year-old woman and three young girls, one of whom was just three years old. Three others were injured



Rajendra Kashyap, who allegedly lost nine family members in a building fire in Palam, speaking to the media on Thursday

while attempting to escape. Eyewitnesses had earlier alleged delays in rescue operations, claiming that the first hydraulic crane deployed at the spot malfunctioned and that a second crane took nearly an hour to arrive, costing crucial time.

On Thursday, neighbours gathered outside the building for a condolence meeting, as questions arose regarding the cause of the fire and the effectiveness of the emergency services.

Some residents suspected a short circuit, pointing to an electrical board near the staircase on the ground floor as a possible origin of the blaze, though the exact cause is yet to be ascertained. "The response was very late. If help had arrived

on time, things could have been different," a neighbour said, standing beside the bereaved father.

Another local alleged that at least four to five lives could have been saved with quicker intervention. "The first fire tender's hydraulic system did not work. That delay proved fatal," he claimed. The building now stands blackened and hollowed out, with its interiors completely gutted, as the neighbourhood struggles to come to terms with the scale of the tragedy. A case has been registered and a magisterial inquiry ordered into the incident, while further investigation is underway to determine the exact cause of the fire and any lapses in response.

Congress demands panel to probe fire

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav wrote to the Lieutenant Governor, Taranjit Singh Sandhu, on Thursday, demanding the constitution of a committee to inquire into the Palam fire incident, which claimed nine lives.

According to an official statement, Yadav, in his letter, said the "heart-wrenching" loss of lives could have been avoided with timely and efficient rescue operations.

He urged Sandhu to order a thorough investigation into the incident and take steps to curb the rising number of fire-related mishaps in the national capital, the statement read.

Citing data, he said 4,652 people died in fire incidents in Delhi between 2016 and 2025, while 24 deaths have

been reported in 2026 so far. Yadav alleged that delays in emergency response aggravated the Palam tragedy. "Fire tenders reached the spot after nearly an hour, and hydraulic machines did not open in time, leaving victims with no escape," he said.

He also flagged an acute shortage of manpower and equipment in the fire department, claiming that only half the required number of water tenders and specialised machinery were available at the site.

"There has been no recruitment of Fire Station Officers since 2012. A total of 70 fire stations have a requirement of 90 station officers, while currently there are only 18 station officers, out of which 12 are going to retire soon," Yadav alleged.



Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav

BJP, AAP leaders scuffle in Palam



AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal with party workers at Palam in New Delhi. He alleged that BJP workers blocked his visit to the family of a Palam fire victim

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A confrontation over a fatal blaze in southwest Delhi's Palam escalated into a physical scuffle between BJP MLA Kuldeep Solanki and AAP Delhi unit president Saurabh Bharadwaj on Thursday.

The clash broke out a day after a fire claimed the lives of nine people, with leaders from both parties trading charges over alleged lapses in the emergency response. The AAP alleged that BJP *karyakartas* blocked access, created a ruckus, pushed AAP leaders, prevented them from meeting the grieving family, and threw chairs.

The incident occurred when representatives from both sides visited the area where nine members of a family, including a 70-year-

old woman and her three granddaughters, died on Wednesday.

According to police, the altercation was triggered by a heated exchange over an alleged delay in deployment of hydraulic cranes during the firefighting operation.

"The argument escalated into a brief scuffle, with supporters from both sides raising slogans against each other," a senior officer with Delhi Police said.

The situation was brought under control after police intervention, the officer said, adding that additional force has been deployed in the area to maintain law and order.

Meanwhile, AAP Delhi AAP President Saurabh Bharadwaj stated that BJP leaders intended to attack Arvind Kejriwal and that

video evidence of the attempt exists, adding that an associate of a BJP MLA hurled a chair at former AAP MLA Vinay Mishra, injuring him, which reflected a clear and deliberate attempt to incite violence.

The Delhi BJP President Virendra Sachdeva said that since the fire broke out yesterday morning, it has been publicly known through media statements of neighbors and eyewitnesses that the lower floors of the building housed godowns and shops where large quantities of inflammable materials were stored.

These materials caught fire, and within moments, the blaze spread throughout the entire building. Many deaths had already occurred before the fire brigade arrived.

High Court orders tight security for peaceful Eid in Uttam Nagar



Barricades placed on a road as part of security arrangements ahead of Eid at Uttam Nagar on Thursday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday directed the city police and administration to ensure a conducive atmosphere for the peaceful and dignified observance of Eid in Uttam Nagar, where a 26-year-old man was killed in a clash on Holi.

A bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia said the police bandobast in the area should be such that it instils a sense of safety and security in all.

The bench directed the authorities to ensure that no one plays any mischief that has the potential to create any "untoward situation".

It clarified that the police arrangements in the area shall continue till the upcoming festival of Ram Navami.

The order was passed on a PIL filed by a civil rights group, the Association for Protection of Civil Rights, which approached the Delhi

High Court on Wednesday to prevent "imminent communal violence" on Eid in Uttam Nagar. The petition came up for hearing after a petitioner's counsel mentioned the matter before the Chief Justice's bench for an urgent listing during the day.

After hearing the parties, the court said Eid is a festival to rejoice, and it is the duty of all authorities to ensure that on such a "pious occasion", public life is not disrupted by any untoward incident of vandalism or hooliganism by any individual or any section of society.

It observed that the apprehensions in the petition arose from the incident of the death of a youth in the area on March 4, and therefore, the police must be "extra cautious" and ensure that "all sections of society maintain restraint considering the past incident".

"We thus direct the police and civil administration of the area to take all required

action, permissible under law, to ensure that the situation does not take any ugly turn and an atmosphere is created conducive to peaceful and dignified observance of the festival of Eid, which is likely to be tomorrow," the court ordered.

"Police bandobast to be made should be such as will instil a sense of safety and security in all. The authority shall also ensure that no one from any section of the society is permitted to play any kind of mischief, having the potential of creating any untoward situation," it further said. The court added that if, upon assessment of the situation, a need is felt to strengthen the arrangements, such measures shall be forthwith taken by the authorities.

"The situation as described in the petition not only calls upon authorities to be at constant strict vigil, but it also calls upon members of different sections of society to

100 pickets, rooftop watch in Dwarka

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 100 picket points, rooftop surveillance and increased barricading are among a slew of security measures taken ahead of Eid-ul-Fitr by Delhi Police in Dwarka district, including Uttam Nagar, where communal tension has been simmering since the March 4 killing of a man.

A senior officer on Thursday said police have drawn up a comprehensive plan to ensure peaceful celebrations. "Adequate arrangements have been made, and sufficient deployment will be in place to maintain law and order. We are fully prepared to deal with any situation," the officer said.

Police said deployment in and around sensitive pockets, particularly Hastsal village, where the killing took place, and adjoining areas, has been

reinforced and will remain in place throughout the festive period. Delhi Police and central armed forces personnel will be stationed at key points to prevent any untoward incident.

Tarun, 26, was killed in a clash between his family and their neighbours in the JJ Colony area on Holi on March 4. The violence broke out after water from a balloon thrown by a girl from Tarun's family splashed on a woman from his neighbour's family, according to police. Some Hindu outfits later staged a protest against the killing and torched two vehicles of the accused family members. Police have apprehended 14 people.

According to police, special focus is on mosques, Eidgahs and other religious sites, where a large number of people are expected to gather. Regular foot and vehicle patrols are being

conducted as part of area domination measures.

Authorities have also intensified surveillance, both on the ground and online. Social media platforms are being closely monitored for provocative or inflammatory content, with several such posts already identified and removed, police said.

As part of confidence-building measures, flag marches have been conducted in sensitive localities and will be repeated multiple times during Eid to reassure residents, they said.

Pradeep Shukla, president of the Uttam Nagar RWA, said security has been beefed up in the area with adequate barricading, and there is complete silence.

"Now it feels like the calm before the storm. We are afraid, but we are trying to ensure that everything remains normal," he said.

Rains, gusty winds sweep Capital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rain and gusty winds swept the national Capital on Thursday, sending the day temperature dipping sharply, and turning March into the wettest in three years, with an average of 9.4 mm of precipitation. The maximum temperature settled at 26.8 degrees Celsius, the lowest so far this month. The weather department has issued an orange alert for the city till 11.15 pm.

According to the weather office, an orange alert stands for "be prepared" for severe weather conditions that could disrupt daily life, including transport and routine activities. Meanwhile, a persistent cloud cover and intermittent rainfall brought relief to the city, sweltering in warmer conditions for days. The rainfall recorded during the day stood at 8.2 mm at the city's base observatory.

At Safdarjung, the city's base station, 9.4 mm of

average rainfall has been recorded till March 19 against a normal monthly average of 12.6 mm. The last time higher rainfall was recorded in March was in 2023, when the monthly total stood at 50.4 mm, underlining the intensity of the current spell.

Rainfall was recorded at Safdarjung (8.2 mm), Palam (6.2 mm), Lodhi Road (8.2 mm), Ridge (8.6 mm) and Ayanagar (7.2 mm) till 8.30 am, while other stations such as Pitampura (5.5 mm), Pusa (11.0 mm), Mayur Vihar (3.0 mm) and Janakpuri (12.5 mm) also recorded showers, reflecting precipitation across the capital with varying intensity. Light rainfall was recorded across parts of Delhi also on Wednesday.

At Safdarjung, a trace of rainfall was recorded between 8.30 am and 11.30 am. Ayanagar recorded relatively higher rainfall of 0.5 mm till 2.30 pm and 0.7 mm by 5.30 pm. Mayur Vihar recorded 3.0 mm of precipitation.



maintain restraint and conduct themselves in a manner which may promote peace and harmony and not cause any situation which may turn ugly," the bench further said. The court issued notice on the PIL and listed it for hearing on April 6.

Advocate Sanjay Lao, standing counsel for Delhi Police, assured that adequate police personnel from Dwarka district, additional force from Delhi Police and Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) have been deployed to ensure

Eid passes without incident. Since March 5, adequate police arrangements have been made on a round-the-clock basis in Uttam Nagar JJ colony as well as the neighbouring areas, and several preventive actions have been taken, Lao told the court.

He informed that eight companies of armed police personnel are present in all eleven areas under police stations in Dwarka district, and hundreds of police personnel are on vigil.

He further said that 50

inflammatory posts were taken down from social media platforms following monitoring of online platforms, and requests have been made to take down about 170 such posts to date.

Extensive verification has also been undertaken of over 8,000 persons in the area. "Aman committees" have been formed at every police station and 30 meetings have been held with the heads of religious places in the last two weeks, the police counsel further said.

IN FOCUS



Priests performing Ganga Aarti on the first day of Hindu New Year and Chaitra Navratri at Lalita Ghat in Varanasi

PTI

DJB to fix faulty bills with city-wide e-KYC drive



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Jal Board (DJB) on Thursday approved a series of ground-level measures to fix faulty water billing, expand sewer connections in under-served areas, and reduce pollution flowing into the Yamuna, directly targeting long-standing issues faced by residents. Chaired by Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, the Board cleared a city-wide e-KYC and digital database update drive for nearly 35 lakh consumers, alongside major sewer projects in Kirari and new wastewater treatment measures.

Officials said the decisions respond to repeated complaints about inflated bills, non-functional meters, missing bills, and a lack of sewer infrastructure in several colonies. To address billing problems, the DJB will carry out a door-to-door e-KYC verification exercise at a cost of ₹60 crore. The Board will use technology-enabled meter readings with photo capture, GPS tagging, and proof of delivery for bills to improve accuracy and accountability.

Singh said billing errors had become a daily concern for residents. "People want to pay their water bills. The problem starts when they receive inflated bills, when meters don't work, or when bills don't reach them on time," he said. "We are fixing these gaps at the ground level."

He added that the exercise aims to rebuild trust in the system. The DJB expects to create verified digital records for all registered consumers within six months, which officials say will reduce disputes and improve service

delivery. In a parallel move, the Board approved large-scale House Service Sewer Connections (HSSC) in Kirari and nearby areas, where residents have struggled for years without proper sanitation infrastructure.

The project will cover three major catchments. In Pratap Vihar, it will benefit around 4.30 lakh residents across 72 colonies. In Prem Nagar, it will cover 1.45 lakh residents in 30 colonies. In Bhagya Vihar and its surrounding areas, including three villages, the service will extend to approximately 1.5 lakh residents. Officials stated that the project will replace unsafe and unhygienic arrangements, thereby improving living conditions in these areas. Many households will receive their first sewer connections.

The DJB also cleared projects aimed at reducing pollution in the Yamuna by treating waste before it enters the river. The Board approved a ₹71.12 crore project for in-situ treatment of wastewater in the Delhi Gate drain. It will treat sewage at the source and prevent untreated discharge into the river. The DJB will also revive the pondage area upstream of the Wazirabad barrage to improve water quality and increase storage capacity.

Officials said these steps form part of a broader plan to clean the Yamuna by focusing on drains and untreated waste flows. The Board's decisions mark a shift towards addressing everyday civic problems that directly affect residents. From billing disputes to lack of sewer access, the measures aim to close long-pending gaps in basic services.

Congress raises alarm over VBSA bill's federal issues

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Thursday expressed serious concerns over the new Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (VBSA) Bill, alleging that the proposed law was violative of the federal structure of the Constitution.

In a statement, Congress general secretary, communications, Jairam Ramesh listed seven key issues the Congress has with the Bill in its present form, which include failure to consult state governments while framing it, constitutional overreach, absence of funding council, bureaucratisation of higher education and dilution of UGC's Consultative requirements.



The Congress has alleged that the architecture of higher education is sought to be "restructured" through the Bill, which is currently under consideration of the Joint Committee of Parliament.

"The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education's annual Demand for Grants report on the Department of Higher

Education presented yesterday revealed a shockingly high number of vacancies in key regulatory agencies like the University Grants Commission (UGC) and the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE).

"This concerning news comes at a time when there is already a move to restructure the architecture of higher education regulation

through the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (VBSA) Bill, 2025," he said.

Ramesh claimed that the ministry has not consulted state governments in the drafting of this bill, despite the fact that education is listed in the Concurrent List of the Constitution and this Bill directly impacts state universities.

He said that the proposed Bill, as stated in its Statement of Objects and Reasons, is introduced for passing in Parliament under Entry 66 of Union List in the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution, which gives specific legislative powers to Parliament that is only for "Co-ordination and determination of standards in institutions for higher education."

Ladakh development council delegation meets Home Minister Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A high-level delegation from the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council, Kargil, led by Chairman and Chief Executive Councillor Mohd Jaffer Akhoun and Member of Parliament Mohammad Haneefa Jan, called on Union Home Minister Amit Shah here on Thursday.

The delegation, which also included Executive Councillor Zakir Hussain, submitted a memorandum seeking the operationalisation of civil flights from Kargil. The Ladakh Autonomous Hill



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during a meeting with Chairman and Chief Executive Councillor of Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council, Kargil, Mohd Jaffer Akhoun along with MP Mohamad Haneefa in New Delhi

Development Council (LAHDC) leaders requested an extension of the existing runway and the establish a full-fledged civil airport to ensure connectivity, especially during the winter months when surface routes remain closed.

The delegation also pressed for district status for Sankoo and Shakar-Chiktan subdivisions. They noted that these "subdivisions are among the most populous and oldest in Kargil district, fulfil all necessary criteria". The delegation specifically requested their inclusion in the forthcoming official notification along with

other newly announced districts in Ladakh, according to a statement from the council.

The leaders also sought restoration of Administrative Approval and Expenditure Sanction powers up to ₹5 crore for the Deputy Commissioner and CEO of LAHDC Kargil to ensure the timely execution of developmental works at the district level.

In the health and education sectors, the delegation sought sanction of a 200-bedded hospital for Kargil, citing the inadequate infrastructure and increasing patient load at the existing 100-bedded facility. Further,

the Chief Executive Councillor (CEC) Akhnoon urged for early execution and operationalisation of the already sanctioned Engineering College in Kargil and called for the establishment of an Agricultural University to strengthen higher education and support the agrarian economy of the region, the council said in its statement.

The memorandum also sought a Women's Degree College at Sankoo to facilitate access to higher education for girls and eliminate the hardships they face in pursuing education outside the district.

Delhi LG Inspects Yamuna river

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Thursday inspected the Yamuna at Kalindi Kunj and called for involving scientific experts to develop practical and sustainable solutions for cleaning the river. During his visit to Kalindi Kunj Ghat, Sandhu took stock of the ground situation along the river, accompanied by senior officials from concerned departments. The visit comes amid ongoing concerns over pollution levels in the Yamuna.

Officials said the Lieutenant Governor discussed bringing in local and international experts



from leading scientific institutions and organisations to address the issue. The focus, they said, will be on identifying long-term measures that can be implemented effectively. Sandhu stressed the need for a scientific and coordinated approach to tackle pollution. He said expert inputs will play a key role in shaping future interventions aimed at improving water quality in the river. The visit is part of continued efforts by the admin-

istration to monitor conditions on the ground and accelerate clean-up work. Authorities have been under pressure to ensure visible improvement in the Yamuna, particularly by reducing untreated waste entering the river.

Later in the day, the Lieutenant Governor also travelled on the Delhi Metro and interacted with commuters during the journey. He described the Metro as an example of efficient and reliable public transport.

Sandhu said such systems can help solve several urban challenges if implemented effectively across cities. Officials said he spoke with passengers and took feedback on their daily commute.

Diplomat Vikram appointed Ambassador to China

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Seasoned diplomat Vikram Doraiswami was on Thursday appointed as India's new ambassador to China, a move that comes amid efforts by the two sides to rebuild ties that came under severe strain following the over four-year military standoff in eastern Ladakh.

Doraiswami, a 1992-batch Indian Foreign Service (IFS) officer, is currently serving as Indian High Commissioner to the United Kingdom. He will succeed Pradeep Kumar Rawat. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said Doraiswami is expected to



take up the new assignment shortly.

In the last few months, India and China have stepped up efforts to stabilise their relations, seeking a reset after the 2020 military standoff in the Galwan Valley plunged ties to the lowest point in decades.

India lives in Ram Rajya as world fights on: Yogi in Ayodhya

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ayodhya

While the world simmers in wars, India is "experiencing Ram Rajya", Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said on Thursday.

Adityanath made the remark while addressing a gathering here in the presence of President Droupadi Murmu, who installed a 150-kg gold-plated 'Shri Ram Yantra' at the Ram Temple. "Currently, numerous wars



are raging across the world; there is disorder, economic chaos, fear, and terror. Yet here in India, specifically at Ayodhya Dham, we stand liberated from fear, gather-

ing in our thousands to offer our salutations to the president," he said.

"By participating in this ceremony for the installation of the Sri Ram Yantra, we are experiencing the true essence of Ram Rajya," Adityanath said, according to a statement. The chief minister paid his tributes to the seers and farmers to say that an "unwavering faith" has always preserved India as a unified and supreme nation. Adityanath

extended his greetings to the public at the beginning of the Indian New Year. He claimed that people now prefer visiting temples with their families on the New Year instead of destinations "opposed to Sanatan values." He said that under the leadership of Narendra Modi, events such as the bhoomi puja, the consecration of Ram Lalla, the installation of Ram Darbar Idols, and now the Shri Ram Yantra ceremony reflect the

deep-rooted faith of the country. Adityanath alleged that faith had been dismissed as blind belief in the past, while political practices were not subjected to similar scrutiny.

He said the centuries-long faith associated with the Ram Temple movement ultimately prevailed after enduring prolonged struggles. The chief minister said that in 2025, around 156 crore people visited religious sites across Uttar Pradesh.

PM dials world leaders on West Asia crisis

In his call with Sultan Haitham, Modi conveyed Eid greetings while underscoring the importance of restoring stability. Both leaders agreed that dialogue remains the only viable path forward. He also reiterated India's position on respecting sovereignty and appreciated Oman's role in facilitating the safe return of stranded foreign nationals, including Indians.

During his conversation with Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani, the Amir of Qatar, Modi also extended warm Eid greetings to him and the people of Qatar. Calling him his brother, Modi reiterated that India stands in solidarity with Qatar and strongly condemned the attacks on the region's energy infrastructure. He expressed gratitude for the care and support provided to the Indian community in Qatar and hoped for peace and stability to prevail in the region. "We stand for safe and free navigation through the Strait of Hormuz," Modi said, sharing the conversation on his social media platform.

Speaking with King Abdullah II, Modi condemned attacks on energy infrastructure and warned of further escalation, while highlighting the shared commitment to ensuring uninterrupted movement of goods and energy supplies.

In a separate conversation with Anwar Ibrahim, Modi reiterated the need for early restoration of

peace through diplomatic means.

The outreach comes as India faces heightened vulnerability due to its dependence on energy imports routed through the Strait of Hormuz. Over 85% of its crude oil is imported, with nearly half transiting through the route, while strategic reserves cover just over a week of demand.

Recent attacks on energy infrastructure in the Gulf, including a strike on Qatar's Ras Laffan Industrial City, have further raised concerns. However, some relief has come from Iran allowing India-bound shipments to pass through the strait, easing immediate pressure.

The latest diplomatic engagement follows Modi's conversation a day earlier with UAE President Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, during which he condemned attacks on civilian and commercial infrastructure in the Emirates.

Markets tank as oil, gas infrastructure hit...

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said the impact on inflation remains "not substantial" so far, while Chief Economic Adviser Anantha Nageswaran warned that sustained \$100-plus crude could widen fiscal and current account deficits. Economists caution that prolonged closure of the Strait of Hormuz could push Brent crude to \$150-\$160 per barrel within months, triggering stagla-

FROM PAGE - 1

tion reminiscent of the 1970s, with higher inflation, slower growth, and tighter monetary policy. Airlines, emerging markets, and energy-intensive industries are already under pressure. While brief market rallies occurred on talks of US naval escorts or diplomatic engagement, Iran's leadership has vowed to keep the waterway closed until its demands are met, prolonging attacks on shipping. The global financial turbulence reflects a direct economic consequence of the geopolitical chokehold on one of the world's most vital energy arteries.

India flags global energy risks after strike...

Any prolonged disruption could impact fuel prices, supply chains and inflation.

The strike marks a broader escalation in the ongoing conflict, with energy infrastructure increasingly coming under attack. It follows Israeli strikes on the South Pars gas field in Iran, which is linked to Qatar's North Field—the world's largest natural gas reserve.

As one of the world's leading LNG exporters, Qatar supplies key markets across Asia and Europe, including India. Disruptions at Ras Laffan—home to major liquefaction and export facilities—could tighten global supply and increase price volatility.

Analysts warn that even limited damage may

delay shipments and push up spot prices, adding to existing pressures in energy markets.

Concerns are also rising over the security of the Strait of Hormuz, a critical route for global oil and gas flows.

While the immediate crisis has been contained, experts caution that LNG facilities are highly sensitive and even minor incidents can lead to prolonged shutdowns. The attack underscores the vulnerability of critical energy infrastructure amid intensifying geopolitical tensions.

With energy assets increasingly being targeted, the conflict is entering a phase where economic lifelines are at risk. For India, the implications are significant, given its reliance on imported energy and exposure to Gulf supply chains.

President links Ram Temple to India's rise

She added that the country's resurgence spans economic, social, political and cultural spheres.

The President also underlined the importance of environmental protection and wildlife welfare alongside social inclusion and economic justice, and called for adherence to the ideals of Ram Rajya. "The guiding maxim, 'Ramo Vighrahan Dharma,' reminds us that only by aligning our personal and collective lives with the broader principles of Dharma can we truly offer sincere devotion," she said.

Extending festive greetings, Murmu said, "I extend my heartfelt greetings to all Indians and Ram devotees living in India and abroad for the New Year... I extend my greetings to everyone on Ram Navami in advance."

Over 2,000 cases filed as UCO Bank tries...

Other defaulters include Rabirun Vinimay (₹1,350 crore), AMW Motors (₹1,009 crore), Vandana Vidyut (₹1,009 crore) and Monnet Power (₹1,000 crore). Other defaulters ranging between ₹600-₹1,000 crore are GVK Power, Mumbai based companies Sunil Hitech Engineers, Jyoti Structures-Mumbai, Fair Deal Supplies Ltd limited by industrialist AC Muthiah, Hyderabad based Sujana Towers, Jhabua Power, Gammon India. Hyderabad based companies Anrak Aluminum, Konaseem Gas Power, former TDP MP Rayapati Sambasiva Rao owned Transtroy India, Indu Projects, Icom Tele Limited — ₹ 621 crore — and Congress leader Kamal Nath's family controlled Moser Baer India ₹5,06 crore.

Interestingly, fugitives Mehul Choksi and Nirav Modi owned Gitanjali Exports (₹184 crore) and Venugopal Dhoot and former Shiv Sena MP Raigopal Dhoot headed Videocon Industries (₹155 crore) has shown mercy to UCO bank by taking relatively small loans, while plundering other PSU Banks in 10,000 of crores.

India must become global hub for drone making: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Underlining the important role played by drone and anti-drone technology in the ongoing Iran-Israel and Russia-Ukraine conflicts, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday said India must develop a robust ecosystem for drone manufacturing. Making this assertion in his address at the National Defence Industries Conclave, he also said: "For India's defence preparedness and strategic autonomy, it is essential that India becomes fully self-reliant in drone manufacturing."

"As the entire world watches the ongoing conflict involving Russia and Ukraine, along with Iran-Israel, we can clearly see the extremely significant role of drones

and counter-drone technologies in future warfare," Rajnath Singh said.

"Today, there is a need to build such a drone manufacturing ecosystem in India in which we are completely self-reliant," he said.

The conclave was attended by top executives of leading domestic defence manufacturing firms as well as officials of defence public sector undertakings.

The defence minister also touched upon the growing significance of artificial intelligence, robotics and other new and critical technologies.

"In today's era, innovations such as automation, artificial intelligence and robotics are transforming manufacturing across the world. Alongside these, simulation technology is also opening up new possibilities," he said.



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh visiting a stall during the National Defence Industries Conclave (NDIC 2026) at Manekshaw Centre in New Delhi

Rajnath Singh also called upon industry leaders to focus on improving the quality of their products. "This self-reliance is necessary not only at the product level but also at the component level. That

many critical components are imported from a specific country," the defence minister added.

"India must work in a mission mode to emerge as a global hub of indigenous drone manufacturing in the next few years," he said while stressing self-reliance in view of the present geopolitical uncertainties.

Rajnath Singh added that while the creation of any nation's defence industrial ecosystem relies on the contributions of large industries, MSMEs, start-ups, and innovators, it is equally driven by a clear policy push from the Government, tailored to meet the country's specific defence requirements.

Rajnath Singh emphasised that MSMEs are today actively engaged in fields such as Artificial Intelligence,

Robotics, Automation, and Advanced Manufacturing, representing a monumental and positive transformation.

He termed it as imperative for the MSMEs and start-ups to embrace and integrate these technologies to ensure the optimal utilisation of their resources and capabilities. The defence minister also said 'integration' is another crucial concept for the enhancement of MSME capabilities.

Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan, Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi, Chief of the Army Staff General Upendra Dwivedi, Defence Secretary a Rajesh Kumar Singh, Secretary, Department of Defence R&D and Chairman, DRDO Dr Samir V Kamat and other senior officials were present on the occasion.

Nuclear plants generated 56,681 MU of power in 2024-25: Jitendra Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Total energy generation from India's nuclear power plants was 45,855 million units (MU) in 2022-23; 47,971 MU in 2023-24; and 56,681 MU in 2024-25, Union Minister Jitendra Singh said on Thursday. In a written reply in the Rajya Sabha, the minister said the country currently has an installed nuclear power capacity of 8,780 Mega Watts (MW) from 24 nuclear power plants, excluding the Rajasthan Atomic Power Station-Unit 1.

Eighteen nuclear power reactors with a total capacity of 13,600 MW are to be implemented. This consists of 10 nuclear reactors that are under construction (including

a 500 MW Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor or PFBR) and eight reactors under pre-project activities.

"Bharatiya Nabhi kiya Vidyut Nigam Limited is currently commissioning a 500 MW PFBR project at Kalpakkam in Tamil Nadu. The Government has accorded approval to carry out pre-project activities for the 2x500 MW twin unit of fast breeder reactor 1 and 2 project at Kalpakkam," Singh said.

PM invites global investors to India's power sector

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday invited global investors to invest in the power sector, urging them to "make, invest, innovate, and scale" in India.

In a written message read out by Union Power Secretary Pankaj Agarwal at the Bharat Electricity Summit 2026, Modi said India stands at a defining moment in its energy journey as the world's fastest-growing major economy.

"I invite the global community to make in India, innovate in India, invest in India, and scale with India. I'm confident this summit will catalyse meaningful dialogue and enduring partnerships to power India's

growth," Modi said.

Modi said the summit aims to bring the whole power and energy ecosystem onto a single platform to exchange ideas, foster collaboration, and chart a shared path to power growth and improve life.

"It reflects our collective resolve of electrifying growth and bringing sustainability,

progress is a testimony to this commitment. Over 50 per cent non-fossil fuel capacity has already been achieved, with a clear pathway to 500 gigawatt by 2030, he noted.

Initiatives like one sun, one world, one grid underscore our vision for global cooperation, he pointed out.

India is evolving into a reliable energy partner in building resilient supply chains, advancing battery manufacturing, creating green jobs, and enabling investments through bold reforms, Modi added.

The SHANTI Act 2025 opens new frontiers in nuclear energy, while PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana is driving distributed generation and ensuring reliable energy and sustainable consumption, he noted.

Panel lauds IAF and Army for role in Operation Sindoor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Sindoor, emergency procurement provisions were accorded in 2025 for capital and revenue procurement to further enhance the capability for development.

"The Committee are also happy to know that emergency procurements are being utilised for acquiring drones, counter-drones, weapon systems, precision ammunition, electronic warfare and surveillance systems," it says.

The report is titled — Demands for Grants of the Ministry of Defence for the year 2026-27 on Army, Air Force, Navy, Joint Staff, Ex-Servicemen Contributory Health Scheme and Director General of Armed Forces Medical Services.

The panel praised the Indian Army's "decisive role" in safeguarding national security during Operation Sindoor last year, and emphasised the need for sustained investment in defence preparedness.

It urged that future budgets should "prioritise induction of State-of-the-art



weapon systems and the development of requisite infrastructure", so that the Army's hallmark swiftness and coordinated response to diverse security scenarios can be maintained and further strengthened.

The panel also praised the Indian Air Force for its "commendable role during Operation Sindoor. By executing precision strikes with advanced aerial platforms and integrating indigenous technologies, the Air Force demonstrated exceptional professionalism and operational readiness".

Its swift deployment, accurate targeting, and seamless

coordination with ground forces ensured the success of the mission, "significantly degrading hostile infrastructure," it added.

The Committee emphasised upon the defence ministry that such capabilities underscore the importance of continued investment in modern air power to maintain India's strategic edge and safeguard national security. It urges the ministry to make all necessary efforts for providing adequate financial support for acquiring the latest advanced aircraft, weapons and equipment required to meet the challenges of the present geopolitical scenario

so that preparedness and combat capability of the air force are "enhanced to a significant level".

In the report, the panel also noted that with a view to fast track the process of theaterisation, a dedicated team of officers from all three Services has been formed under the Chief of Integrated Staff to the Chairman Chiefs of Staff Committee (CISC).

The Committee also note that three Joint Staff Officers undertake a study of global military organisations as well as organise discussions among the three Services to streamline the process of reorganisation.

The Joint Staff has been able to take forward the process of theaterisation to an "advanced stage," it said.

The Committee said it is happy to note that all three Services are working towards one common goal and enhancing their integration through pursuits in the common operational planning process, technology development, harmonising

intelligence surveillance and reconnaissance resources, aggregating remotely piloted assets, joint standard operating procedures and formulation of joint military civil fusion doctrine.

In a separate report, 'Review of Sainik Schools, Rashtriya Indian Military College (RIMC) and Rashtriya Military Schools', also presented in Parliament on Wednesday, the panel flagged that the average dropout rate during the last five years in the Sainik Schools, Rashtriya Military School and Rashtriya Indian Military College is 6.93 per cent, 6.96 per cent and 7.1 per cent, respectively.

The Committee said it feels that the seats which fall vacant after the cadets leave these institutions midway remain vacant until the next entrance examination is held.

"This has a rippling effect, as on one side, the precious resources of the Government go to waste due to idling of seats, on the other side, it curtails the opportunities of candidates who intend to join the NDA course.

States Focus



BJP names candidates for 5 Assembly bypolls in 4 States

The BJP on Thursday announced names of its candidates for bypolls to five Assembly seats in Goa, Karnataka, Nagaland and Tripura scheduled to be held on April 9. The party has fielded Ritesh Ravi Naik from the Ponda seat in Goa, Daochier I Imchen from the Koridang seat in Nagaland and Jahar Chakraborti from the Dharmanagar seat in Tripura.

Veerabhadrayya Charantimath will contest from the Bagalkot seat, and Srinivas T Dasakariyappa will join the fray from Davanagere South seat in Karnataka, according to the list released by the BJP.



PM Modi greets people on Navratri, various festivals

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday greeted people on the start of Navratri and also the traditional Indian new year, which is celebrated in the form of various festivals across India.

Extending greetings for Nav Samvatsar, Navratri, Gudi Padwa, Ugadi, Cheti Chand, Navreh and Sajibu Cheiraoba, the prime minister said the festivals mark the arrival of a new year, bringing with it a sense of renewal, hope and fresh possibilities. "Greetings to everyone on the very special occasion of Nav Samvatsar. May everyone be blessed with infinite happiness, success and good health," he said in a message.

11 Naxalites with ₹68 lakh bounty surrender in Maharashtra

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gadchiroli



Eleven Naxalites including five senior cadres on Thursday surrendered in eastern Maharashtra's Gadchiroli, police said, claiming that the Left Wing Extremism (LWE) has almost come to an end in the district.

The Maoist cadres, which included six women, were carrying a total reward of ₹68 lakh on their heads. They surrendered before police and Central Reserve Police Force officials, said a release from Gadchiroli Police.

As many as 123 armed Maoists have surrendered in the district, which borders Chhattisgarh, over last one year, police said.

The Naxal movement, once active in all 10 sub-divisions of the district, is now confined only to the border areas of Bhamragad sub-division, claimed the release.

The cadres who turned themselves in on Thursday were identified as Divisional

Committee Member (DVCM) Soni alias Bali Vatte Mattami (45), Area Committee Secretary Budari alias Rambatti Mattami (40), Sukhlal Koksa (31), Shanti alias Somari Telami (28), Yamunakka alias Rukhmakka Pendam (60), Ganesh Kowasi (21), Minako alias Jamani Mattami (22), Dhanu Velanje Chhattisgarh, over last one year, police said.

The Naxal movement received a major blow last October when Mallojula Venugopal Rao alias Bhupathi along with 61 senior cadres surrendered before Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis in Gadchiroli, the police noted.

73 Rajya Sabha MPs declare criminal cases; 31 billionaires: ADR report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Around 32 per cent of sitting Rajya Sabha MPs have declared criminal cases against themselves, while 14 per cent are billionaires, according to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR).

The report is based on an analysis of affidavits of 229 out of 233 Rajya Sabha MPs. One seat from Jharkhand is currently vacant, while affidavits of three MPs were unavailable. The analysis includes 37 recently elected members.

Of the 229 MPs analysed, 73 (32 per cent) have declared criminal cases, with 36 (16 per cent) of them facing serious charges. One MP has declared a case of murder, four have cases of attempt to murder, and three have cases related to crimes against women.

Party-wise, 27 of 99 BJP MPs, 12 of 28 Congress MPs, four of 13 TMC MPs, and four of 10 AAP MPs have declared criminal cases. Three MPs from CPI(M) and BRS each

have disclosed criminal cases. The report also found 31 MPs (14 per cent) having a net worth of billions of rupees.

Among major parties, six BJP MPs, five Congress MPs, four YSRC MP, two AAP MPs, two BRS MPs, and three NCP MPs have declared assets exceeding "100 crore.

The average assets of a Rajya Sabha MP stand at ₹120.69 crore.

Among major parties, the average assets per MP are ₹28.29 crore for BJP, ₹128.61 crore for Congress, ₹17.70 crore for TMC, and ₹574.09 crore for AAP. Other parties include YSRC (₹522.63

crore), SP (₹399.71 crore), BJD (₹105.63 crore), and DMK (₹11.90 crore).

BRS MP Bandi Partha Saradhi has declared the highest assets at over ₹5,300 crore, followed by AAP's Rajinder Gupta with over ₹5,053 crore, and YSRC's Alla Ayodhya Rami Reddy with over ₹2,577 crore.

On the other end, AAP MP Sant Balbir Singh is the poorest, with assets worth about ₹3 lakh.

He is followed by Maharaja Sanajaoba Leishemba of Manipur with around ₹5 lakh, and TMC's Prakash Chik Baraik with approximately ₹9 lakh.

NIA gets custody of 7 amid security alert

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The arrest of seven foreigners by the NIA has unraveled that intelligence agencies had red-flagged as early as 2024 a noticeable surge in "unusual Western visitors" with no apparent tourism purpose moving through a region already on high alert due to escalating violence across the border.

It has also come to light that 20 suspected mercenaries have allegedly left India undetected after crossing in from Myanmar.

The rather unusual presence of foreigners in the last few years is now firming up into a pattern indicating a much larger picture with the latest arrests, sources said here on Thursday.

Investigators also point to a suspected foreign mercenary network with links with insurgent activity inside Myanmar. The NIA, is now probing what sources describe as a suspected foreign mercenary network with links to insurgent activity inside Myanmar. Officials also stated that two US nationals linked to Kuki-Chin

networks — a broad ethnolinguistic and militant connection spanning Northeast India (Manipur/Mizoram), Myanmar's Chin State and the Chittagong Hill Tracts (CHT) of Bangladesh — are separately under scanner. The agencies are tracking an alleged funding trail linking VanDyke, the American national in custody, to a network suspected of diverting charitable donations to finance rebel activities along the India-Myanmar border.

Investigators said they have sent mobile phones of seven arrested foreigners, including a self-styled US mercenary, for data extraction to unearth a larger conspiracy of using Indian ethnic

groups to hamper national security. Besides, social media accounts of the accused, six of them Ukrainian nationals, are also being scanned to find out source of funding, mastermind of the conspiracy and their unknown accomplices, sources said.

According to an FIR filed by the NIA, 14 Ukrainians had entered India on tourist visa on separate dates and flew to Guwahati (Assam) and then to Mizoram without requisite Restricted Area Permit (RAP)/ Protected Area Permit (PAP).

The group then entered Myanmar "illegally" to conduct a pre-scheduled training for Myanmar-based Ethnic Armed Groups (EAGs),

known to support terrorist organisations operating in India in the domain of drone warfare and jamming technology, it said.

"These EAGs are also known to be supporting some proscribed Indian insurgent groups by way of supplying weapons and other terrorist hardware and training them, thus affecting national security and interest of India," the FIR stated.

The seven arrested include Matthew Aaron VanDyke, a US citizen and international security analyst, who was detained at Kolkata airport. He is the founder of 'Sons of Liberty International (SOLI)' and a self-described veteran of the 'Libyan Revolution'.

Six Ukrainian nationals, identified as Hurba Petro, Slyviak Taras, Ivan Sukmanovskiy, Stefankiv Marian, Honcharuk Maksim, and Kaminskyi Viktor, were first detained from Delhi and Lucknow airports. All of them have been charged for engaging in unlawful activities for allegedly helping armed militia in Myanmar, which work closely with anti-India insurgent groups, the officials said.

VanDyke's organisation

SOLI provides free security consulting, training, supplies, and other services to vulnerable populations to enable them to defend themselves against terrorists and insurgents. It is said to have facilitated "missions" in Ukraine, Venezuela, the Philippines and Iraq.

Through 'Operation Nineveh Rising', SOLI aided deployment of teams of US military veterans to train hundreds of Assyrians (ethnic community) to defeat terror outfit Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS) on the battlefield, according to its website.

Security agencies have now sent seized mobile phones of these seven accused persons to Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In), a specialised cyber security agency, for data extraction and its analysis, the officials said quoting the FIR.

"It is very important to analyse the data of their mobile phones to unearth the conspiracy which was being hatched by accused persons to use local ethnic groups of India to hamper national security of India," the FIR said.



States Focus



BENGAL POLLS: BJP RELEASES 2ND LIST OF 111 CANDIDATES

The tourist resorts of Gulmarg and Sonamarg, along with several areas in the higher reaches of Kashmir, experienced fresh snowfall, while the plains were affected by heavy rains, officials said on Thursday. Gulmarg, located in north Kashmir's Baramulla district, and Sonamarg, in central Kashmir's Ganderbal district, both received fresh snowfall, which was ongoing intermittently until the last reports were received. Officials stated that approximately five to six inches of new snow had accumulated at the Gulmarg resort since the previous day.



NITISH DID NOT PROJECT SAMRAT AS NEW CM: MINISTER

Bihar minister Vijay Kumar Chaudhary rejected suggestions that Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, who is expected to step down soon to enter the Rajya Sabha, has projected his deputy Samrat Choudhary as his successor. Kumar had, during his tour of Jamui district on Wednesday as part of the Samridhi Yatra, pointed towards Samrat Choudhary, a senior BJP leader, and remarked, "He shall be looking after Bihar and the state will make tremendous progress."

CM Siddaramaiah seeks Centre's help over LPG crisis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah has urged the Centre to immediately intervene to address a severe shortage of commercial LPG in Bengaluru, saying the crisis is forcing restaurants and related establishments to shut down and impacting a wide cross-section of the public dependent on the hospitality sector.

In a letter written to Union Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri on Wednesday and shared with the media on Thursday, Siddaramaiah highlighted a sharp mismatch between demand and supply, noting that only a fraction of the required cylinders is being made available.

"As against the demand of 50,000 LPG cylinders from restaurants, hotels, catering establishments and PG accommodations etc., we are able to supply only 1,000 cylinders per day," the Chief Minister said.

He added that the shortage has led to a visible increase in shutting down of establishments due to unavailability of commercial LPG, affecting students, IT professionals, farmers, dairy producers and others reliant on the hospitality ecosystem.

Referring to recent directions from the Ministry prioritising domestic LPG supply, Siddaramaiah said



the State has taken steps to regulate allocation for essential segments in line with the Centre's guidelines, but the situation remains critical.

The CM also flagged the absence of an integrated monitoring system for commercial LPG distribution, in contrast to the existing IT system for domestic gas supply, leading to gaps in transparency and oversight. He further pointed out that Auto LPG, a key fuel for last-mile connectivity in Bengaluru, is also facing similar issues due to the lack of a monitoring mechanism.

Noting that India is expected to receive two LPG tankers soon, Siddaramaiah sought the Union Minister's intervention to ensure adequate allocation to Karnataka, particularly Bengaluru, considering its operational needs and dependency patterns.

CM Naidu unveils population policy with ₹25,000 incentive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Thursday announced a population management policy aimed at boosting the state's population, while emphasising the need to strengthen family systems. Under the policy, the Government will offer financial incentives of ₹25,000 to families having two or three children. The Chief Minister said efforts are being made to revive the joint family system to ensure better care for elders and enhanced social stability.

"Through a population management policy, we are taking steps to increase population again we must strengthen families and values in society," Naidu said while addressing Ugadi celebrations organised by the Government in Vijayawada. According to him, a declining birth rate and ageing

population are emerging as a serious concern globally. The trend has begun to manifest in south India.

The CM said his perspective on family planning has now transitioned into a broader strategy for population management, stressing that larger families are vital to maintaining demographic balance.

"Earlier, I said one child is ideal, two are okay and three are not advisable. Now I am reversing it, one is not enough, two are good and three are even better," he added.

The Chief Minister warned that continued decline in population could lead to a future dominated by machines and automation, reducing human participation in the workforce.

He said that ideally a couple should have 2.1 children to maintain stability, but noted that the rate in the state has dropped to around 1.5, raising concerns over long-term demographic imbalance.



Naidu noted that several countries are already facing the consequences of ageing populations, with fewer young people and increasing pressure on economic and social systems.

He called for returning to value-based living, ensuring support for immediate family members.

Naidu reaffirmed his Government's commitment to providing economic, social and health security to all people, while promoting joint family values and planning

measures to encourage such systems.

He said schemes such as Talli ki Vandanam', which offers ₹15,000 annual financial aid for school going children, will support family growth and social security.

Despite financial constraints, he said the state Government has extended support to the poor with a continued focus on welfare measures.

He said reservoirs currently have a storage level of about 65 per cent and

Chhattisgarh tables bill to curb religious conversions

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Raipur

The Chhattisgarh Government on Thursday tabled a bill in the State Assembly aimed at preventing religious conversions carried out through force, inducement, fraud or misrepresentation. The Opposition Congress, however, raised objections, seeking to hand over the bill to a 'Select Committee' (generally appointed to examine a specific bill or subject) for review, and boycotted the day's proceedings after the Chair rejected their objection.

Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Sharma, who also holds the Home portfolio, tabled the Chhattisgarh Dharm Swatantraya Vidheyak, 2026 (Freedom of Religion Bill, 2026), in the House.

Earlier, when Sharma sought permission from the Chair to present the bill, Leader of Opposition Charan Das Mahant objected.

Mahant said similar laws from 11 States are currently under consideration before the Supreme Court, and, therefore, it should not be taken up in the House hastily.

He suggested that the bill be referred to a Select Committee for wider consultations, including inputs from retired judges of the



Supreme Court and the High Court and legislators from both parties (BJP and Congress).

Mahant cautioned against any move that could deepen social divisions, invoking the principles of constitutional values and tolerance.

The LoP referred to the views of Dr BR Ambedkar, former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee and the teachings of Lord Buddha, who pushed for social justice and uniformity.

"...Atal ji had stated that our greatest strength lies in diversity and tolerance. Therefore, nothing should be done that causes deep divisions within society. Buddha has said that hatred is not dispelled by hatred; hatred is dispelled only by love," he said.

A related amendment passed by the Chhattisgarh Assembly in 2006 was returned by the President in

December last year, Mahant noted, urging the Government to proceed carefully. Responding to the objections, BJP member Ajay Chandrakar said the Opposition appeared confused and asked why it was necessary to refer the bill to a Select Committee.

A similar legislation had been enacted in Madhya Pradesh during Congress rule, he argued, and asked how Mahant could say the bill was divisive.

The Bhawani Shankar Niyogi Commission was constituted during the tenure of Ravi Shankar Shukla (in Madhya Pradesh), who was CM from the Congress party, Chandrakar pointed out.

Deputy CM Sharma maintained there was no stay by the Supreme Court preventing States from enacting such laws.

He cited Article 25 of the Constitution, saying State

Governments are empowered to legislate on matters of public order. The bill was prepared after consultations, he added.

Dharamlal Kaushik, who was presiding over the Chair, rejected the objections and permitted the introduction of the bill.

Following this, Mahant announced that Congress legislators would boycott House proceedings for the day and staged a walkout.

In response, Sharma remarked that it was not a walkout, but an "escape".

The proposed legislation, which seeks to effectively curb conversion from one faith to another through force, allurements, undue influence or false representation, was approved in the State Cabinet last week.

After the Cabinet clearance, Sharma had said the bill expands upon provisions that have existed since 1968 by incorporating newer dimensions of inducement.

He said allurements could take various forms, including digital and economic means, while threats could also be physical or indirect.

A structured legal framework has been designed to ensure that citizens' constitutional freedom is not affected, while preventing situations that could lead to social discord, the deputy CM had said.

Lightning, drowning, snakebites kill 6,578 in Odisha in two years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

Altogether 6,578 people were killed due to lightning, drowning and snakebite in Odisha in the last two financial years, Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Suresh Pujari told the Assembly on Thursday.

In a reply to a question from MLA Chakramani Kanhar, the minister said 3,439 people died in such incidents in the 2023-24 financial year, and 3,139 in 2024-25.

During the two years, 3,860 people drowned in different water bodies, while lightning strikes claimed 600 lives and 2,118 people were killed after being bitten by venomous snakes, he said.

In 2015, the Odisha Government had declared heatwave, lightning, boat capsizing, tornado, heavy rain, drowning, snakebite and fire as state-specific

disasters, providing assistance to victims from the State Disaster Response Fund (SDRF).

In case of deaths due to lightning, drowning and snakebite, the Odisha Government provides ₹4 lakh to the next of kin of each deceased from the SDRF through direct benefit transfer, Pujari said.

During the last two financial years, the Government disbursed a total of ₹263.12 crore as ex gratia to the families of 6,578 deceased people, he said.

More than 200 people drowned in Balasore, Mayurbhanj, Sundargarh, Keonjhar, Ganjam and Cuttack during the period, as per the data provided by the minister in the House.

The majority of snakebite deaths were registered in Balasore, Cuttack, Ganjam, and Keonjhar districts, he said.



Congress-led UDF gains in Keralam ahead of 2026 polls: Survey

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram/New Delhi

Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) appears poised to make significant gains in Keralam, according to a pre-poll survey released ahead of the 2026 Assembly elections, with growing signs of anti-incumbency against the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF).

The survey, conducted by Poll Mantra with a sample size of 26,000 respondents, shows the UDF leading with a 38.2 per cent vote share. The LDF trails at 33.7 per cent, while the BJP-led NDA stands at 20.4 per cent. Around 8 per cent of voters remain undecided, a segment that could play a decisive role in the final outcome.

Within the UDF, VD Satheesan emerges as the most preferred chief

ministerial face with 29.5 per cent support. He is followed closely by AICC General Secretary KC Venugopal at 28.2 per cent and Lok Sabha MP Shashi Tharoor at 23.4 per cent.

In the LDF camp, incumbent Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan leads internal preference with 38.2 per cent support, though facing a strong challenge from former health minister KK Shailaja, who secured 32.5 per cent.

Among political influencers surveyed at both state and national levels, Venugopal leads with 46.8 per cent backing as the most likely chief ministerial face, ahead of Vijayan, who garnered 27.9 per cent support.

The survey highlights Venugopal's cross-demographic appeal. He leads among Christian voters with 33.2 per cent support and among Muslim



voters with 29.5 per cent. Among younger voters aged 18-35, he tops preferences with 33.9 per cent, indicating growing traction among first-time voters.

On national leadership influence, Rahul Gandhi is seen as the most

influential among Kerala voters, with 44.2 per cent support. He is followed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at 19.5 per cent and Vijayan at 16.8 per cent. Venugopal is cited by 12.4 per cent of respondents as a key national influencer.

Snow and Navratri spark tourism surge in Himachal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Shimla

Tourist influx surged in Himachal Pradesh after the snow, with Manali being thronged and devotees making a beeline for shaktipeeths and other shrines on the first day of Navratri on Thursday.

While snow-enthusiasts headed towards Manali and the Atal Tunnel, devotees turned up in hordes at Devi temples wishing for a prosperous year.

People linked to Manali's tourism and allied industries welcomed the sudden spike in hotel occupancy.

In the Manali valley and parts of Lahaul and Spiti, an intermittent snowfall has been on for the past three



A view of snow-covered streets following fresh snowfall at Palchan village in Kullu district on Thursday

PTI

days. Since Wednesday evening, Gondla in Lahaul and Spiti district has received 13 cm of snow, followed by Keylong, Kukumsari, Hansa, and Kalpa in Kinnaur, which

received 12 mm, 11.4 cm, 10 cm, and 0.4 cm of snow.

Vehicles were barred from going beyond the Solang Valley due to snow accumulation. "The snowfall in mid-

March is a boon for the tourism industry as it would last till summer in high altitude areas, attracting tourists," said Roshan Thakur, president of Manali Hoteliers Association.

Gajender Thakur, president of the Federation of Himachal Hotels and Restaurant Association, said he expects hotel occupancy to double to 70 per cent on the weekend.

Chaman Kapoor, another leading stakeholder in the tourism industry, said, "Snowfall and a drop in mercury have proved to be a blessing boon for tourism. Snowfall has also brought cheers to orchardists, who were worried due to inadequate moisture and cooling in the winter."

Manali resident Fateh

Chand said the rain will help crops by replenishing the soil's moisture levels.

The doors of such famous shrines as Brajeshwari Devi and Chamunda Mata in Kangra district, Chintpurni in Una district, Sri Naina Devi in Bilaspur, Baba Balaknath temple in Hamirpur, MaaBalaSundri Temple in Sirmour district, opened before dawn.

As they did, they all resonated with the echoes of hymns and chants.

Hundreds of devotees visited Kali Bari, Tara Devi, Bhimakali, Hatkoti and SankatMochan in Shimla.

Sadan Sharma, the priest at the Brajeshwari Temple, said pilgrims throng the temple throughout the entire nine-day festival from across the north.

CM Bhajanlal flags off 207 new RSRTC buses in Jaipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma on Thursday flagged off 207 new buses of the state road transport corporation from the Ajmer Road bus terminal on the occasion of Rajasthan Day.

The induction of new buses of the Rajasthan State Road Transport Corporation (RSRTC) is expected to strengthen public transport and provide improved travel facilities to commuters, officials said.

Speaking to the media, Sharma extended greetings on Rajasthan Day and the Hindu New Year. He said



various state-level programmes are being organised across the state to mark the occasion.

"The State is progressing rapidly towards realising the vision of a developed India and developed Rajasthan under the leadership of Prime Minister NarendraModi. New mile-

stones of development have been achieved over the past two-and-a-half years," the chief minister said.

Sharma flagged off the buses after performing rituals. The new fleet includes 100 Blue Line Express buses, 79 Starline buses and 28 air-conditioned buses. These buses are equipped with modern safety features and provide comfortable travel options for passengers, the officials said.

During the programme, the chief minister also distributed helmets to 700 women, designating them as road safety ambassadors, and urged them to follow traffic rules.



TRANSGLOBE
ADVISORS

Your Trusted Management Advisory

www.transglobeadvisors.in



Order Order

Rajasthan family court annuls child marriage, advocates eradication of practice



A 21-year-old woman, who was married off at the age of 12, has secured an annulment of her marriage following an order passed by a family court here on Thursday. In its order, the court noted the adverse impact of child marriage on the present and future of children and emphasised the need for societal efforts to eliminate the practice.

The woman, Khushboo (name changed), was married off in 2016 under social pressure in a rural area of Jodhpur district. A few years later, when her in-laws began pressing for 'gauna' (consummation of marriage), she reportedly experienced mental distress.

Around 18 months ago, she moved court seeking annulment of the marriage.

A petition was filed in the family court challenging the validity of marriage, solemnised without her consent when she was merely 12 years of age.

During the proceedings, the petitioner presented age-related documents and other evidence supporting the claim that she was a minor at the time of marriage.

It was also submitted that the person with who she was married off had not attained the legal age of 21.

The respondent, however, argued that the marriage had taken place later when both parties were adults.

After hearing both sides, Presiding Officer Varun Talwar ruled in favour of the petitioner and annulled the marriage.

Following the verdict, Khushboo expressed relief, saying she now intended to focus on her future. "I never accepted this marriage. Now I am free, and will resume my study and stand on my own feet," she said.

Her legal aid said the girl, who had dropped out of school in Class 7, has now resumed her studies, preparing for secondary-level examination from open school.

Gauhati HC appoints fast-track sessions court in Zubeen case

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The Gauhati High Court has appointed an exclusive fast-track sessions court for conducting day-to-day trial proceedings in the Zubeen Garg death case, Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said on Thursday.

Baksa district judge Sharmila Bhuyan will head the fast-track court, formed exactly six months after the popular singer's death in Singapore.

Till the exclusive court becomes operational, the current additional district and sessions court here, hearing the case, will take it up on a daily basis, Sarma said.

"Today marks a significant milestone in our collective pursuit of justice in the Zubeen Garg murder case," Sarma said in a post on X.

"The Hon'ble Chief Justice of the Gauhati High Court has been pleased to nominate Smt. Sharmila Bhuyan, presently serving as District Judge, Baksa, to preside over an exclusive fast-track sessions court for conducting day-to-day trial proceedings in this matter," he added.

The 52-year-old singer died while swimming in the sea on September 19 last year in Singapore, where he had gone to attend the fourth North East India Festival (NEIF).

A Special Investigation Team (SIT) of Assam Police's CID had probed the death and filed its charge sheet before a local court here, naming seven accused.



Zubeen Garg

The State cabinet had last month decided to request the Gauhati High Court for a fast-track court to take forward the hearing.

Sarma said appointment of the fast-track court "will greatly expedite the judicial process and it reinforces our commitment to ensuring timely justice".

"I express my deep appreciation and heartfelt gratitude to Justice Ashutosh Kumar, Honble Chief Justice, Gauhati High Court for accepting our request and for his unwavering support in strengthening the cause of justice," the CM added.

Speaking to reporters later, Sarma said he received the chief justice's letter, dated March 16, on Thursday morning.

"The honourable chief justice has asked the state government to provide the logistical support for setting up the exclusive fast-track court. Till the new court becomes operational, the current additional district and sessions court number 3, which is hearing the case, will take it up on a daily



Misuse of IBC by defaulters impacts economy: HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court has deprecated the misuse of provisions of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) by loan defaulters and guarantors to "wear a cloak of immunity" by triggering a moratorium, and said this practice has the tendency to adversely impact the country's economy.

A bench of Justices Manish Pitale and Shreeram Shirsat, in an order passed on Wednesday, said such strategies by loan defaulters frustrate the very objective of the IBC and paralyse the whole process of lawful steps taken by secured creditors, adding that the court cannot remain a mute spectator when misuse of legal provisions demonstrates failure of justice.

The court said it has noticed a "disturbing trend" in which chronic defaulters take resort to the provisions of the IBC to frustrate secured creditors and auction purchasers from proceeding under the provisions of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act. In a number of such matters, it is found that the borrowers/guarantors act as fence sitters and do not



take any steps when secured creditors proceed under the Securitisation Act and till the culmination of the process and auction purchasers come into the picture, the HC said.

At this stage, the borrowers/guarantors initiate collusive proceedings under the IBC, claiming triggering of moratorium before the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), it said. "As a consequence, all steps taken under the Securitisation Act suddenly come to a standstill and such borrowers/guarantors, who are defaulters, wear a cloak of immunity under the

garb of moratorium triggered under the IBC," the court said.

In its judgment, the HC noted that the objective of the IBC was to ensure that insolvency resolution of corporate persons and individuals are undertaken in a time-bound manner for maximisation of value of assets, availability of credit and balance the interest of all stakeholders. "We find that the manner in which the defaulting borrowers and guarantors have been taking recourse to the provisions of the IBC, shows that such strategies are frustrating the very objective of

the IBC, apart from paralysing the whole process of lawful steps taken by secured creditors under the Securitisation Act," the HC said.

Chronic defaulters of loan and financial facilities, when facing the heat of proceedings initiated by secured creditors, scamper to file proceedings under the IBC in a collusive manner so as to claim that moratorium is triggered, the HC said. It added that in such a situation, the creditor or the auction purchaser has to approach the NCLT followed by the NATIONAL Company Law Appellate

British citizenship row: HC peruses record of MHA's 2019 notice to Rahul Gandhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High Court (Lucknow Bench) on Thursday perused the official records produced by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) concerning the notice issued to Congress leader and LoP in Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, in 2019, seeking clarification regarding his nationality. The records were placed before a bench of Justice Rajeev Singh.

The previous order was passed on a petition filed by BJP Worker S Vignesh Shishir, appearing in person, who has challenged a January 28, 2026, order of a Lucknow Magistrate court that refused to direct the registration of an FIR against Gandhi over allegations concerning his British citizenship. In pursuance of the Court's order, Under Secretary Vivek Mishra and Assistant Section Officer Pranav Rai of the MHA's Foreigners' Division Citizenship Wing appeared before the bench with the



complete record related to the notice issued to Rahul on April 29, 2019, by the then Director (Citizenship).

After a perusal of the files, the High Court returned the original records to the Under Secretary. The Court also formally permitted the applicant to implead the Government of India as a party to the case and granted the Government Advocate time to file a reply by the next date of listing.

Union Home Ministry issued show cause notice to Rahul Gandhi on the complaint filed BJP leader Subramanian

Swamy. In his petition, Swamy produced British Company Registry, where Rahul had floated company in London, named as BackOps. In the annual filings of the company, Rahul declared him as British citizen and shown his London address as place of residence. The company was liquidated in 2009.

Swamy approached Delhi High Court for non-action of Union Home Ministry on his complaint. Home Ministry has not informed the status of the inquiry to HC on Rahul's British Citizenship.

SC reserves verdict on 'industry'

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Thursday told the Supreme Court that it is "certainly not anti-labour" and will do everything to protect the interests of workers as a nine-judge Constitution Bench reserved its verdict on the correctness of 1978 ruling that gave expansive interpretation of term "industry".

The Constitution bench led by Chief Justice Surya Kant would decide on the pleas questioning the correctness of the landmark verdict that broadened the term "industry" in the Industrial Disputes Act of 1947 bringing millions of workers under the protective umbrella of the law.

On the third day of the hearing, Attorney General R Venkataramani said, "I have consulted the government. The government is certainly not anti-labour. Labour welfare will be taken care of. We are moving towards a globalised economy and we need to



take a call on how to manage the affairs."

The attorney general, however, sounded an alarm and said that departments like forest should be declared as an industry as such an interpretation will adversely impact various governmental activities.

Besides the CJ, the bench also comprised justices BV Nagarathna, P S Narasimha, Dipankar Datta, Ujjal Bhuyan, Satish Chandra Sharma, Joymalya Bagchi, Alok Aradhe and Vipul M Pancholi.

The judgement, keenly awaited across labour and industrial sectors, is expected to have far-reaching consequences on the rights of

workers and the applicability of labour protection under the now-repealed Industrial Disputes Act, 1947, even as the bench clarified that its ruling will govern pending and existing disputes under the old regime.

On February 21, 1978, a seven-judge bench delivered a verdict on the definition of the term "industry" while deciding the plea of Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board and expanded the definition which brought millions of employees in hospitals, educational institutions, clubs and government welfare departments under the protection of the Industrial Disputes (ID) Act, 1947.

SC stays HC order annulling Vijaypur MLA's election

GIRISH SHARMA ■ Bhopal

In a major political development, the Supreme Court on Thursday granted interim relief to Mukesh Malhotra, allowing him to continue as the Member of the Legislative Assembly from the Vijaypur constituency in Madhya Pradesh, while staying the earlier order of the High Court that had annulled his election.

The relief was granted by a bench comprising Justice JB Pardiwala and Justice KV Viswanathan, which put the High Court's decision on hold and restored Malhotra's position for the time being.

However, the court imposed certain restrictions, barring him from voting in Assembly proceedings, including the upcoming Rajya Sabha elections, and withholding his salary and official allowances until a final decision is reached.

The dispute traces back to the Vijaypur by-election held in



Mukesh Malhotra

November 2024, where Malhotra, contesting on a Congress ticket, defeated BJP candidate Ramniwas Rawat by a margin of over 7,000 votes. The result was subsequently challenged by Rawat before the Gwalior bench of the Madhya Pradesh

High Court on the grounds that Malhotra had allegedly concealed details of criminal cases in his election affidavit.

After hearing the petition, the High Court annulled Malhotra's election and declared Rawat as the elected representative, triggering a fresh political contest over the seat. Challenging this verdict, Malhotra approached the Supreme Court through senior advocate Vivek Tankha, seeking a stay on the order.

Taking note of the submissions, the top court stayed the High Court ruling, observing that the matter requires detailed examination. The interim arrangement allows Malhotra to retain his seat while limiting his legislative privileges, thereby maintaining a balance between judicial scrutiny and representation of the electorate.

Reacting to the development, Malhotra expressed satisfaction with the court's decision, describing it as

a victory for the people of Vijaypur. At the same time, he voiced concern over the suspension of financial entitlements, including development-related funds, stating that it could affect welfare activities in the constituency. He affirmed his commitment to continue raising public issues despite the restrictions.

The Vijaypur seat has emerged as politically significant in recent years, particularly due to its sizeable tribal voter base and shifting political loyalties. Both Malhotra and Rawat have changed party affiliations in the past, making the constituency a key battleground for the major political parties in the State.

The Supreme Court has scheduled the next hearing in the matter for July 23. The final verdict will determine whether Malhotra retains his seat or whether the High Court's earlier ruling is upheld, potentially leading to another political shift in Vijaypur.

Snake venom case: SC quashes FIR, proceedings against Elvish Yadav

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

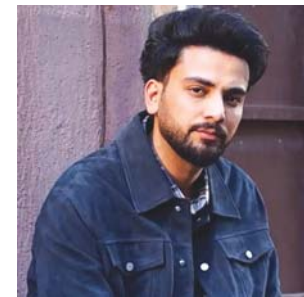
The Supreme Court on Thursday quashed an FIR and subsequent proceedings against YouTuber Elvish Yadav who was arrested for allegedly using snake venom at a rave party in Noida, Uttar Pradesh, in 2023, and said the case cannot be sustained in law.

A bench of Justices MM Sundresh and N Kotiswar Singh said it was confining its consideration to two specific questions — the applicability of Section 2(23) of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1985, and the validity of proceedings under Section 55 of

the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972.

The top court, however, granted liberty to the competent authority to initiate appropriate proceedings in accordance with law by filing a proper complaint under Section 55 of the Wildlife Protection Act. The case against Yadav was registered on November 22, 2023, and he was arrested on March 17, 2024.

The apex court said offences under the Indian Penal Code (IPC) invoked in the FIR against Yadav were based on an earlier FIR registered in Gurugram, in which a closure report has been filed. The bench noted that no recovery had been



Elvish Yadav

made from Yadav himself, with the chargesheet only alleging that he placed orders for snake venom for recreational purposes through his friends, who are co-accused in the case.

It said provisions of the NDPS Act cannot be invoked

as the liquid substance recovered from the co-accused was not a prescribed substance under the schedule.

On the invocation of the Wildlife Protection Act, the top court said Section 55 mandates that prosecution can be initiated only through a complaint filed by a duly authorised officer.

In the case in hand, it noted, the complainant was a former employee of Wildlife Board of India and therefore not an authorised person under the Act to lodge a complaint.

The bench referred to the earlier decisions of the court and said the case against Yadav cannot be sustained in

law. It quashed the FIR and subsequent proceedings, including filing of the chargesheet and cognisance order of the trial court.

The controversial YouTuber had challenged an Allahabad High Court order refusing to quash the chargesheet and the cognisance order of the trial court terming it a serious offence.

On February 18, the top court indicated that it would examine a complaint against Yadav under the Wildlife (Protection) Act in the snake venom case and observed that if popular persons are allowed to use "voiceless victims" like snakes, it could send a "very bad message" to society.

Editor's
TAKE

Oil Shock 2.0: A global energy crisis unfolds

The present oil crisis is a reminder that the global economy still runs on it – and when its flow is disrupted, the shockwaves travel across the globe

With the US and Iran showing resolve to fight a long war, with no side willing to sit at the negotiation table, the chances of a prolonged conflict are high, and so are the chances of an oil crisis 2.0 in the offing. As the war has entered its third week, crude prices have already breached the psychological barrier of USD 100 per barrel. And it is getting worse; with the Strait of Hormuz closed for all practical purposes, and 1,000 oil ships stranded, an oil crisis is inevitable. The world is inching towards an unprecedented oil crisis. To add to it has started attacking oil facilities. Iran's strikes on energy infrastructure in Qatar and Saudi Arabia, along with its choking of the Strait of Hormuz, have pushed global oil markets into a state of acute anxiety. Oil prices are likely to cross USD 120 per barrel in weeks, if not days. What we are witnessing right now is an early stage of a full-blown energy crisis. Any prolonged closure or restriction of the Strait of Hormuz does not merely restrict oil supply - it throws the pricing of oil haywire.

Iran's strikes hit Qatar's Ras Laffan LNG hub – the world's largest – clearly showing Iran's intention to fight a strategic economic war, as it knows it cannot match the US-Israel militarily. This is what oil markets are anxious about and reacting to, pricing not just current disruptions but also the fear of prolonged outages and damaged infrastructure that could take months to restore.

A spiraling price surge will inevitably translate into higher inflation, disrupted logistics, and slower economic growth across continents, but developing countries would be hit the hardest. Europe, already vulnerable on the gas front, faces intensified competition for LNG cargoes. The question naturally arises: why was this not anticipated? Donald Trump, whose foreign policy approach towards Iran was defined more by arrogance and unilateral actions rather than sorting out issues amicably at the negotiation table. He misread Iran's might, and now the world is paying the price.

For India, the crisis is particularly alarming. The country imports nearly 85 per cent of its crude oil, mostly sourced from the West Asia. A sharp and sustained increase in oil prices will widen the current account deficit, weaken the rupee, and fuel domestic inflation. Higher oil prices would reflect in increased prices of eatables and a squeeze on taxpayers, as the government's fiscal calculations, especially around fuel subsidies, would be under considerable strain. But this crisis is also a wake-up call. There is an urgent need to fast-track investments in renewable energy, green hydrogen, and electric mobility to structurally reduce oil dependence over time. On the diplomatic front, India can play a role as a stabilising voice, leveraging its relationships across the Gulf, Iran, and Western powers. Whether this crisis becomes a temporary spike or a prolonged price escalator will depend on when, how and on what terms the war ends. Until then, the world must brace for a bumpy and expensive road ahead.

The writer is the Minister of State for New and Renewable Energy

@shripadyessonaik

@shripadyanaik

The Pioneer

PIC TALK



A woman dressed in traditional attire takes part in a bike procession on the occasion of the 'Gudhi Padwa' festival in Mumbai.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

www.dailypioneer.com

facebook.com/dailypioneer

@TheDailyPioneer

instagram.com/dailypioneer

linkedin.com/in/The Pioneer

RUPEE SLIDES AS DOLLAR STRENGTHENS AND OIL RISES

The rupee hitting a fresh record low of 92.63 against the US dollar reflects mounting external pressures on the Indian economy. A fall of 23 paise in a single session, along with an intra-day low of 92.65, signals sustained weakness driven by foreign institutional investor outflows and a strong dollar.

Elevated crude oil prices, amid intensifying conflict in West Asia, have further dampened market sentiment.

As India is heavily dependent on crude imports, any surge in global oil prices widens the current account deficit and puts additional pressure on the rupee. The combination of capital outflows and rising import bills creates a challenging macroeconomic environment for policymakers.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 92.42 and traded in a narrow range for most of the session before weakening sharply towards the close. Such volatility reflects investor uncertainty and global risk aversion.

There is a need for calibrated policy responses to stabilise the currency. Strengthening foreign exchange reserves, managing inflation, and ensuring investor confidence will be crucial in navigating this phase. Proactive measures can help cushion the economy from prolonged external shocks and maintain financial stability.

Swift policy action is essential to stabilise the rupee and restore market confidence. Ensuring currency stability will be key to safeguarding India's economic resilience.

At the interbank foreign

GUNDU K MANIAM | TAMIL NADU

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Towards sustainable energy transition

By targeting 30 per cent electric vehicle penetration by 2030 and shifting industrial loads to green alternatives, these comprehensive transitions are projected to save India over ₹1 lakh crore in fossil fuel imports cumulatively by the end of this decade



SHRIPAD
YESSO
NAIK

The story of India's power sector is one of unprecedented scale and resilience. Under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India's energy transition has become a steady, institutional effort driven by pragmatic policy design. India is shaping a decisive chapter in global energy history and is emerging as a major player in overall RE generation capacity, showcasing significant growth in its clean energy transition.

Our installed generation capacity has more than doubled since 2014, with our non-fossil share rising to over 51 per cent by October 2025. This enabled us to achieve our Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) target of 50 per cent non-fossil electric capacity nearly five years ahead of schedule.

The pace of this transformation is unparalleled. In FY 2025-26 alone, we added a record 47.3 GW of non-fossil capacity. Our solar journey has surged from a modest 2.8 GW in 2014 to 143.6 GW by February 2026. Backed by 60 GW of signed Power Sale Agreements and bids for 47.2 GW of Battery Energy Storage Systems, this consistent expansion proves our planning frameworks and private sector ecosystems are successfully aligning with long-term national objectives.

In today's volatile global landscape, where geopolitical uncertainties disrupt traditional supply chains, the imperative for Aatmanirbharta (self-reliance) has never been more evident. To insulate our economy, we are aggressively driving electrification-from mobility to heavy industry—to systematically reduce oil import dependency. By targeting 30 per cent electric vehicle penetration by 2030 and shifting industrial loads to green alternatives, these comprehensive transitions are projected to save India over ₹1 lakh crore in fossil fuel imports cumulatively by the end of this decade.

Manufacturing sovereignty is another vital pillar. Under the Approved List of Models and Manufacturers (ALMM) framework, we have already established around 172 GW of domestic solar module manufacturing capacity, with indigenous solar cell production capacity of 27 GW. Yet, guided by 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam' (the world is one family), our transition is not inward-looking. Through platforms like the International Solar Alliance and bilateral frameworks, our clean energy journey is an offering to the world.

Equally central is social inclusion. Building on the success of legacy electrification pro-

grammes, the Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme (RDSS) sanctions INR 6,500 crore to electrify 13.6 lakh vulnerable tribal households, demonstrating the intersection of infrastructure policy with rural development.

Our flagship initiatives empower citizens directly. PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana, aiming for 1 crore households by 2027, has so far enabled 32 lakh households to generate their own electricity through rooftop solar installations. The scheme, in totality, will add 30 GW of capacity and reduce 72 crore tonnes of CO₂ emissions. Similarly, the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Urja Suraksha evam Utthaan Mahabhiyaan (PM-KUSUM) Scheme has transformed agriculture, subsidising solar pumps to reduce diesel use and increase farmer income, bringing over 12 GW of solar capacity to 23 lakh Urjadata farmers.

Furthermore, the National Green Hydrogen Mission (₹19,744 crore outlay) positions India as a global architect of the green hydrogen economy. By 2030, we aim for a 5 MMT production capacity, 125 GW of dedicated RE, and the creation of 6 lakh full-time jobs, ultimately capturing 10 per cent of global demand.

The path forward

This progress has benefited from sustained policy continuity. However, after a decade of record expansion, our focus is deliberately shifting from mere capacity addition to system strength, grid integration, and market reforms. Recent CERC network access amendments introducing dynamic 'solar' and 'non-solar' hours mark a decisive step towards unlocking stranded capacity and easing grid

congestion. To complement this physical grid expansion, we are pioneering modern market mechanisms. Virtual Power Purchase Agreements (VPPAs) will play a pivotal role by decoupling procurement from physical delivery. We are strategically incorporating these instruments under the Electricity (Amendment) Bill and CERC regulations to deepen demand and stimulate private investment without being held back by immediate physical connectivity constraints.

In this context, platforms for global collaboration are essential. The upcoming Bharat Electricity Summit (BES) 2026, scheduled for March 19-22, 2026 at Yashobhoomi (IICC), Dwarka, New Delhi, will bring together policymakers, industry leaders, and financiers to drive this dialogue.

As India's flagship power sector event, BES 2026 will feature over 500 global exhibitors showcasing innovations that shape our sustainable energy future. The Summit's curated agenda reflects our national priorities through strategic panels like 'India's power sector roadmap to 2047', 'Unified power for a new India', and 'Hydrogen, ammonia and green molecules'. Furthermore, special programmes spotlighting Women in Electricity and global partnerships like PRAKRITI 2026 (the 2nd International Conference on Carbon Markets) will accelerate low-carbon growth.

Looking ahead, India's energy pathway remains focused on reliable access, decisive decarbonisation, and inclusive economic participation. The journey is ongoing, and collective engagement at landmark forums like Bharat Electricity Summit 2026 will play a vital role in shaping its next phase.

The writer is the Minister of State for New and Renewable Energy

@shripadyessonaik

@shripadyanaik

The Pioneer

Life is no sugar: A lesson learned over a lifetime



APS
MALHOTRA

2ND OPINION

In 1984-85, I was in my final year of school in Delhi, preparing for the board examinations. Of all the subjects, English was my favourite. The teacher who taught it was a young, charming woman with large Kohl-lined eyes and a mild demeanour. Having done fairly well in English over the years, I had become something of a favourite student of hers.

One morning, she walked into class with unusual solemnity. Beside her stood a well-dressed, gently stooped gentleman with deeply lined features and thick-rimmed spectacles. She informed us that, as she would be proceeding on extended leave-perhaps leaving the school altogether-due to personal reasons, the gentleman would take over our English classes until the board examinations. I remember feeling crestfallen at the mere thought that this might be the last time I would see her, which, sadly, it turned out to be.

On the next day, when our new elderly teacher stepped into the classroom, the atmosphere was far from welcoming. Still attached to our former teacher, many of us boys responded with the kind of mischief adolescents often mistake for wit. There was hooting, whistling, chalk flying across the room, and the occasional drama. With each passing day, the disruptions grew louder and more brazen.

Weeks passed in this uneasy rhythm, and before we quite realised it, the last day of the session arrived. As we gathered our books and prepared to leave, he raised his hand and asked us to remain seated for a moment. His eyes were moist, and when he spoke, his voice was calm but firm.

"Friends," he began, "do not think I was unaware of what you were doing behind my back." He paused briefly before continuing, "In my younger days-as a teacher and later a principal-it would have taken me no time to restore discipline in this class. But with experience, I have come to understand that, at your stage, there are powerful undercurrents of anxiety and stress, camouflaged as brawn and swagger. There is a dichotomy between what you perceive and what the wider world is."

After another pause, he added quietly: "It is only when you step outside that you will understand what I mean."

The writer is an author and a corporate coach

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Crisis threatens energy supply

As tremors from the deepening West Asia conflict ripple across energy markets, it is warned that a prolonged crisis could choke oil supplies and test India's resilience far from the theatre of war. The escalating tensions in the Middle East, particularly disruptions linked to the Strait of Hormuz, could cast a long shadow over Indian fuel availability. India has called for restraint as queues formed at petrol stations, while reassuring that supplies remain stable for now. India currently holds many days of petrol reserves, alongside healthy stocks of diesel and jet fuel.

To maintain transparency, the government must issue twice-weekly updates on fuel availability with immediate effect. India's domestic fuel security remains limited, and authorities are working closely with industry to sharpen data on fuel stocks and shipping flows, ensuring a clearer picture of supply lines in uncertain times.

Even as tankers continue their journey towards India's shores and reserves remain robust, the government is watching the horizon closely, aware that in a world bound by energy interdependence, distant conflicts can swiftly redraw the contours of national security.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Safety lapses cost lives

Apropos the news report "Fires in Delhi, Indore claim 17 lives, including five minors", here is my response. A devastating fire in Delhi killed nine members of a family in a residential-cum-commercial building in the Palam area, as flames spread rapidly due to highly inflammable materials such as perfumes and beauty products.

In desperate rescue attempts, some members jumped from upper floors. Another fire broke out in Indore, where a blaze was triggered by an explosion at an EV charging point outside the house, and there were several LPG cylinders inside, which intensified the fire.

Only a couple of days ago, a fire incident occurred at SCB Medical College and Hospital in Cuttack, Odisha, resulting in several deaths. The incident revived painful memories of earlier hospital fires in Jhansi and Jaipur. Few things are as tragic as going to a hospital to seek healing, only to die in preventable circumstances.

Such tragedies can be avoided through regular third-party audits, upgrading old wiring, and installing proper safety systems. Strict enforcement of fire safety norms and accountability is essential.

BAL GOVIND | NOIDA

Redefining industry is essential

The Supreme Court re-examining the "Definition of Industry" (March 19) is timely. In the 1978 Bangalore Water Supply case, the Court had established a "triple test" rule for an entity to be considered an industry, namely systematic activity, cooperation between employer and employee, and production or distribution of goods and services.

This expansive definition, suited to the then social-ist era, brought hospitals, universities, charitable institutions, and even some government welfare departments under the ambit of "industry", leading to rigid labour laws. This also strengthened the licence-permit-quota raj and encouraged trade unions, whose frequent strikes caused public inconvenience and economic losses.

However, following the liberalisation of the Indian economy in 1991, the time is ripe to revisit this definition and balance worker rights with economic realities.

To become a global manufacturing hub and a preferred destination for investment, India must reduce the compliance burden on businesses. Complex labour regulations, high exit costs, and procedural hurdles discourage investors.

V JAYARAMAN | CHENNAI

Merge state oil firms to absorb price shocks

LPG subsidy may be gradually abolished, and should be provided only on submission of affidavits by family heads about total family income rather than voluntary surrender of LPG subsidy by those having annual family income of ₹10 lakhs. Prices once increased should not be reduced even after reduction in global crude prices

SUBHASH CHANDRA AGRAWAL

Rising prices of oil due to the global price rise of crude oil have necessitated the need for some measures so that the burden of the price rise of crude oil may not result in a price rise of oil and gas, that too without affecting the national economy. This can be done by measures taken for a drastic cut in overheads of oil companies in India.

Merger of public-sector oil companies necessary

Presently, there are many public-sector companies in the country engaged in exploration, refining and marketing/distribution of oil and natural gas, namely Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Limited (ONGC), Indian Oil Corporation Limited (IOCL), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (BPCL), Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited (HPCL), Gas Authority of India Limited (GAIL), Oil India Limited (OIL), apart from some other companies like Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited (CPCL), Numaligarh Refinery Limited (NRL) and Petronet LNG Limited.

It is high time that all these companies may be merged together for a drastic cut in overheads and elimination of unhealthy competition. Merger can be initiated initially on the basis of (a) marketing and distribution (b) exploration and refining.

The policy of pricing petrol, diesel and LPG should be totally overhauled by putting all petroleum products under the GST network to ensure uniform pricing of these in all parts of the country. This should not pose any problem because the GST system has provision for levying cess over the highest GST slab. There may be weekly revision in prices rather than daily, with prices of petrol and diesel rounded to the nearest rupee, and that of LPG cylinders rounded in multiples of rupees 50. In practice, delivery persons never return the balance, which in the suggested manner will become a gain to the exchequer. Oil companies had once decided to replace old iron cylinders with transparent plastic cylinders to check usual incidents of pilferage. But these plastic cylinders are not commonly seen even after so many years of introduction. Iron



NEWS REPORTS INDICATE THAT FURTHER MEGA MERGER OF PUBLIC-SECTOR BANKS IS ON THE CARDS. BUT TILL SUCH A MERGER PLAN IS IMPLEMENTED, BANK CHARGES AND INTEREST RATES (SEPARATELY FOR LOANS AND DEPOSITS) SHOULD BE THE SAME FOR ALL PUBLIC-SECTOR BANKS

The author is a writer, a Guinness World Record holder and an RTI consultant

dailypioneer

@TheDailyPioneer

The Pioneer

cylinders should not be manufactured in future. However, new plastic gas cylinders should be in 5, 10 or 20 kg LPG packing, to be in the true spirit of metric packaging and for lasting long.

LPG subsidy may be gradually abolished, and should be provided only on submission of affidavits by family heads about total family income rather than voluntary surrender of LPG subsidy by those having annual family income of ₹10 lakhs. Prices once increased should not be reduced even after reduction in global crude prices. Such saving should be kept in reserve to avoid future increase in case of further global price rise of crude. Rise in prices of goods and transportation due to increase in fuel price is never reduced with any fall in fuel price.

Merge four public-sector companies engaged in General Insurance on the lines of LIC of India

Likewise, it is high time that four public-sector insurance companies engaged in general insurance may be merged to reduce overheads and unnecessary competition amongst these public-sector companies. Such a merged single public-sector company engaged in general insurance can then ensure vacation of merged nearby branches of the suggested unified public-sector company. Such a step will be in the larger interest of the general public to save them from malpractices present-

ly prevailing in private-sector insurance companies engaged in general insurance. I recall a case when a private-sector company unethically deducted ten per cent from the settled claim amount towards a fire accident because of late submission of a No Objection Certificate (NOC) from the bank. Rather, the private-sector company was at gain by utilising the claim amount for its business due to late lodging of the claim papers. Even the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority (IRDA) did not take any step against the company on lodging the complaint against the said private-sector company. Every branch of all public-sector banks must collaborate with any unit/branch of any public-sector company engaged in general insurance for the benefit of their customers.

Public-sector banks should promote LIC of India rather than private insurance companies

Public-sector Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC of India) was constituted on 01.09.1956 by merging 245 private insurance companies and has done fairly well in the last seven decades of its formation. But gradually, life insurance business is being captured by later constituted private insurance companies, many of which are promoted by private banks. These private banks and their promoted insur-

ance companies always work in alliance to promote their insurance business in addition to banking business.

But unfortunately, several public-sector banks have started collaborating with private insurance companies rather than promoting public-sector LIC of India. It is neither in the interest of the public sector nor in the interest of people, where many private insurance companies offer gimmick schemes to befool people through their agents, paid heavy commission for bringing business by hiding facts of apparently good-looking insurance plans. The Banking Department of the Department of Financial Services (Government of India) should direct all public-sector banks to collaborate only with LIC of India for providing bank customers life insurance services through a wide range of LIC policies. Every branch of all public-sector banks should have collaboration with some nearby unit of LIC of India, which can provide incentives to concerned bank branches to motivate bringing more business to LIC of India.

Merge nearby units of LIC of India for drastic cut in unnecessary expenses. It is observed that even after seven decades of merger of 245 private companies engaged in life insurance, nearby units could not be merged together for a drastic cut in overheads of LIC of India. There are many such cases where a single building has more than one unit of LIC of India, like one such in Daryaganj (Delhi), which has two units of LIC of India. There are also more units of LIC of India in Daryaganj apart from the two in a single building. LIC of India should urgently draw a plan whereby nearby units of LIC of India may be merged into a single unit. On the contrary, there are areas like the big commercial hub in the Chandni Chowk area of Old Delhi where the only unit of LIC of India in the SBI Building is now closed.

LIC of India should search for some suitable premises, preferably a government building, like one lying vacant since its completion near Bhai Mati Dass Chowk in Chandni Chowk, constructed during the redevelopment plan of Chandni Chowk. Healthy competition can be developed by giving appreciation points to branch managers bringing more insurance business in the public sector. This will promote the public sector, save people from gimmick and misleading insurance plans

of private-sector companies, and provide a single-window facility for all banking and insurance needs. Profits of public-sector insurance companies will increase by saving on commission paid to agents which can and should be reduced, especially when insurance agents pay back a heavy portion of their commission to their clients. Payback is as high as 2.5 per cent in the single-premium LIC pension plan Jeevan Akshay.

LIC of India should abolish useless formalities

LIC of India requires all annuitants having Jeevan Akshay policy to submit life certificates after getting these attested from a responsible officer, including a bank branch manager, gazetted officer, registered medical practitioner, postmaster, school or college principal, Class I officer of governments or their undertakings, LIC officer, LIC development officer, or LIC agent, after the annuitant has signed before the attesting authority. LIC of India should abolish this useless formality of a life certificate. Abolition of this formality will in no way harm LIC of India because Jeevan Akshay is simply a pension plan, and it does not make LIC of India pay for the death of the annuitant except returning the investment money to the nominee in case of death of the policyholder. However, such a life certificate may be required in cases where cheques or online remittances are bounced back.

Public-sector IDBI Bank be named as LIC Bank of India

Public-sector IDBI Bank, where LIC of India has acquired major shareholding, should be renamed LIC Bank of India, with facilities of a single-window system for all banking and insurance needs available at each branch.

Welcome reports about further merger of public-sector banks

News reports indicate that further mega merger of public-sector banks is on the cards. But till such a merger plan is implemented, bank charges and interest rates (separately for loans and deposits) should be the same for all public-sector banks. There should be uniformity in different types of forms, which should be simplified with provision to be filled on computer, like passport forms, with subsequent provision for such computer-filled forms to be emailed to banks to avoid errors and reduce man-hours.

The environmental fallout of the US-Iran war

KRIPA NAUTIYAL

The US-Israel-Iran conflict is triggering a slow-moving environmental catastrophe across the Persian Gulf and beyond. With an estimated 21 billion litres of crude oil stranded aboard tankers in the Strait of Hormuz, and a sunken Iranian warship leaking fuel near Sri Lanka's coast, the world may be approaching a marine disaster that no ceasefire can quickly undo.

Much of the global attention since the outbreak of hostilities has focused on oil prices and geopolitical escalation. Far less attention has been paid to the parallel crisis unfolding beneath the surface of the sea - an environmental emergency that could outlast the war itself by decades. For India, a maritime nation whose energy security, fisheries and coastal livelihoods depend heavily on the stability of the Indian Ocean and Gulf waters, the implications are immediate and significant.

Black skies over Tehran

Some of the most striking images of the conflict have been of Tehran's skies turning dark after Israeli strikes on major oil storage facilities at Karaj, Shahrān, Aghdasiyeh and the Tehran refinery. Fires at these installations sent vast plumes of toxic smoke into the atmosphere above a densely populated city of nearly ten million people.

When rain followed shortly afterwards, reports indicated that it carried soot and chemical residues. The science behind this phenomenon is well understood. Burning crude oil releases sulphur dioxide and nitrogen oxides that react with atmospheric moisture to produce sulphuric and nitric acids. The resulting acid rain can contaminate soil, damage crops and pollute groundwater.

Tehran's geography compounds the problem. Surrounded by the Alborz mountains, the city often experiences temperature inversions that trap polluted air close to the ground. Fine soot particles from burning hydrocarbons can penetrate deep into the lungs and bloodstream, posing serious health risks, particularly for children, the elderly and those with respiratory illnesses.

History provides sobering reminders. The oil fires set during the 1991 Gulf War and the burning of Iraq's Qayyarah oil fields during the ISIS conflict left long-lasting environmental damage. Similar consequences may follow if large-scale oil infrastructure continues to be targeted.

The strait of Hormuz: A gathering ecological risk

If the destruction of oil facilities poses a serious atmospheric hazard, the situation at sea may be even more dangerous. The Strait of Hormuz remains the world's most critical maritime energy corridor, through which roughly one-fifth of globally traded oil normally passes each day.

Since hostilities escalated, shipping activity in the strait has been severely disrupted, leaving numerous tankers stranded or waiting in the Persian Gulf. Collectively, these vessels are estimated to be carrying tens of billions of litres of crude oil. The ecological risks are considerable. The Persian Gulf is one of the world's most environmentally fragile seas. Its shallow waters, high temperatures and limited natural circulation mean that oil spills can persist for long periods. Coral reefs, mangrove forests and seagrass beds in the region support marine biodiversity and fisheries that sustain millions of people across the Indian Ocean rim.

Even a single major accident could have devastating consequences. Naval mines, missile strikes or collisions involving large tankers could produce spills on a scale rarely seen in maritime history. The presence of poorly insured "shadow fleet" vessels operating under flags of convenience further complicates the question of liability and environmental clean-up should such an accident occur.

A wreck near India's maritime neighbourhood

The environmental reach of the conflict has already extended into the Indian Ocean region. In early March, the Iranian frigate IRIS Dena sank off the southern coast of Sri Lanka following combat action at sea. The vessel went down rapidly, reportedly killing dozens of crew members.

Satellite imagery soon detected an oil slick spreading from the wreck site. Within days, patches of oil began washing ashore along parts of Sri Lanka's southern coastline, affecting fishing communities near Galle and Hikkaduwa, where livelihoods depend heavily on coastal fisheries. The incident occurred during the sea turtle nesting season, when coastal ecosystems are particularly vulnerable. Although Sri Lankan authorities succeeded in clearing much of the surface slick, the larger threat may lie underwater. Sunken vessels can release trapped fuel slowly for months or even years, creating persistent environmental contamination that is far harder to monitor or contain.

India's maritime environmental response

In confronting such challenges, the Indian Coast Guard remains India's principal maritime environmental responder. Under the National Oil Spill Disaster Contingency Plan, it serves as the

central authority responsible for coordinating oil spill response in Indian waters.

Over the past decade, India has strengthened its pollution response capability through specialised vessels, aircraft surveillance and dedicated response centres located along the coast. The induction of modern pollution control vessels equipped with oil recovery and containment systems has significantly enhanced operational readiness.

The Coast Guard also conducts regular national exercises and international cooperation programmes aimed at improving preparedness for marine pollution incidents. These capabilities are particularly important given the increasing environmental risks in the wider Indian Ocean region.

The way ahead

The unfolding environmental crisis requires urgent international attention even as the conflict continues. Preventing a catastrophic spill in the Strait of Hormuz must be an immediate priority. Maritime authorities should work towards ensuring safe passage for stranded tankers and reducing the risks posed by mines or attacks in crowded shipping lanes.

Independent environmental monitoring is also essential. Satellite surveillance and coordinated reporting mechanisms can help detect spills early and guide response operations.

The wreck of IRIS Dena likewise deserves detailed technical assessment before seasonal monsoon currents disperse contamination across wider areas of the Indian Ocean. Regional cooperation will be critical in addressing such incidents. Finally, the deliberate destruction of oil infrastructure and environmentally sensitive facilities during armed conflict must receive greater scrutiny under international law. Environmental damage caused during war does not respect political boundaries and can affect entire regions for decades.

A sea that remembers

Wars eventually end, but their environmental consequences often linger far longer. Petroleum residues from earlier Gulf conflicts still remain in parts of the region's coastal sediments decades later.

For India, whose maritime interests stretch across the Indian Ocean, the stakes are clear. Protecting marine ecosystems is not merely an environmental concern but a strategic necessity tied to food security, economic stability and regional cooperation. The challenge for the international community is to ensure that when this conflict finally subsides, the seas that connect Asia, the Gulf and the wider world are not left irreparably damaged.

The author is a retired Additional Director General of the Indian Coast Guard

dailypioneer

@kripa_nautiyal

dr-kripa-nautiyal-bb7773219

The insight of the Forest Man

ARJUN BALRAJ MEHTA

The mighty Brahmaputra is the soul of Assam; a mythical land since antiquity where legend and fact often commingled along the sweltering banks of the river and its various tributaries. With over two thousand islands and sandbars, the river is morphodynamically complex, and studies on it are ongoing to this day. Decades ago, on one such remote river island-where shifting sands stretched endlessly under the harsh tropical sun-a quiet revolution took root, one sapling at a time. At the heart of this transformation stands Jadav Payeng, widely known as the "Forest Man of India." For over four decades, Payeng has single-handedly nurtured a barren landscape into a thriving forest, offering those who care to observe a living example of resilience, patience, and the profound impact of individual action.

As the world marks World Rewilding Day today, Payeng's story resonates more deeply than ever. At a time when climate change, deforestation, and biodiversity loss dominate national and global discourse, his work stands as both inspiration and instruction-a reminder that restoration is not only possible, but essential.

Payeng's journey began in 1979, as a young boy living on Majuli, one of the world's largest river islands. After a particularly severe flood, he noticed numerous dead snakes on a barren, uninhabited sandbar. He realised that the scalding sun and the absence of vegetation had made the sandbar uninhabitable for wildlife. While others were resigned to this state of affairs, Payeng was incited to action. With little more than determination, he began planting trees on the barren sandbar.

"I didn't start with a big plan," he recalls. "I just wanted to help nature heal." What followed was not a short-lived effort but a lifelong commitment. Starting with a few bamboo seedlings, Payeng spent day after day, season after season, planting and protecting his ever-growing green oasis, often working in isolation. In the early years, his efforts went unnoticed and, at times, even unappreciated. The harsh climate, lack of resources, and the sheer scale of the task would have discouraged most. But for Payeng, persistence was not a choice-it was a way of life. Over time, the land began to change. What was once a desolate expanse slowly transformed into dense greenery. Today, the forest he created-often referred to as Molai Forest-spans hundreds of hectares and supports a rich ecosystem. Tigers patrol their territory, elephant herds roam freely, rhinos inhabit the grasslands, while deer graze under the canopy and birds fill the air with life.

The rewilding of this tract has not only restored biodiversity but has also helped stabilise the soil and mitigate the effects of erosion in the region. From a barren sandbar to a forested island-because of one man. For Payeng, however, the success of the forest is not measured in hectares or headlines. It is measured in life. "When I see animals return, when I see trees growing strong, I feel happy," he says. "That is enough for me."

His understanding of rewilding is simple yet profound. While the term often appears in scientific and policy discussions, Payeng reduces it to its essence: helping nature regenerate and reclaim its lost territory. "Nature knows how to take care of itself," he explains. "We just need to support it, not destroy it." This philosophy is particularly relevant today, as large-scale environmental solutions often overshadow the role of individuals. Payeng's story challenges that notion. Working alone for decades, he has demonstrated that meaningful change does not always require vast resources or institutional backing. Instead, it requires commitment, patience, and a deep connection to the natural world.

"People think they are too small to make a difference," he says. "But every big forest starts with one tree."

Despite his many plaudits-a grateful nation honoured him with the Padma Shri in 2015-Payeng remains deeply grounded. He continues to live a simple life, tending to his forest and advocating for environmental conservation at the grassroots level. His humility is striking, especially in contrast to the magnitude of his achievement.

He emphasises the importance of local involvement, noting that those who live closest to

nature are often its most effective guardians. For young people, his message is clear. In an age dominated by digital engagement and rapid consumption, he urges a return to the basics-planting trees, conserving resources, and respecting the environment. Looking ahead, Payeng remains committed to his mission. He continues to plant trees and care for the forest that has become his life's work. While he does not speak in terms of legacy, his impact is undeniable-not only in the landscape he has transformed but also in the minds he has inspired.

On World Rewilding Day, as nations discuss strategies to restore the planet, the story of Jadav Payeng serves as a powerful reminder that the seeds of change often lie in the simplest of actions. His journey underscores an enduring truth: even in the face of overwhelming challenges, one person, with unwavering dedication, can make a difference. In a world searching for solutions, the Forest Man's quiet revolution offers hope-not as an abstract ideal, but as a living, growing reality of grassroots conservation led by individuals.

The writer, a wildlife conservationist, is a consultant for sustainable wildlife projects

dailypioneer

@TheDailyPioneer

dailypioneer

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

BLASÉ CAPITAL

H-1B : GAINS vs PAINS

Both the pains and gains of H-1B visas, which allow foreign skilled workers to enter the US are well-documented. We know the pitfalls and benefits, and we can believe in either depending on whether we believe in ‘America First,’ or ‘Economy First.’ However, a recent study figures out the financial gains to the federal and states’ kitty from H-1B households, even as it seems to advocate stricter rules that are, or will be imposed, by the US policy-makers. It calculates how much such families contribute to the public finances on a net basis. The research was conducted by a duo that includes an economist, and a Texas senator, who was a former judge. The overriding conclusion is that the H-1B households contribute “significantly more” to public finances compared to an average American family across states. Thus, it is in America’s interests to keep encouraging immigration inflows.

On an average, an H-1B household adds a net fiscal contribution of just over \$30,000 at the federal level. This is 2.6x higher than the figure for an average American family, which is \$11,500. At the state and local levels, say the researchers, the H-1B contribution is more than \$5,000 per household, and the figure is positive in 49 states in the US. According to a media report, “H-1B households were found to generate positive fiscal balances in almost every state. Even lower-income states, like Mississippi, see substantial gains, with an average net contribution of \$4,600 per household, which is higher than that of 21 other states.” Hene, the fiscal benefits are not limited to the higher-income states. Obviously, the figures should not be compared, or may be comparable because it may be a case of matching apples with oranges.

In the case of H-1Bs, a high-skilled foreign employee with a higher-than-average salary, who logically pays higher taxes, is being compared to an average American family, which includes the poor, who either pay zero or minimal taxes. In addition, the spouse of an H-1B visa holder, is generally educated, can find decent employment if allowed, and earn a higher-than-average salary. The latter may pay higher taxes. A better research approach may be to compare the contributions by H-1Bs may be to compare H-1B families with skilled middle-class American homes, where the collective household salaries are similar, and maybe the tax outgoes too. In the case of India, the comparison in the research may be akin to comparing the salaries of expats who work in India with the average working salaries. It is obvious that the former, if she pays taxes in India, will contribute more than the latter.

What is pertinent is that the two researchers do not use the conclusions related to financial implications with an advocacy to encourage H-1Bs, as is logical to assume. Instead, they contend that the new restrictive changes in the earlier visa regime, and the inclusion of potential policy changes in the future, may further increase the contributions. From March 2026, according to experts, instead of the random lottery system, H-1B applicants will be selected due to salaries. The higher the pay of an applicant the better her chance of getting a visa. “Allowing all H-1B spouses to work, and changing the lottery to a wage-based system could increase the federal tax benefit to over \$65,000 per household, and may raise the average state benefit to more than \$10,500,” stated a media report. In effect, the cumulative will go up from \$35,000 per family to more than \$75,000, or an increase by more than 2x or 100 per cent.

One cannot discount the fact that an increase in visa fee to \$1,00,000, if it remains, and the shift to salary-based entry may reduce the inflows. Firms that routinely apply for the visas, especially Indian software ones, may reduce the dependence on them. This has begun to happen, not over the past few months but over the past 1-2 years. The new changes will further propel the firms not to send employees to the US because wage arbitrage is the biggest incentive for H-1Bs. If the firms need to send higher-paid employees, or senior executives, the economic purpose for them to use the visa regime vanishes or reduces. In addition, the new policies may bring back the illegal and semi-legal practices of the past, when Indian applicants paid money to the brokers and middlemen to get the visas, and hoped that the higher salaries they earned in the US would aid them to save, and make up for the initial expenses. For example, Indian firms may insist that an applicant indirectly cough up the \$1,00,000 visa fee if she wishes to go to the US.

According to media reports, the new research “builds on previous research, and focuses on the 3-6-year period of H-1B visas rather than lifetime contributions.” As the study notes, “Existing research... tends to focus on immigrants’ lifetime contributions. The report, conversely, shows how H-1Bs contribute during their three-to-six-year visa periods.” What the researchers possibly imply is that looking at the shorter span, which is the visa period, enhances the average contribution. Hence, it argues for the new policies, where the possibility to further enhance the financial contributions exist.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | MARCH 20, 2026

BUSINESS

10

Mandate, uncertainty, same rates

Maximum jobs, lower inflation is Fed’s monetary mantra

There are several positives about the American economy, which include higher-than-predicted GDP growth, higher business fixed investments, and stable consumer spending. There are a few doubtful less-than-positive trends, which include low job gains that keep joblessness “little unchanged,” and elevated inflation. Based on a monetary mantra that aims to check prices, and ensure maximum jobs, the US Federal Reserve Board kept the interest rates unchanged. This is contrary to the expectations of President Donald Trump, who has criticised, even threatened, Fed chair, Jerome Powell, for not cutting rates fast enough. The conundrum between executive and regulator continues.

On the jobs front, there are confusing signals. Job gains have happened, but on the lower side. However, the unemployment rate, 4.4 per cent in February 2026, remains almost the same since late last Summer. What explains a contradictory mix of job growth, though low, and little changed joblessness are several factors such as “a decline in the growth of labour force, due to lower immigration, and (lower) labour force participation.” Hence, there are fewer outsiders who seek jobs, and more Americans wish to opt out of jobs.

Immigration numbers are a direct result of Trump’s ‘America First’ policies, which make it more difficult for foreigners to get jobs. One of the foremost examples is in IT, software, and tech, where high visa fees keep inflows in check. New H-1B visa rules will impact the trends more visibly from March 2026 onwards. The reasons why Americans are not interested in jobs may be because of multiple trends. Educated graduates and postgraduates do not find jobs that suit them, either financially or in terms of satisfaction and

skills. In highly-paid segments, firms have slashed jobs at the mid- and higher-levels, and hired people at the lower-levels, or with different skills.

Other indicators on the job front, such as job openings, layoffs, hirings, and nominal wage growth, “show little change in recent months,” according to Powell’s speech after the latest interest rate decision. The unemployment rate, states the Fed Board, will remain at 4.4 per cent by the end of the year (2026), and “edge down thereafter.” Since maximum employment is a part of the twin objectives of the Fed, rate cuts this year may happen possibly once, and the regulator will wait till jobs perk up at the end of this year, or early next year.

Although inflation has “eased significantly from its highs in 2022,” it remains higher than the Fed’s internal target and goal of two per cent. Over the past 12 months till February 2026, prices rose by 2.8 per cent. If one excludes the volatile food and energy categories, the figure was three per cent. With the recent increase in energy costs, as global crude oil prices zoomed from around \$60-65 to more than \$110, the price situation seems challenging, and quite uncertain. Indeed, the trade-related tariffs boosted the price rises in the goods sector.

In a landmark ruling, the Supreme Court deemed the tariffs imposed under the president’s emergency powers illegal. But Trump introduced tariffs of 10 per cent under the trade Act, and wants to impose higher ones under Section 301 investigations that were ordered against 16 nations, including India. These may keep the goods’ prices high, and coupled with energy costs may keep the overall inflation higher than the Fed’s benchmark. Despite the recent fuel added

to the inflation fire, Powell stated, “Most measures of longer-term expectations remain consistent with our 2 per cent inflation goal. The median projection... for... this year is 2.7 per cent, and 2.2 per cent next year...”

However, there are several risks to these estimates, and much will depend on the state of the Iran war. Powell admitted that the “implications of the events in the Middle East for the US economy are uncertain. In the near term, higher energy prices will push up overall inflation, but it is too soon to know the scope and duration of the potential effects on the economy.” Hence, the Fed will wait for the incoming data, monitor the evolving outlook, and analyse the balance of risks before it decides on “extent and timing of additional adjustments.”

During the meeting of the members of the Fed Chair, which was held before the interest rate announcement, the participants “wrote down their individual assessment of an appropriate path of the federal funds rate, under what each participant judges to be the most likely scenario for the economy. The median participant projects that the appropriate level... will be 3.4 per cent at the end of this year, and 3.1 per cent at the end of next year,” said Powell. But these are individual forecasts, subject to uncertainty, and they are “not a Committee plan or decision.” At present, the Fed rate is 3.5 per cent to 3.75 per cent.

Despite the challenges, growth remains high, and seems to expand at a “solid pace.” The Fed expects GDP to grow by 2.4 per cent this year (2026), and 2.3 per cent next year, somewhat stronger than projected in December (2025).” The growth in the past two quarters, and predictions for the future, surprised most experts. The earlier consensus was that growth will dip due to high Trump’s tariffs, which has not happened as consumer spending remains strong. But higher inflation, even if temporary, and lack of jobs, may change this scenario. Neither economics nor monetary policy is, therefore, a “preset course.”

However, Powell refused to use the word ‘stagflation,’ or an era of lower growth and higher inflation, in his speech, or in the answers at a press conference. “I always have to point out that this was a 1970 term, at a time when unemployment was in double figures, and inflation was really high. We actually have unemployment close to longer-run normal, and we have inflation that is one percentage point above that. I would reserve the term stagflation for a much more serious set of circumstances.” Productivity gains may make up for lower growth.

In effect, what one may witness in the US economy over the next few quarters may be higher-than-expected inflation coupled with higher-than-predicted GDP growth. Instead of signs of stagflation, there may be visible trends of a slightly-overheated economy. If this happens, the Fed, instead of lowering rates this year, or possibly the next one, may need to keep them intact, or even raise them once. The world is riddled with ongoing uncertainties and, hence, it is full of possibilities.

A Left-Handed Economist

Cost of wars, the Trump way

More than months, it is about hundreds of billions of dollars

wars. Once he became the president for the second time, he demanded the Nobel Peace Prize for ending several ongoing and long-lasting global wars. Yet, he kidnapped the Venezuelan president, tried hard to annex Greenland, and attacked Iran. In each case, he offered justifiable excuses, which hinted that the actions were in the interests of America, and its people. But the politics of war is influenced by perspectives, and not logic.

Although most Republicans may go with Trump’s \$200 billion demand for the Iran war, they do not seem to have a legislative strategy, or certainty that they can keep the party flock together. There are murmurs of protest within the party against the current war. In addition, the Republicans, according to media reports, need to find a “clear path to surpass the

Senate’s 60-vote rule,” or the number they need to push through the demand for \$200 billion. Based on the reactions, the Pentagon may rejig the figures accordingly.

The Pentagon’s demand will depend on the attitudes of the Democrats, who are “sharply critical” against the Iran war. After a recent classified briefing on the Iran war, Democrat senator Richard Blumenthal said, “I emerge from this meeting as dissatisfied and angry, frankly, as I have from any past briefing in my 15 years. I am left with more questions than answers, especially about the cost of the war.” Another senator added that Trump “cannot explain the reasons that we entered this war, goals we are trying to accomplish, and methods for doing that.”

According to analysts, who depend on the

estimates that the Pentagon gave to the Congress during the first week of the war, America spent \$25 billion on Iran at the time of writing this piece. This includes the \$11.3 billion spent in the first six days, and estimates of a billion dollar a day in the subsequent period. Some analysts contend that these figures, even the Pentagon’s estimate of \$200 billion may be highly understated. According to one of them, “The cost of the war in Iraq ended up being almost \$3 trillion. So, this (Iran) could be astronomical, easily.”

It is evident that the Iraq war was a long war, and included non-war or post-war elements and ingredients. One is not sure if the US will be willing to enter Iran like the way it did in Iraq, or even in Venezuela (which was not a war, really). Some estimates indicate that even if the US does not stay in Iran, but puts boots inside the territory through foot soldiers, a two-month war may cost up to \$100 billion. Seen from this perspective, Pentagon’s demand for \$200 billion may seem fair, if it includes actual costs, and money for replenishments.

Jack Watling, an author of a book on statecraft, admitted in a podcast, “That would be my view, yes, that they (American political leadership) discounted the risk, and they probably overestimated the military’s capacity to deal with this problem quickly. I think there has been a growing trend because of the ability to conduct precision strikes at very, very long ranges for people to overestimate how quickly you can achieve something with military means.” This may imply that the Iran war may go on for longer than expected, and may even last a few months, albeit at a milder and subdued scale with intermittent attacks.

For many analysts, the random retaliation factor creates confusion. In a rational war, one can expect the two sides to inflict and take in less pain, and yet maximise the gains. For example, in the Russia-Ukraine war, as Watling explained, the Russian Navy can blockade Ukraine’s trade. But if Ukraine sinks Russian ships, it will be a huge blow for the enemy’s economy. It is a blow that the Russians “want to avoid.” By attacking locations in the Middle East, and virtually crippling a huge portion of the global oil logistics, Iran has proved this.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

LPG bookings close to normal, but situation worrisome

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Bookings for domestic LPG refills are approaching pre-war normal levels, signalling a gradual return to normalcy, but concerns persist as supply restrictions on commercial consumers, including hotels, remain in place due to ongoing disruptions in input supplies caused by the West Asia conflict.

Over 33 crore domestic LPG consumers had, on average, booked about 55 lakh cylinders daily before the February 28 military strikes by the US and Israel on Iran. The escalation triggered sweeping retaliation from Tehran, effectively shutting the Strait of Hormuz — a critical ship-

ping corridor used by major Gulf producers such as Saudi Arabia, Qatar and the UAE to export crude oil, gas and LPG to key markets including India.

The shutdown of the Strait of Hormuz blocked India's access to almost 60 per cent of its LPG, leading to curtailment of supplies to commercial users and triggering panic buying by domestic users, which peaked to 87.7 lakh on March 13.

Bookings have since fallen to 56-57 lakh on March 18, said Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas.

"Panic booking is coming down," she said, adding that the Government continues to prioritise the supply of avail-



able LPG to domestic households. However, "LPG (supply) situation remains worrisome but there is no dry out at any LPG distributor," she said.

Commercial users are getting just a fifth of their requirement. Sharma said domestic LPG production has increased by over 40 per cent in the last two weeks and the three public sector oil marketing companies have been making normal, pre-war levels of daily deliveries of LPG refills.

"Our supply has not dipped. Some days the supply has been higher (than pre-war times). On March 18, 54.91 lakh LPG cylinders were delivered against a booking of over 56 lakh," she said.

Oil companies are operat-

ing extra shifts to keep LPG deliveries in pace with the bookings. They delivered 62.5 lakh cylinders on March 13 and 60 lakh on March 14 — the peak two days of panic bookings.

LPG supplies are under close monitoring amid the prevailing geopolitical tensions, with no dry-outs reported at distributorships and domestic cylinder deliveries continuing uninterrupted, she said.

Online bookings have risen sharply to 94 per cent, while Delivery Authentication Code (a unique OTP that is sent to registered mobile numbers of actual users to ensure LPG is being delivered to correct customers) coverage has expanded to 83 per cent.

In addition, customers near a city gas network are being encouraged to shift to piped natural gas — a convenient alternative to LPG as the fuel continuously travels through pipes to household kitchens without the botheration of refill bookings. "In the last two weeks, 1.25 lakh new domestic, commercial and industrial connections have been issued," she said.

Raids and inspections to stop black marketing continue with seizure of cylinders as well as FIRs in several states.

The Union Government on March 18 wrote to all state Governments asking them to take all steps to prevent black marketing and hoarding while taking stringent actions against violators.

RBI working to provide avenues to Russian trade counterparts for INR use

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is working on providing more avenues for the usage of Indian rupee (INR) accumulated by the Russian trade counterparts, a senior official said on Thursday.

The Central Bank is looking at avenues to either settle Indian rupees of Russian trade counterparts lying in India for imports or for making capital investments in India, he added.

"We are working on providing various avenues for using the INR, which is accumulated here by the Russian counterparts, to use it either for settling their imports or making capital investments in India, so on and so forth," N Senthil Kumar, chief general manager in RBI's Foreign Exchange



Department, said at the Russia-India forum in Mumbai.

For the past few years, both countries have focused on local currencies to settle bilateral trade and reduce reliance on the US Dollar. Last year, the RBI was allowed to invest surplus balances in Government securities.

Kumar noted an "inertia" among stakeholders in trans-

acting in local currencies and added that this needs to be overcome. "There should be some amount of trust which should come for exporters or importers to use local currencies, which will help in increasing the level of transactions which happen in INR," Kumar added.

Additionally, he nudged for an increase in INR-Rouble transactions.

CDSCO pushes dossier-based drug licencing system

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) has issued comprehensive guidelines outlining a dossier-based approach for issuance and renewal of drug manufacturing licences, aimed at ensuring uniform product licencing and quality standards.

The document, released last month, seeks to streamline the application process for manufacturers by introducing a structured checklist covering administrative and technical requirements. It applies to pharmaceutical manufacturers but excludes AYUSH drugs, cosmetics and medical devices.

According to the guidance document, dossier-based licensing enables regulators to undertake a "structured and comprehensive evaluation" of applications, including test reports, certificates and supporting documents, rather than relying on individual assessments.

"The dossier based approval process promotes transparency and ensures fairness in the decision



making process. The dossier based approach is more efficient than the individual evaluation as it streamlines the process and reduces the need for redundant assessment," the document said, adding that this approach is helpful when objective and consistent evaluation is necessary.

The initiative follows deliberations at the 61st meeting of the Drugs Consultative Committee, where con-

cerns over quality, safety and efficacy of drugs, as well as the need for uniform implementation of regulatory provisions, were raised.

The committee recommended implementation of the dossier/document-based licensing system for drugs across the country, stressing the need for nationwide adoption of a standardised checklist for licensing.

The guidance document divides

submission requirements into two parts — part A covering firm and facility-related details such as site plans, staff qualifications and regulatory approvals, and part B focusing on product-specific data including stability studies, process validation and bioequivalence reports.

Officials said the checklist is designed to bring "credibility and predictability" to the regulatory system and assist both applicants and state licensing authorities in ensuring compliance with the Drugs and Cosmetics Act and Rules, 1945.

All state regulators have, in principle, agreed to implement the framework to achieve uniformity in documentation and evaluation processes for granting manufacturing licences following discussions in a meeting of drug regulatory authorities on August 29, 2023, at the CDSCO headquarters, the document noted.

CDSCO sources said the move will help address long-standing issues related to drug quality and promote a more robust and transparent regulatory environment in India's pharmaceutical sector.

Oil and natural gas prices soar as Iran attacks Gulf energy facilities

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bangkok

Global oil and natural gas prices soared on Thursday after Iran attacked a key natural gas facility in Qatar that can supply one-fifth of the world's gas as well as two oil refineries in Kuwait.

The attacks added to fears the energy crisis triggered by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz to tanker traffic may be longer and more extensive than feared, with lasting damage to oil and gas production.

Brent crude, the international benchmark, rose to \$116.38 per barrel, up from under \$73 per barrel on the eve of the war.

The European TTF benchmark for natural gas prices

contract, the benchmark for US natural gas, gained 5.1 per cent.

As oil and gas prices spiked, world shares retreated and US futures edged 0.2 per cent lower.

Germany's DAX lost 2.1 per cent to 23,015.40 and the CAC 40 in Paris fell 1.5 per cent to 7,848.88. Britain's FTSE 100 shed 1.7 per cent to 10,134.02.

In Asian share trading, Tokyo's Nikkei 225 fell 3.4 per cent to 53,372.53 as the Bank of Japan opted to keep its benchmark interest rate on hold at 0.75 per cent, citing the war with Iran as one factor.

In its monetary policy statement the BOJ said that "in the wake of increased tension in the Middle East,

CIL taking adequate measures to ensure coal supply to all consumers

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government on Thursday asserted that India's domestic coal production is steadily matching consumer demands, with state-owned Coal India Ltd (CIL) implementing robust measures to secure uninterrupted dry fuel for all sectors, amid escalating tensions in West Asia.

As a proactive step, CIL, which accounts for over 80 per cent of domestic coal output, has planned 29 e-auctions in the current month, offering about 23.56 million tonnes (MT) of coal.

"Out of these 29 auctions, 5 auctions have already been conducted since March 12, 2026, wherein 73.1 lakh tonnes of coal were offered, and 31.96 lakh tonnes of



coal have been booked, indicating adequacy of coal offered in the e-auctions," the coal ministry said in a statement.

In addition to this, CIL has also taken necessary action to ensure coal availability to the small, medium and other consumers through the State Nominated Agencies (SNAs)

route and requested the State Governments to provide the additional coal requirement, which can be met in full to avoid any energy shortages.

The coal offtake of the states through the SNAs is being constantly monitored by the coal behemoth to ensure that uninterrupted supplies are ensured.

Geopolitics impacting Indian auto industry

KUSHAN MITRA
■ Jaipur

In conversation with Ashish Gupta, Brand Director, Škoda Auto India, *The Pioneer* learned that currently supplies of components and parts for the carmaker have not been affected by the ongoing conflict in Arabia and Iran.

"But I'm worried if this situation continues there could well be concerns for all carmakers."

Speaking to *The Pioneer* during the media drive of the refreshed Kushaq, Gupta made clear that he was working closely with his colleagues on the manufacturing side of things.

"Products like the Kushaq and the Kylaq have a very high level of localisation, which insulates us. But every carmaker has global supply chains and eventually there could be delays in parts



coming in, if not to us but to our vendors." Gupta however highlighted that global supply chains also meant that parts could also come from other factories.

Other Indian carmakers have also highlighted that supply chains are under pressure due to the conflict. In fact, exports of cars from

India to Arabia and North Africa have been impacted as well with a recent shipment of Hyundai vehicles to Jebel Ali returning to India.

In case the situation continues to deteriorate many carmakers have said that production could be impacted and airfreight could be a solution.

Govt classifies energy data as national security matter; mandates disclosure across oil, gas chain

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government has classified energy data as a matter of national security, mandating all entities across the oil and gas value chain to furnish detailed operational information.

The Oil Ministry's Petroleum and Natural Gas (Furnishing of Information) Order, 2026 requires refiners, LNG importers, pipeline operators, city gas distributors and petrochemical firms, across both public and private sectors, to regularly (even daily in some cases) report granular data to the ministry's Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC).

The data to be disclosed includes production, imports, stock levels and consumption patterns, with the order overriding existing confidentiality provisions, according to a March 18 gazette notification issued by the ministry.

The move comes amid heightened energy security concerns after the war in the Middle East disrupted its gas



and LPG supplies. India imports about 88 per cent of its crude oil, 50 per cent of natural gas, and 60 per cent of LPG.

Before the war broke out, more than half of the crude oil that India imported came from countries like Saudi Arabia, Iraq and the UAE through the Strait of Hormuz. As much as 85-95 per cent of LPG and 30 per cent of the gas came through the strait.

The war has effectively shut the strait, impacting India's energy supplies.

While the disruption in crude oil has been partially

offset through alternative sources, such as Russia, West Africa, the US and Latin America, gas and LPG supplies to industrial and commercial users have been curtailed because of the deficit in supplies from Gulf nations.

The ministry's order aims to create a centralised, real-time data framework to enable faster response to supply disruptions, prioritisation of critical sectors such as power, fertilisers and household LPG, and more informed procurement decisions.

Officials said the initiative will strengthen India's ability

to monitor supply chains, manage inventories and reduce exposure to geopolitical shocks. Industry players will be required to upgrade data reporting systems to ensure compliance as the regulatory framework tightens. Energy security, officials indicated, will increasingly depend not just on sourcing but on real-time visibility across the supply chain.

The ministry issued the order deriving powers under the Essential Commodities Act OF 1955 that empowers the Central Government to require any person holding in stock, producing, importing, exporting or dealing in any essential commodity to furnish such information relating to production, supply, distribution, stocks or utilisation.

The Central Government, it said, considers it necessary in the public interest to establish a centralised institutional mechanism for the systematic collection, compilation and analysis of such information for effective monitoring of the petroleum and natural gas supply chain.

HDFC Bank shares sink over 5 per cent after chairman quits

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Shares of HDFC Bank dived over 5 per cent on Thursday after Atanu Chakraborty resigned as chairman of the country's second biggest lender, citing ethical concerns.

The blue-chip stock tumbled 5.13 per cent to settle at ₹799.70 on the BSE, trimming some of its sharp early losses. During the day, it tanked 8.41 per cent to ₹772 — its 52-week low.

At the NSE, the stock dropped 5.31 per cent to close at ₹798.20. Intra-day, it dived 8.66 per cent to hit the 52-week low of ₹770.

The company's market valuation eroded by ₹65,946.08 crore to ₹12,30,896.85 crore following the sharp decline in the stock.

In the equity market, the 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 2,496.89 points or 3.26 per cent — its biggest single-



day plunge since June 2024 — to settle at 74,207.24. The 50-share NSE Nifty tumbled 775.65 points or 3.26 per cent to end at 23,002.15.

This is the first time that the part-time chairman of HDFC Bank left mid-way, raising concerns over its functioning.

"Certain happenings and practices within the bank, that I have observed over the last two years are not in congruence with my personal values and ethics. This is the basis of my aforementioned decision," he said in his resignation letter dated March 17.

FROM THE WORLD

CHINA

7 arrested in Hubei province

A Chinese province has launched a crackdown on the fentanyl trade - a contentious issue in US-China relations - arresting seven people and shutting down more than 200 websites in recent months, state media reported on Thursday. The announcement came shortly after US President Donald Trump said he would postpone a highly anticipated trip to China because of the Iran War. Trump has used tariffs to try to pressure China to do more to stem the export of fentanyl precursors - the chemical ingredients that go into the synthetic opioid blamed for tens of thousands of overdose deaths annually in the US.

PAKISTAN

ADB to provide \$10 billion

The Asian Development Bank (ADB) is expected to extend about \$10 billion in financing to Pakistan over the next five years, according to a media report on Thursday. The Manila-based lending agency said the facility was part of its 2026-30 Country Partnership Strategy (CPS2026-30) launched on Wednesday. According to the Dawn newspaper, the bank said that the CPS sets out "a roadmap to support the country's transition to sustainable and inclusive growth through private sector-led development".

PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it known to the general public by this public notice that my client, Sh. Jaideep Mathur S/o Late Dharam Pal R/o 28, Village Kirari, Delhi-110086 is one of the co-owners of the land in the agricultural land of 42 bighas in Kharsa nos. 57/9, 10, 11 & 12 & 57/11, 58/11 & 58/4,5,6 & 7, 15/2 admeasuring approximately 42 bighas (as per Khata Khatouni no.365/350) at Village Karala, Delhi. However, it is learnt that without the division and partition thereof, the other co-owners have been trying to sell-off mortgage/lease-out/paring with possession of the land so as to usurp the share of my client, dupe him as to the detriment to his undivided share. The other co-owners namely 1. Sh. Sudhir Singh S/o Late Sukhbir Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 2. Sh. Yashbir Singh S/o Late Sukhbir Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 3. Sh. Jai Bhagwan S/o Late Sukhbir Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 4. Mrs. Rajabala W/o Late Jasbir Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 5. Sh. Mohit S/o Late Jasbir Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 6. Sh. Rohit S/o Late Jasbir Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 7. Sh. Ankit S/o Late Anuj R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 8. Sh. Neelesh Mathur S/o Late Dharmvir Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 9. Sh. Anil Mathur S/o Late Dharmvir Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 10. Sh. Deepak S/o Late Mahavir Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 11. Sh. Desraj S/o Late Mahavir Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 12. Sh. Pawan S/o Late Rajveer Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 13. Sh. Subhash S/o Late Ranveer Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 14. Sh. Suresh S/o Late Ranveer Singh R/o Village Karala, Panna Satghara, Opposite MS Model School, Delhi-110081, 15. Sh. Pradeep Mathur S/o Late Dharam Pal Singh R/o 113/114, Pocket E-2, Sector-16, Rohini, Delhi-16. Sh. Jasbir S/o Late Rajpal Singh R/o 150, Village Kirari, Suleman Nagar, Delhi-110086; 17. Sh. Yashbir Singh S/o Late Rajpal Singh R/o 150, Village Kirari, Suleman Nagar, Delhi-110086; 18. Sh. Satpal Singh S/o Late Babir Singh R/o 203, Village Kirari, Suleman Nagar, Delhi-110086; 19. Sh. Satish Chander Mathur S/o Sh. Karan Singh R/o 216, Village Kirari, Suleman Nagar, Delhi-110086; 20. Sh. Kulbir Singh S/o Sh. Karan Singh R/o AP-112A, Pitam Pura, Delhi-110034; 21. Sh. Ravinder Singh S/o Sh. Karan Singh R/o 24, Village Kirari, Suleman Nagar, Delhi-110086; 22. Sh. Jitender Singh S/o Sh. Karan Singh R/o 22, Village Kirari, Suleman Nagar, Delhi-110086; 23. Sh. Viorender Singh S/o Sh. Karan Singh R/o 24, Village Kirari, Suleman Nagar, Delhi-110086; 24. Sh. Aadesh Mathur S/o Late Ramesh Chander R/o 24, Village Kirari, Suleman Nagar, Delhi-110086; 25. Sh. Ajay Mathur S/o Late Ramesh Chander R/o 24, Village Kirari, Suleman Nagar, Delhi-110086; 26. Smt. Kamia W/o Late Manmohan Singh R/o 5/552-B, Indira Colony, Near Shiv Mandir, Sonapat, Haryana; 27. Smt. Saroj Jatan R/o Late Ram Kumar Jatan R/o 1201-A, Ramna Apartments, Sector-43, Gurugram, Haryana above and exclusive right to alienate, sell-off, transfer or part with possession of the above-said land without the apportionment thereof with my client.

Take note that any deal between the co-owners and aspirant buyers would be per se illegal, malafide and unauthorized, and my client shall not be responsible for the deal and the accrued consequences.

Advocate Manish Gandhi
Gandhi Associates
Advocates & Legal Consultants
CH. No. X6A, CIVIL WING, TIS HAZARI
COURT, DELHI-110054

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Washington

The Pentagon is seeking USD 200 billion in additional funds for the Iran war, a senior administration official says. The department sent the request to the White House, according to the official, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the private information. It's an extraordinarily high number and comes on top of extra funding the Defence Department already received last year in President Donald Trump's big tax cuts bill. Congress is bracing for a new spending request but it is not clear the White House has transmitted the request for consideration. It is unclear

US Jews grapple with surge in attacks, bitter rifts over Israeli policies

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Washington

For many US Jews, following current events these days can be emotionally tumultuous. Simultaneously, there is widely shared anger at the upsurge of attacks targeting their communities, and deep divisions within those communities over whether to support or oppose various policies and actions by Israel in the conflict-ravaged West Asia. Just last week, there was unified condemnation of the attack by a man who drove his pickup truck into a Detroit-area synagogue where more than 100 children were attending a preschool programme. The driver, who had lost family members during an Israeli airstrike in Lebanon, exchanged gunfire with a guard before killing himself, according to the FBI. "To hold American Jews - let alone children in a preschool - accountable for



Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard, speaking during a House Permanent Select Committee on Intelligence hearing to examine worldwide threats on Capitol Hill in Washington



People looking out from the window of an apartment building that was struck by an Iranian missile in Ramat Gan, Israel

the actions of a foreign government is a dangerous double standard that we don't apply today to any other group," said Rabbi Rick Jacobs, president of the Union for Reform Judaism. "One can be deeply critical of the policies of the State of Israel and still recognise that targeting synagogues or any Jewish institutions with violence is not political protest; it is antisemitism, plain and simple," Jewish author and commentator Peter Beinart

also denounced the attack, just because they share a religion, an ethnic national ancestry, a race."

A debate over displaying pro-Israel signs Beinart added, however, that US synagogues displaying "We stand with Israel" signs should take them down "because those signs make the congregants less safe and because they are immoral". Amy Spitalnick, CEO of the Jewish Council for Public Affairs, has numerous policy differences with Israeli Government, yet said she wouldn't ask that "We stand with Israel" signs be taken down. "We live in a country where people are entitled to their beliefs," she said. "No one should have to risk violence because they're expressing them." It's important, Spitalnick said, for Jews to acknowledge that these interrelated issues are nuanced. "I believe deeply in the need for a Jewish homeland," she said. "And I have fundamental

disagreements with this government, the humanitarian crisis it created in Gaza."

The new funding request was first reported by The Washington Post. Asked about the figure at a press conference Thursday, Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth did not directly confirm the figure, saying it could change. But he said "we're going back to Congress and our folks there to ensure that we're properly funded". "It takes money to kill bad guys," Hegseth said. **Iran's 11 submarines 'are gone': Hegseth** Saying that Iran's "surface fleet is no longer a factor," US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth said that "their submarines - they once had 11 - are gone." The crafts Hegseth ref-

erenced are "midget" submarines designed to work in shallow waters in the Persian Gulf and its narrow mouth, the Strait of Hormuz.

The small vessels are designed to evade sonar as they lay mines and fire torpedoes. Earlier, Hegseth opened Pentagon briefing with remarks about dignified transfer. Hegseth said he told families of service members killed in the Iran war that US forces "will finish this." Hegseth said they told him "through tears, through hugs, through strength and through unbreakable resolve" that they wanted the US military to "finish this." Honour their sacrifice. Do not waver. Do not stop until the job is done." "My response,

along with that of the president, was simple: Of course we will finish this. We will honour their sacrifice," Hegseth said. "Their sacrifice only steels our commitment."

Health of new Iranian leader 'unclear': Gabbard The health of Iranian Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei remains uncertain, Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard told Congress. Testifying before the House Intelligence Committee, Gabbard said his exact condition, as well as the leadership structure in Iran, is not fully known to US intelligence. "It is unclear his status or his involvement. He was injured very severely in one of the Israeli strikes," Gabbard said.

UK police charge two men with spying on for Iran



ASSOCIATED PRESS

London

British police have charged two men with spying on the UK's Jewish community on behalf of Iran. Iranian-British national Nematollah Shahsavani, 40, and 22-year-old Iranian citizen Alireza Farasati have been charged with engaging in conduct likely to assist a foreign intelligence service. Prosecutors said the country charges relate to Iran. Frank Ferguson, head of counterterrorism at the Crown Prosecution Service, said the charge "relates to carrying out activities in the UK such as gathering information and undertaking reconnaissance of targets." Both suspects live in London and are due to make their first court appearance at Westminster Magistrates' Court. The men were arrested March 6. Two other British-Iranian nationals arrested that day as part of the same investigation. The head of Britain's M15 domestic intelligence service, Ken McCallum, said in October that more than 20 "potential lethal Iran-backed plots" had been disrupted in the previous 12 months.

Consensus reached on trade talks with US: China



China on Thursday said "new points of consensus" have been reached in its current trade talks with the US ahead of President Donald Trump's planned visit to Beijing, which was postponed due to the escalating conflict in West Asia. China and the US have agreed to continue making good use of their economic and trade consultation mechanism to strengthen dialogue and communication, China's Commerce Ministry said on Thursday. The ministry's spokesperson, He Yongqian, while responding to a question on the recent China-US economic and trade talks in Paris, said both sides engaged in candid, in-depth and constructive consultations on issues of mutual interest, including tariff arrangements, promoting bilateral trade and investment, and maintaining the existing consensus from earlier consultations. "Some new points of consensus were reached, and both sides agreed to maintain consultations," He said at a media briefing here. The two parties also agreed to explore the establishment of working mechanisms to expand economic and trade cooperation, continue to make good use of the China-US economic and trade consultation mechanism, strengthen dialogue and communication, properly manage differences, and expand practical cooperation.

Japan's PM Takaichi meets with US President Trump

MICHELLE L PRICE /DIDI TANG

Washington

The meeting that Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi will have at the White House on Thursday originally seemed like a prime opportunity to have President Donald Trump's ear before he embarked on a trip to China.

But now, the war in Iran and Trump's unsuccessful call for Japan and other nations to help protect the



Strait of Hormuz means the China trip has been delayed and Takaichi may be likely to get an earful. Trump has repeatedly

complained on camera and online that US allies, including Japan, have rejected his request to help safeguard the critical waterway for

Experts warn Israel's strategy of killing Iran's top leaders could backfire

SAM METZ

Dubai

Israel has killed one senior Iranian leader after another in airstrikes as it seeks to topple the Islamic Republic.

But its past experience of targeting senior militants shows the strategy has limits and can sometimes backfire.

Israel killed Hezbollah leader Hassan Nasrallah. The group still fires rockets. It took out Hamas' top brass. The group still controls half of Gaza and has not laid down arms. As a strategy, targeted killing has rarely been employed against a state. While it may provide tangible achievements that



leaders can brand as victories - especially in wars with no clear endgame - it rarely addresses the underlying grievances that propel conflicts. Jon Alterman, chair of Global Security and Geostrategy at the Centre for Strategic and International Studies, said the impact of targeted

India-US nuclear collaboration has enormous potential: Vinay Kwatra

SAGAR KULKARNI

Washington

The India-US bilateral collaboration in civil nuclear energy has enormous potential, Vinay Kwatra, Indian ambassador to the US, said at an event here attended by senior officials from Washington.

Kwatra made the remarks at an event organised by the Indian Embassy in association with the Nuclear Energy Institute here on Wednesday to celebrate the enactment of the Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India (SHANTI) Act and US-India nuclear energy cooperation. The celebration was attended by James Danly, Deputy Secretary, Department of



Energy and Christopher Yeaw, Assistant Secretary of the Bureau of Arms Control and Non proliferation, Department of State and representatives from the industry.

Pak-Taliban announces 3-day ceasefire

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Islamabad

A key outlawed Pakistani militant group behind numerous gun and bomb attacks announced a three-day ceasefire early Thursday ahead of a key Muslim holiday, hours after Pakistan and Afghanistan also declared a temporary pause to escalating fighting.

No exchanges of fire were reported, marking the first lull since late February, when clashes erupted.

Mohammad Khurasani, a spokesman for the Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan, or TTP, said the ceasefire was intended to allow people to observe Eid al-Fitr, which marks the end of the holy month of



Coffins containing the remains of victims of an airstrike on a drug rehabilitation hospital are laid out before burial in Kabul, Afghanistan

Ramadan. The TTP, which is separate from but allied to the Afghan Taliban, has stepped up attacks inside Pakistan since the Afghan

Taliban returned to power in 2021. The TTP has been designated as a terrorist organisation by the United States and the United Nations.

Pakistan accuses Afghanistan's Taliban Government of sheltering TTP leaders and thousands of members who carry out

cross-border attacks. Kabul denies the charge.

The group said the ceasefire is set to take effect from the first day of Eid, which is expected to begin Friday in Pakistan subject to a sighting of the moon.

Pakistan and Afghanistan announced Wednesday that they plan a temporary pause in fighting until Monday night.

The two sides said the truce was made at the request of Saudi Arabia, Turkiye and Qatar.

The three countries have been mediating efforts to end hostilities since cross-border fighting resumed in February and previously helped broker a ceasefire in October.

Won't tolerate use of Afghan soil terrorism : Asim Munir



SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistan's Chief of Army Staff and Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir on Thursday said the country "would not tolerate the use of Afghan soil for conduct of terrorism against our people". Munir made the comment during an interaction with Ulema of Ahle-Tasheeh (Shiite) community at Rawalpindi, the army said in a statement.

Referring to Operation Ghazab lil Haq (Righteous Fury), he emphasised that "Pakistan will not tolerate use of Afghan soil for conduct of terrorism against our people, and reiterated the resolve to eliminate terrorists and their infrastructure operating against Pakistan."

Pakistan launched the operation on February 26 in response to alleged attacks by the Afghan Taliban forces along the 2,600-km-long border.

Munir further said that Afghan Taliban must prevent the use of Afghan soil for terrorism against Pakistan. (PTI)

Thailand PM to remain in power after Parliament polls



JINTAMAS SAKSORNCHAI
■ Bangkok

Thailand's incumbent Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul won a vote in Parliament on Thursday to remain in office, according to an official tally.

The leader of the Bhumjaithai Party garnered 293 votes, exceeding the required majority of the 498 members who attended the session in the House of Representatives.

Anutin is expected to take office a few days after obtaining a formal appointment from King Maha Vajiralongkorn and the new cabinet is expected to be appointed in the following weeks.

Anutin's Bhumjaithai Party won 191 seats in February's general election, according to official results, and has since built a coalition with several

other parties to form a governing majority. Among those partners is the populist Pheu Thai Party, which placed third with 74 seats. The progressive People's Party, which finished second with 120 seats, has said it will not join the Bhumjaithai-led Government. Party leader Natthaphong Ruengpanyawut received 119 votes after being nominated in what the party said was only a symbolic contest. Anutin and Natthaphong were among the 86 lawmakers who abstained from voting Thursday.

Anutin, 59, became prime minister only in September after serving in the Cabinet of his immediate predecessor, Paetongtarn Shinawatra, who was forced out of office for an ethics violation regarding mishandling relations with Cambodia. (AP)

Thapa tenders resignation as Nepali Congress chief



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kathmandu

Nepali Congress President Gagan Thapa has submitted his resignation from the post after the party's defeat in the recently held general elections, a media report said on Thursday.

The House of Representatives elections held on March 5 elected a 275-member Lower House known as the Pratinidhi Sabha. The Nepali Congress (NC) secured 38 seats in the polls, despite its slogan -- "This time, over 100 seats".

Thapa, 49, who was projected as the NC's prime ministerial candidate, also lost from Dhanusha-4 constituency to Amaresh Singh of the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP). Thapa submitted his resignation to NC Vice President Bishwa Prakash Sharma shortly after a date for the party Central Working Committee meeting was fixed. The Kathmandu Post newspaper reported, adding that the party has not made his resignation public.

"A Central Working Committee meeting has been called for March 20, where the president's resignation will be formally discussed," the report said, quoting a party office-bearer.

"But it is the prerogative of the Central Working Committee to decide whether to accept the resignation," the office-bearer said. Thapa chose to resign to steer the party towards a regular general convention following the party's defeat, the report said.

He had revolted against the party's old generation leadership, leading to a split in the country's oldest and largest party. The Thapa-led group held a Special General Convention from January 11 to 14 in Kathmandu and elected a 166-member executive body with Thapa as president, which was challenged by the Sher Bahadur Deuba-led faction.

Congo, Rwanda agree to de-escalate tensions

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Goma (Congo)

Congolese and Rwandan officials met in the United States and agreed on coordinated steps to de-escalate tensions in eastern Congo, where Government troops are fighting rebels backed by neighbouring Rwanda, according to a joint statement.

The statement issued by the Congolese, Rwandan and US Governments said that Congolese and Rwandan officials met on Tuesday and Wednesday to advance progress in eastern Congo as peace efforts led by the US and partners including Qatar have stalled and violence continued. The mineral-rich



eastern Congo has been battered by decades of unrest as Government forces fight more than 100 armed groups, the most potent the M23 rebel group backed by Rwanda.

The M23 made an unprecedented advance into the region early last year, seizing key cities as they quickly expanded their

presence. US President Donald Trump has emerged as a key peace facilitator as he tried to rally both countries to commit to a permanent ceasefire while at the same time paving way for American companies to gain access to Congo's minerals, which are critical for much of the world's technology from jets to mobile phones. Both Congo and Rwanda in this week's meeting committed to efforts that revolve around the agreement that Trump facilitated between the two presidents last year.

The sides agreed to specific but unnamed measures that will support each other's sovereignty and territorial integrity, the state-

ment said. They also agreed to the "scheduled disengagement of forces as well as the lifting of defensive measures by Rwanda" in defined Congolese territory.

Although neither Rwanda nor M23 have publicly acknowledged the presence of Rwandan troops, UN experts have reported evidence of their involvement.

Rwanda frames its role as defensive measures to protect its territory from Hutu rebels responsible for the 1994 genocide in Rwanda.

The US talks agreed that Congo will make "intensified efforts" to neutralise the Democratic Forces for the Liberation of Rwanda (FDLR), the statement said.

EU leaders slam Hungarian PM Ukraine loan veto

LORNE COOK/SAM MCNEIL
■ Brussels

European Union leaders on Thursday lashed out at Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orban, accusing him of hijacking critical aid for Ukraine and undermining EU decision-making in an effort to win an election at home. In a rare public tirade against a member of their ranks, leaders insisted that Orban must respect the 27-nation bloc's decision in December to fund Ukraine's armed forces and war-ravaged economy for the next two years.

Orban himself had previously approved what is seen as a critical lifeline for war-ravaged Ukraine.



Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orban arriving for a European Union leaders' summit in Brussels, Belgium

"He's using Ukraine as a weapon in his election campaigning, and it's not good. We had a deal, and I think that he betrayed us," Finland Prime Minister Petteri Orpo told reporters as the leaders gathered for a summit in Brussels. Ukraine's economy is in tatters. EU officials believe it must get at least a

sizeable part of the 90-billion-euro (USD 103-billion) loan by the start of May. For that to happen, work must move forward on the EU agreement within two to three weeks.

Orban -- who is seen as Russian President Vladimir Putin's closest ally in Europe and is a strident nationalist

admired by US President Donald Trump -- is trailing in opinion polls ahead of elections on April 12. Part of his election campaign has been to portray Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy as an existential threat to Hungary.

He has alleged that the Ukrainian leader, along with European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, wants to drag Hungary into Russia's war, now in its fifth year. He has claimed that his reelection is the only guarantee of peace and security.

Fellow EU leaders are now taking Orban to task, pulling the rug from under his claims that EU institutions in Brussels are against him.

"I have the impression that this is part of his electoral campaign, but in any case we have to respect the decisions that were taken here," Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever told reporters. "It's unacceptable to decide with the leaders and then after say but I'm not ready to execute what I decided."

Austrian Chancellor Christian Stocker said that "what we decide - and what he has agreed to - must be implemented".

He said that if Orban is using the election as a pretext, then "this is not a valid argument given the situation in Ukraine, the plight of the people in Ukraine, and what we ourselves have decided." (AP)

Belarus leader hosts US envoy for talks, latest step in his effort to improve ties with Washington

YURAS KARMANAU
■ Tallinn (Estonia)

Authoritarian President Alexander Lukashenko on Thursday hosted a US envoy for talks in the Belarus capital of Minsk, the latest step in the isolated leader's effort to improve ties with the West.

Lukashenko met with President Donald Trump's special envoy for Belarus, John Coale, according to the presidential press service. State news agency Belta quoted Lukashenko saying topics on the agenda include restoring the normal functioning of the US Embassy in Minsk, which



Alexander Lukashenko

suspended operations in 2022, the "release of so-called political prisoners," as well as sanctions and other economic issues.

The last time US officials met with Lukashenko, in December, Washington announced easing some of

the sanctions against Belarus, and 123 prisoners were released and sent to Ukraine and Lithuania. Belarus has released hundreds of prisoners since July 2024 in what was widely seen as an effort at a rapprochement with the West.

A close ally of Russia, Minsk has faced Western isolation and sanctions for years. Lukashenko has ruled the nation of 9.5 million with an iron fist for more than three decades, and the country has been sanctioned repeatedly by Western countries - both for its crackdown on human rights and for allowing Moscow to use its territory

in the full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022.

Lukashenko's rule was challenged after a 2020 presidential election that kept him in power, when tens of thousands of people poured into the streets to protest a vote widely seen as rigged. They were the largest demonstrations in Belarus' history, after the country became independent following the 1991 collapse of the Soviet Union.

In an ensuing crackdown, tens of thousands of people were detained, with many beaten by police. Prominent opposition figures either fled the country or were imprisoned. (AP)

Rajapaksa received bribe for planes, Sri Lanka says in court

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Former president Mahinda Rajapaksa was given a bribe of LKR 60 million rupees, Kapila Chandrasena, chief accused in the 2017 Airbus case, told a court in Sri Lanka on Thursday.

Chandrasena, the former CEO of the national carrier between 2011-15, was produced in the magistrate's court here after he was arrested last week in the case.

Rajapaksa was given Sri Lankan rupees (LKR) 20 million each at three different occasions at his country homes in the rural south in 2015 when he was the pres-



Mahinda Rajapaksa

ident, the former airline CEO alleged.

Former Aviation Minister Priyankara Jayaratna during Rajapaksa's time, was also mentioned as having received a share of the bribe, he said.

Chandrasena himself had received a kick back from Airbus and monies had been credited to his wife's account.

Probe of Hong Kong's deadliest fire in decades begins evidence hearings



KANIS LEUNG
■ Hong Kong

An independent committee investigating the cause of Hong Kong's deadliest fire in decades on Thursday heard that a series of failures contributed to the blaze's burning seven buildings and killing 168 people as it opened its first hearing on the evidence. Former residents and relatives of the dead have been waiting for answers since November 2025, when the fire shattered the close-knit community of Wang Fuk Court, which housed thousands of people in the suburban district of Tai Po.

In his opening remarks, the committee's lead lawyer Victor Dawes said the fire is suspected to have started at a platform in a light well outside two low-level units, noting that cigarette butts were found there and on scaffolding.

Dawes said the evidence showed that multiple factors came together to produce the disaster, ranging from fire alarms and hose systems being shut off to the use of non-fire-retardant scaffolding netting and covering windows with foam boards.

Moldovans cut off from water after Russian strike on Ukrainian hydropower plant

STEPHEN MCGRATH/AUREL OBREJA
■ Balti

Tens of thousands of Moldovans have been left without water after a Russian strike on a hydroelectric plant in neighbouring Ukraine resulted in oil polluting a major river that flows through both countries.

Moldovan President Maia Sandu has blamed Russia for the pollution on the Dniester River following an attack on Ukraine's Novodnistrovsk hydropower plant on March 7, saying it's "threatening Moldova's water supply" in the European Union candidate country. The Ukrainian plant

is situated about 15 kilometres upstream from Moldova's northern border with Ukraine and supplies water to about 80 per cent of Moldova's population of about 2.5 million. Moscow has repeatedly targeted Ukraine's civilian infrastructure, such as dams and river ports, since it fully invaded the country in 2022.

"Russia bears full responsibility," Sandu said on Sunday in a post on X.

Moldova declares environmental alert Moldova's environment ministry on Sunday declared an environmental state of alert for 15 days, giving the authorities a legal mechanism to boost technical interventions and impose



People filling containers with drinking water distributed by the emergency services in Balti, Moldova

temporary restrictions on water supplies to several districts.

"We are taking this decision to make sure we prevent any risk to the population's health," it said. "Because of the continuous

wave of pollution with oil products, the risk of the pollution spreading, and the exceedance of contaminant levels in the northern area of the Dniester River."

While oil pollutants have

been confirmed in the river following the strike, the exact source of the pollutant is not yet clear.

The situation has forced the authorities to cut the water supply to several districts, including Moldova's second-largest city of Balti, which has a population of about 90,000 people. As well as humanitarian aid from neighbouring Romania, Moldova's military stepped in this week to distribute drinking water in the northern city from a 10-tonne tanker.

Water shortage impacts residents "It's very hard, very hard," said 84-year-old Balti resident Liuba Istrati, who has been carrying buckets of water up to her apartment.

"We live on the fifth floor, it's just the two of us, old people, my husband is sick in bed."

The water shortage has also forced some schools to close and move learning online. "It's a complicated situation, I have to come every day to get water," said Irina Mutlic, a teacher living in Balti.

"Even for one person you need quite an amount of water to consume, for the bathroom and so on, so it's really complicated."

The authorities are now racing to clean up pollution and analyse and monitor the river water.

Neighbouring Romania, which has close relations with Moldova, has dis-

patched teams and equipment, such as absorbent materials for dams, to aid cleanup efforts.

Tests show improvement in water "The latest samples taken show an improvement in the water indicators, which confirms the effectiveness of the filters and barriers for the capture and disposal of pollutants," the Ministry of Environment said on Wednesday.

The ministry added that the authorities are "working at an accelerated pace" to resume water supplies, "but this decision will be made exclusively on the basis of at least two consecutive sets of analyses, taken on two different days.

PROSPECT

Fit India: Starting with the youth

Amid a growing fitness trend among Indian youth driven by heightened health awareness, social media influence, and aspirations for better living, Fit India Ambassador Narendra Kumar Yadav has stressed that fitness is now essential, not optional. "Fitness is not just about physical health; it also strengthens mental balance, discipline, and a positive mindset," Yadav said. He urged young people to incorporate daily exercise, yoga, or sports into their routines for improved quality of life. Experts attribute the surge to rising wellness consciousness and popular activities like running, gym workouts, and outdoor sports. Yadav advised gradual adoption, balance, and expert guidance. "A healthy and fit youth is the foundation of a strong nation," he concluded.



AccuLaw Source LLP expands to Ghaziabad with third branch



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ghaziabad

Expanding its footprint in the National Capital Region, the Delhi-based law firm AccuLaw Source LLP inaugurated its third branch in Ghaziabad on Sunday. The new associate office aims to provide high-quality legal services and greater accessibility to clients in Ghaziabad and its neighbouring areas.

The inauguration ceremony was attended by the firm's senior management and prominent members of the legal fraternity. Managing Partner Advocate Ajit Sharma and Senior Partner Advocate Pramod Kumar Singh formally opened the premises by lighting the traditional ceremonial lamp.

Established in October 2023 in Delhi's Paschim Vihar, the firm has witnessed rapid growth within a short span. With the launch of the Ghaziabad branch, AccuLaw Source LLP now marks its presence across Delhi, Haryana, and Uttar Pradesh.

The firm specialises in a wide array of legal sectors, including real estate matters involving complex property and land disputes, corporate services providing legal advisory and representation for banks and large entities, and litigation offering solutions for various civil and criminal cases.

Speaking at the event, Managing Partner Ajit Sharma emphasised the firm's commitment to transparency. "Our goal is to deliver justice with complete integrity. Through this new branch, we will be able to serve our corporate and individual clients in Ghaziabad more effectively," he said.

The event saw the participation of Branch Head Sarita, Advocate Aditya Bhardwaj, Advocate Yashasvi, and several associate advocates.

CBI questions Anil Ambani in RCom case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI on Thursday questioned industrialist Anil Ambani for nearly eight hours in connection with a ₹2,929 crore cheating case, registered against Reliance Communications Ltd and him on a complaint by the State Bank of India. The industrialist, who is facing several investigations in CBI cases, has been called again on Friday for questioning, said officials.

Ambani arrived at the agency headquarters at around 10.15 and was taken to the investigation team after the completion of formalities. He left the agency headquarters at around 6.15 in the evening. "In connection with the case registered by CBI on August 21, 2025 against Reliance



Industrialist Anil Ambani leaves the CBI headquarters after questioning in bank fraud case Thursday

Communications Limited in ₹2929.05 crore Bank Fraud case in which Reliance Communications Limited, Anil D Ambani and others unknown including unknown public servants, are accused, the CBI summoned Anil D Ambani for interrogation today at CBI Head Office at Delhi," a CBI

spokesperson said in a statement. "The accused Anil D Ambani appeared before the Investigating Officer today and has been interrogated for about 8 Hours. For further questioning, the accused has been directed to appear before the investigating officer tomorrow as well," the spokesperson said. According to the statement, the agency questioned Ambani about the decision-making process at the company, several emails exchanged between him and executives also came up.

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) also sought his responses on alleged fund diversion, misappropriation and other irregularities in the loan funds issued to the company by the bank, they said.

The CBI had booked Ambani in August last year for allegedly defrauding the SBI to the tune of ₹2,929 crore, officials said. According to the SBI complaint, now part of the FIR, the company had an outstanding of over ₹40,000 crore to various lenders, with the public sector bank alone facing a loss of ₹2,929 crore, according to 2018 figures. The CBI booked Ambani and RCom for allegedly committing offences of criminal conspiracy, cheating and criminal breach of trust.

"It is alleged that the accused persons, in criminal conspiracy, misrepresented and got sanctioned credit facilities from SBI in favour of Reliance Communication Ltd," a CBI spokesperson said in a statement in August last year. CBI also searched the Ambani residence 'Sea Wind' at Cuffe Parade in Mumbai. The complaint filed by SBI pertains to matters dating back more than 10 years, according to Ambani's spokesperson.

CM Bhajan Lal unveils visionary Rajasthan Mandapam project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

On the eve of Rajasthan Diwas celebration, Chief Minister of Rajasthan, Bhajan Lal Sharma in the presence of Col. Rajyavardhan Rathore, Cabinet Minister of Industries & Commerce, IT & C, Youth Affairs & Sports, Skills, Planning & Entrepreneurship and Soldier Welfare, Krishan Kumar Vishnoi, Minister of State, Industry & Commerce Department, Youth Affairs & Sports, Skills, Planning & Entrepreneurship Department and Policy Making, V Srinivas, Chief Secretary, Government of Rajasthan and Shikhar Agrawal, Additional Chief Secretary (ACS) & Chairman, Rajasthan State Industrial Development & Investment Corporation Limited (RIICO), Dr KP Mahadevaswamy, CMD, NBCC and other dignitaries, unveiled the pictorial digital views of Rajasthan Mandapam and allied infrastructure through a video presentation at an event held at Rajasthan International Centre, Jaipur.

The unveiling marked a significant milestone in the state's journey towards build-

ing world-class infrastructure and reinforcing its position as a progressive and investment-ready destination.

The ambitious project, near Jaipur International Airport is expected to come up on more than 90 acre in Jaipur with a total built up area (BuA) of more than 94.53 lakh sq.ft.

The master plan integrates an iconic convention centre (BuA more than 9 lakh sq.ft.), grand expo halls (BuA around 7 lakh sq.ft), Global Capability Centres (GCCs) & IT/ITES Office Spaces (BuA around 18 lakh sq.ft), Hotels, Retail facilities & Housing (BuA more than 10.76 lakh sq.ft), a Natural History Museum (BuA more than 1.77 lakh sq.ft.), Riverfront public spaces, Unity Mall, and Fintech plaza (BuA close to 69 thousand sq.ft), creating a vibrant mixed-use ecosystem combining business, tourism, culture, leisure, and social interaction.

Strong emphasis has been placed on connectivity, sustainability, climate-responsive design, and pedestrian-friendly public realms, ensuring long-term urban resilience and liveability. The entire development will have



provision of ample parking with BuA of around 32.5 lakh sq.ft.

The entire development is being developed by RIICO with NBCC executing the project. NBCC will implement the project through a robust, self-financing model, ensuring financial sustainability while maintaining world class standards of transparency and efficiency.

The total project value has been assessed at more than ₹5,800 crore, reflecting the expanded scale and comprehensive scope of the Rajasthan Mandapam and allied developments.

This positions the project among the most significant urban infrastructure initiatives in the region, with far-

reaching economic and social impact.

Reaffirming its commitment to timely delivery, NBCC plans to float tenders for the project in April, marking the transition from planning to execution. With its proven expertise in delivering landmark infrastructure projects, NBCC will ensure adherence to the highest standards of quality, efficiency and timely completion.

At the heart of this transformative initiative lies the Rajasthan Mandapam Convention Centre, which NBCC will develop as a world-class, multi-scale facility capable of hosting international conventions, exhibitions, cultural performances, and high-level events.

The convention complex will feature multiple auditoria, including the grand Padam Mandap with a seating capacity of approximately 6500 persons, Swarn, Tulsi, and Kadam Mandaps, in addition to banquet halls, summit spaces, meeting rooms, and a state-of-the-art concert arena designed to meet global standards.

Complementing the convention centre is a comprehensive ecosystem of allied infrastructure planned, including expansive expo halls, Global Capability Centres (GCCs), IT/ITES office spaces, fintech plaza, hospitality developments, retail and residential zones, and a Natural History Museum.

Another highlight of the

project is the revitalisation of the Dravayawati riverfront into a vibrant public space, integrating ecological restoration with cultural and recreational activities, reflecting a strong emphasis on sustainability and urban resilience.

The unveiling witnessed an overwhelming response from a distinguished audience comprising leading business leaders, entrepreneurs and representatives from various institutions.

The audience highly appreciated the scale, vision, and transformative potential of the project, while acknowledging the Chief Minister's forward-looking leadership and the rapid progress being achieved in the state. The presentation concluded with a standing ovation, underscoring widespread confidence in the initiative.

The Rajasthan Mandapam and Allied Projects stand as a symbol of modern Rajasthan where visionary leadership meets world-class execution. The project is poised to redefine Jaipur's urban landscape and establish it as a premier global destination for conventions, business, tourism, and cultural exchange.

CISF, AYUSH joins hands for wellness of personnel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a significant step towards strengthening the health, well-being, and operational readiness of its personnel, the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) signed a MoU with the Ministry of AYUSH, Government of India, at CISF Headquarters in the national Capital.

The MoU was signed on behalf of CISF by IG (Administration), Pratibha Agarwal, and on behalf of the Ministry of AYUSH by Dr A Raghu, Adviser (Ayush).

According to a CISF Press Release, the MoU establishes a structured collaboration between CISF and the Ministry of AYUSH to integrate traditional systems of healthcare—including Yoga, Ayurveda, and other Ayush practices—into the daily lives of CISF personnel and their

families. The initiative is designed to address the unique health challenges faced by CISF personnel, who often operate under strenuous and demanding conditions.

From the perspective of CISF personnel, this initiative translates into tangible and practical advantages in daily life and service conditions like regular yoga sessions and wellness programmes; scientific stress management interventions, improved immunity through Ayush-based practices; access to Ayush consultations and therapies such as Panchakarma; awareness campaigns on healthy lifestyle and disease prevention and improved quality of life, fitness, and overall well-being.

The Ministry of AYUSH will provide technical expertise, including standardized well-



ness modules, treatment protocols, and trained manpower. Wellness camps, workshops, and sensitisation programmes will be conducted across CISF units nationwide to ensure wide accessibility and participation.

CISF units will facilitate infrastructure and administrative support for organising health camps and wellness activities, while the Ministry of AYUSH will extend technical support, expertise, and programme design, added the release.

"This MoU marks a historic

beginning for the Force.

In the coming years, our personnel will realise its true value in improving their health and quality of life. Ayurveda, rooted in centuries of knowledge and practice, offers a strong foundation for preventive healthcare and balanced living.

By integrating Ayush systems with modern medicine, we are enabling our personnel to benefit from the best of both worlds—effective treatment as well as long-term wellness and stress management.

A healthy force is a capable force, and this initiative will go a long way in enhancing the well-being, resilience, and operational readiness of CISF," said CISF DG Praveer Ranjan.

Secretary, Ministry of Ayush, Vaidya Rajesh Kotecha said Ayurveda has witnessed significant growth in recent

PALM expo to hit Delhi



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The PALM Expo, a leading trade platform for professional audio, visual, and lighting technologies, will be held in the national capital from January 7 to 9 next year.

The inaugural edition in Delhi will bring together 70-100 curated exhibitors. The premier expo is expected to attract 5,000-7,000 qualified industry professionals, creating a focused, premium business environment for meaningful industry engagement.

The announcement by Informa Markets marks a significant milestone for India's professional audio-visual and lighting industry, bringing the country's most established industry platform closer to one of its fastest-growing regional markets.

The event is a strategic expansion into North India's rapidly growing audio-video ecosystem and is being replicated here following the success of PALM Expo Mumbai this year.

Bihar showcases strong investment potential as 'Focus State' at Bharat Electricity Summit 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Bihar has made a confident and impactful presentation as the 'Focus State' at the Bharat Electricity Summit 2026, underlining its emergence as a credible and attractive destination for energy sector investments. Participating in the global forum

at Yashobhoomi, New Delhi, the state highlighted its achievements, policy direction and future-ready energy ecosystem while engaging actively with investors and industry leaders.

The Bihar pavilion remained a key point of engagement throughout the summit, drawing significant interest from delegates, industry representatives and visitors. Officials from the state's power sector held detailed discussions with stakeholders, exploring opportunities for collaboration and investment.

Several meaningful interactions took place with leading industry players, indicating strong interest in upcoming projects and partnerships.

The summit also witnessed encouraging international engagement, with representatives from various

countries and institutions expressing interest in Bihar's policy framework and progress in the energy sector. These interactions reinforced the state's growing visibility on the global energy investment map.

Bihar's current positioning is rooted in sustained transformation over the past two decades. From a power availability of less than 700 MW in 2005, the state now meets a demand exceeding 8,700 MW. Reliable, near round-the-clock electricity supply has been extended across urban and rural areas, with over 22 million consumers connected to the grid. Universal electrification has enabled new avenues for economic growth and development.

This progress has been supported by significant



Brijendra Prasad Yadav, Minister of Energy, Government of Bihar & Manoj Kumar Singh, IAS, Secretary, Dept of Energy, (Government of Bihar) Cum CMD, Bihar State Power Holding Corporation Limited

infrastructure expansion. Transmission capacity has increased nearly twenty-fold, while the distribution network has expanded more than five times. The number

of grid substations has risen from 45 to 175, alongside a more than tenfold increase in transformers. Together, these developments have strengthened the State's power network, making it capable of supporting industrial growth.

Operational and financial improvements in distribution companies have further reinforced sectoral stability. The utilities have recorded a profit exceeding ₹2,000 crore in FY 2025. AT&C losses have been reduced to levels below the national average, and both DISCOMs have achieved 'A' ratings, reflecting improved efficiency and financial discipline.

Bihar has also made notable progress in digital transformation. More than 8.7 million smart prepaid meters have been installed, improving transparency and revenue realisation. Advanced systems such as ERP platforms, integrated IT dashboards and centralised command centres have enhanced operational effi-

ciency and responsiveness.

Looking ahead, the state has outlined a comprehensive investment plan to upgrade energy infrastructure. An estimated ₹81,000 crore is proposed over the next five years under the TBCB mode. This includes ₹38,950 crore for power generation, ₹16,194 crore for transmission strengthening, and ₹22,951 crore for distribution improvements, along with ₹3,346 crore allocated for maintenance of existing infrastructure.

The state also presented key upcoming projects, Kajra solar power project integrated with BESS, which is one of the largest Battery storage of the country. Under the pumped storage policy, investment proposals worth ₹13,000 crore have already been received within a short span, indicat-

ing growing investor confidence.

Under the Renewable Energy Policy 2025, Bihar has set a target of developing 24 GW of renewable energy capacity and 6.1 GW of energy storage by 2030. Investor-friendly provisions such as transmission charge exemptions, energy banking, single-window clearances and carbon credit mechanisms are expected to further enhance the State's attractiveness as an investment destination.

Bihar's participation at the Bharat Electricity Summit 2026 reflects not only its progress but also its clear strategic direction.

The State is positioning itself as a forward-looking energy hub, committed to driving investment, innovation and sustainable growth in the sector.

PARADIIP PORT AUTHORITY
e-TENDER CALL NOTICE
No:CE/PHD(M)/AC/TS-11/25/89
Dt: 13.03.2026
Name of Work: "Operation and Maintenance (O&M) of 2.00 MLD STP-III in front of maritime academy for two years (2025-27).
Estimated cost: Rs.2,16,04,587.90.
Last Date & time of submission : 05.04.2026 up to 17:30 Hrs.
Refer our website for details: eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app.
Sd/- Executive Engineer, PHD, PPA
PPA/PR/74/2025-2026 dt. 17.03.2026

BRIEFLY

Only two Premier League teams left in Champions League



Premier League teams dominated the first phase of the Champions League. Now only 2 are standing Eight goals let in by Newcastle. Eight more by Chelsea. Tottenham gave up seven, and Manchester City allowed five. So much for English dominance in the Champions League this season. The goals rained in against Premier League clubs, which went from setting the standard in the league phase to largely being blown away in the round of 16. Only Arsenal and Liverpool are standing from the record six English teams that entered the Champions League this season. Five of those qualified automatically to the round of 16 – more than any other nation – and Newcastle made it a full set when it advanced via the playoffs. But it's been a different story over the past two weeks with City, Chelsea, Newcastle and Tottenham all eliminated this round. Tottenham rallied to beat Atletico Madrid 3-2 on Wednesday but could not overturn a 5-2 first-leg loss. The score was 7-5 on aggregate for Atletico.

Galatasaray player Noa Lang sustains freak hand injury



Galatasaray forward Noa Lang sustained a freak hand injury when he caught his thumb on an advertising hoarding in his team's 4-0 loss to Liverpool in the Champions League on Wednesday. Lang was taken to a hospital due to the deep wound, Galatasaray coach Okan Buruk said, and it may require surgery. The Netherlands international writhed in pain near Liverpool's goal with blood streaming from the injury and was comforted by Liverpool players before being carried away on a stretcher. "He's going to the hospital right now, an important issue he has with his finger," Buruk said. "Very quickly, they have brought him there. If there is a necessity for an operation here immediately, there will be a decision to make." Lang was challenging Liverpool midfielder Curtis Jones for the ball in the 75th minute when he stumbled backward into the hoarding at Anfield. He appeared to trap his thumb between two hoardings and immediately clutched his hand in pain. Galatasaray's medical team came to treat him as play was stopped, with Lang in visible discomfort. Liverpool advanced to the quarterfinals with a 4-1 aggregate win.

Mohamed Salah sets up Liverpool against PSG showdown

JAMES ROBSONAP
■ Liverpool

It has been a season to forget for Mohamed Salah.

But the Egyptian icon fired Liverpool into the quarterfinals of the Champions League on Wednesday, scoring his 50th Champions League goal.

But this is still far from vintage Salah. He got a first-half penalty so wrong that it was hard to tell if he was trying an audacious Panenka' chip or if it was simply a horrible mis-kick. Either way, it was an embarrassing moment just before halftime and all too typical of a campaign in which Salah's powers appear to have diminished. That all changed after the break when he was



at the heart of a Liverpool goal spree that sealed a 4-1 aggregate win over Galatasaray and set up a showdown with defending champion Paris Saint-Germain.

"That tells you about the mental strength of him," Liverpool coach Arne Slot said. With Liverpool leading 1-0 at

CAF chief defends stripping Senegal of title

CIARAN FAHEYAP
■ Geneva

The president of African soccer's governing body has defended its integrity and impartiality after Senegal's government called for an international investigation into "suspected corruption" at the organization after it stripped the country of its Africa Cup of Nations title.

Patrice Motsepe, the president of the Confederation of African Football, sought Wednesday to explain the decision made by its appeals board on Tuesday that ruled Senegal had forfeited the final in January by walking off the field, turning its 1-0 win in extra time into a 3-0 default win for host nation

Morocco. "The CAF disciplinary board took one decision. The CAF appeals board took a totally different position. And I'm told that Senegal is going to appeal, which is very important," Motsepe said in a video published on the CAF website. "We will adhere and respect the decision that's taken at the highest level." Motsepe said that CAF's disciplinary and appeals board members are chosen from names proposed by each of its 54 member associations.

"If you look at the composition of those bodies, they reflect some of the most respected lawyers and judges on the continent," he said. "These are people who have integrity and have a



track record. ... the independence is reflected by the decisions that were taken by the two bodies."

Contrasting decisions: In January, CAF's disciplinary board imposed fines of more than \$1 million against the

Senegalese and Moroccan federations together. It issued suspensions against the Senegal coach and several players. But it did not interfere with the outcome of the final.

CAF's appeals board on

Inter Miami star Messi scores milestone 900th goal

TIM REYNOLDSAP
■ Fort Lauderdale (USA)

Lionel Messi has reached another milestone, getting his 900th career goal in the opening minutes of Inter Miami's CONCACAF Champions Cup Round of 16 match against Nashville on Wednesday night.

The back-to-back Major League Soccer MVP, eight-time Ballon D'Or winner and World Cup champion got it as would be expected - with his left foot, like the majority of his career goals for club and country. He took a pass in the middle of the box in the seventh minute, controlled the ball, spun and lined a low shot through a maze of defenders and into the far corner of the net.



Cristiano Ronaldo is the only other men's player with more than 900 goals — at least, by official counts. It took Ronaldo about 100 more matches to get to the milestone than Messi needed; Ronaldo was 39 when he got to 900 goals in September 2024, while Messi doesn't turn 39 until June.

The historic goal drew the attention of stars names from even outside the soccer world. Basketball Hall of Famer Magic Johnson posted on social media that Messi reaching 900 goals is an "incredible milestone."

"What an unbelievable feat!" Johnson wrote.

There are some who have

suggested Brazilian legend Pele topped 1,000 goals for his career, though his "official" total is closer to 800. Different sources, counting different sets of games, list Pele's goal totals anywhere from around 650 in league matches to somewhere near 1,300 in all matches - some against low-level competition. It was a night where Messi surely didn't feel like celebrating. Nashville tied Inter Miami 1-1, advancing to the tournament quarterfinals on an away-goal tiebreaker. The teams played to a 0-0 tie in Nashville last week, the opening leg of the Round of 16 matchup. Nashville coach B.J. Callaghan paid tribute after the game, saying, "900 goals, congratulations to him." (AP)

Pavic becomes youngest Bayern player in UCL

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Munich

Bayern Munich defender Filip Pavic became the club's youngest-ever Champions League player and the third-youngest in the competition's history when he came off the bench against Atalanta on Wednesday.

Aged 16 years and 58 days, Pavic came on for right-back Josip Stanisic in the 72nd minute with Bayern leading 4-0 on the night after having won the first leg 6-1.

UEFA said Pavic was the first player born in 2010 to feature in a Champions League game and the third-youngest in history. Arsenal's Max Dowman was 15 when



he made his debut against Slavia Prague in November, and Youssoufa Moukoko was 16 years and 18 days old when he came off the bench

for Borussia Dortmund against Zenit St Petersburg in 2020. Pavic pushes Barcelona's Lamine Yamal down to fourth on the all-

time list. Bayern's previous youngest Champions League player was Paul Wanner, who was 16 years and 9 months old in a game against Viktoria Plzen in 2022. Pavic wasn't the only Bayern youngster on the field. The 18-year-old Lennart Karl scored his fourth Champions League goal of the season and there was a debut for 18-year-old Deniz Ofler off the bench for defensive midfielder Aleksandar Pavlovic. Ofler forced a turnover to start the play that ended with Karl scoring Bayern's third goal.

Bayern won Wednesday's game 4-1 and the tie 10-2 on aggregate to move on to a quarterfinal meeting with Real Madrid.

African soccer's long history of trophy controversies

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Lagos (Nigeria)

Two months after the chaotic end to the Africa Cup of Nations final between Senegal and Morocco, the outcome of the game remains in dispute.

Senegal was stripped of its title on Tuesday when African soccer's governing body ruled it had forfeited the final in January by walking off the field. The Confederation of African Football's appeals board turned Senegal's 1-0 win in extra time into a 3-0 default victory for Morocco.

But the Teranga Lions are not giving up the title without a fight. Senegal has vowed to appeal CAF's ruling to the sport's highest court —

meaning the final say could be as much as a year away.

CAF's unprecedented decision to strip Senegal of the trophy is just the latest controversy for African soccer and its governing body. Here are some others.

Deadly ambush in Angola

Togo reluctantly pulled out of the 2010 Africa Cup after a deadly ambush on its team bus in Cabinda in northern Angola killed three people and injured eight. The players wanted to compete in honor of the assistant coach, team spokesman and Angolan bus driver who were killed in the attack, but they were ordered home by then-Togolese Prime Minister Gilbert Houngbo, who said Angola failed to protect the



team. Togo was disqualified from the tournament, and CAF denied the team's request to rejoin.

The governing body subsequently banned Togo from the next two editions, saying the decision to withdraw

was politically influenced.

Host countries replaced

Every Africa Cup since 2013 has been moved because of problems with the original host, starting when South Africa hosted the 2013 tournament because of war in

respect, that there's ethics, that there's governance, as well as credibility in the results of our football matches," said Motsepe, who said the incidents in the final had exposed the work CAF was doing to address suspicion and distrust.

"It's a legacy issue. When I became president one of the major concerns was the impartiality, the independence, and the respect of referees and match commissioners, and a lot of good, good work has been done," he said. "That there continues to be suspicions because it's a legacy issue, it's something that has been there for many, many years and we consistently deal with that because that's critically important." (AP)

Jonas Urbig returns amid injury crisis as Bayern beat Atalanta

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Munich

A week after sustaining a concussion, Jonas Urbig was back in goal to guide Bayern Munich past Atalanta and into the Champions League quarterfinals Wednesday.

Urbig returned amid an injury crisis that nearly meant a chance for 16-year-old goalkeeper Leonard Prescott in the Champions League round-of-16 second-leg game.

Urbig faced eight shots on target as Bayern won 4-1 to wrap up a 10-2 aggregate win. He kicked the post in frustration after Lazar Samardzic managed to head in a consolation goal for Atalanta in the 85th.

Bayern striker Harry Kane joked he was relieved not to be called upon to repeat his feat from 2014, when he had to step in as goalkeeper for Tottenham in a Europa League game when Hugo Lloris was sent off.

"I had my time in goal and I'm one and done, to be honest," Kane told broadcaster DAZN. "Obviously, Jonas was looking good and it was great for him to be able to play for us today."

Urbig, normally Bayern's second choice in goal, sustained a concussion after colliding with an opponent when Bayern won the first leg 6-1 last week. Fellow goalkeepers Manuel Neuer and Sven Ulreich have injuries too and



weren't in the squad.

Urbig was named in the starting lineup just over an hour before kickoff. Prescott and the 19-year-old Jannis Bartl were on the bench.

Bayern coach Vincent Kompany said Tuesday that Urbig's return would be a "purely medical decision" and he'd been training as normal.

New York-born Prescott was on the bench for the team's Bundesliga game Saturday when third-choice Ulreich tore an adductor muscle. Kompany had said Prescott would be the preferred option if Urbig couldn't play. Another 16-year-old did get a debut as defender Filip Pavic came off the bench at right back, becoming Bayern's youngest-ever Champions League player. Bayern has also been dealing with injuries to left back Alphonso Davies and forward Jamal Musiala after last week's win at Atalanta.

Harry Kane was back in Bayern's starting lineup for the first time since Feb. 28 after a calf issue, and scored twice.

Champions League: Barcelona scores 7, Liverpool revives, Bayern cruises and Atletico survives

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Barcelona scored seven and Liverpool revived its season with four goals to flip tight Champions League games Wednesday into big wins sending them to the quarterfinals. Atletico Madrid survived a pulsating Tottenham fightback to make it Spain 3, England 0 in round-of-16 clashes this week.

Bayern Munich had it easiest of all, pushing aside Atalanta 4-1 on Wednesday and 10-2 on aggregate, to get a blockbuster quarterfinal against Real Madrid.

Another Champions League goals rush was sparked by Barcelona tearing apart Newcastle in the

second half of a thrilling 7-2 win after the teams went toe-to-toe before the break.

Tied 1-1 after the first leg in Newcastle, Barcelona surged to a victory after Lamine Yamal's momentum-shifting penalty kick in first-half stoppage time made the score 3-2. Robert Lewandowski then scored twice, Fermin Lopez finished a slick move and Raphinha got his second goal as Newcastle's defense collapsed. Liverpool ultimately eased to a 4-0 win over Galatasaray at Anfield, overturning a one-goal loss in Istanbul, despite Mohamed Salah missing a penalty in first-half stoppage time when the score was 1-0. Still, Salah was key to Liverpool's strong second half with two assists,

for Hugo Ekitike and Ryan Gravenberch, then a trademark goal in a performance that could restart an erratic season for the English champions. "From start to finish, we played the game I was hoping for, the players were hoping for and the fans were hoping for," said Liverpool coach Arne Slot, who has been under growing pressure. Tottenham showed real character after an embarrassing 5-2 loss in Madrid last week but was resisted by Atletico twice leveling the score in Wednesday's second leg. Xavi Simons' late penalty at least gave Tottenham a 3-2 win on the night. Tottenham and Newcastle joined Manchester City, ousted by Real Madrid on



Tuesday 5-1 on aggregate score, as Premier League teams eliminated by La Liga's best. England had a record six teams in the competition and all reached the round of 16, but only Arsenal and Liverpool advanced. Chelsea

was eliminated Tuesday by defending champion Paris Saint-Germain. In Munich, fit-again Bayern talisman Harry Kane scored twice, the second an impressive rising shot after deft footwork, against Atalanta to end Italy's

challenge in this Champions League edition.

Goals galore for Barcelona: Barcelona is scoring for fun at Camp Nou this year. It's now eight games at home in the Champions League, La Liga or Copa del Rey and Barcelona has won all eight, getting at least three goals each time.

Seven against Newcastle was the best yet for coach Hansi Flick team, started by Raphinha's sixth-minute shot — finishing a move where two Newcastle defenders slipped to the turf — then 18-year-old Marc Bernal found space alone in the goalmouth in the 18th.

Newcastle soon leveled each time with rare goals from Anthony Elanga. The Sweden winger was goalless

in 35 previous games this season in the Premier League or Champions League yet struck twice in a 13-minute spell. Barcelona got a fast start to the second half when Lopez ran clear on to slick passes from Gerard Martin to Raphinha to score with a well-placed shot and Newcastle's chance was gone. "I saw new, improved confidence in that second-half performance," Flick said.

Quarterfinals pairings: Real Madrid will play Bayern Munich, in a clash of 15-time and six-time European champions. They still have never met in the final across 71 years of the European Cup and Champions League.

"Every club would live for these games," Bayern coach

Vincent Kompany said. "As a neutral, I'd watch it." Liverpool face defending champion PSG with the first leg at Parc des Princes. It's a rematch of their thrilling round-of-16 games last season, that Slot reminded Wednesday: "We were the only team that brought them to extra time and penalties." The second leg at Anfield should be on Tuesday, April 14. Liverpool hasn't played on April 15 since the Hillsborough Stadium disaster on that date in 1989.

Barcelona and Atletico Madrid meet again twice just weeks after they played a two-leg domestic cup semifinal. Then, Atletico won 4-0 at home and lost 3-0 at Camp Nou to reach the Copa del Rey final.

Like Rohit and Virat, Sanju can't be replaced: Riyan Parag

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

Rajasthan Royals skipper Riyan Parag on Thursday said the void left by Sanju Samson's departure to Chennai Super Kings cannot be filled as finding a replacement for the T20 World Cup hero is as impossible as replacing stalwarts like Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli in the Indian team.

Sanju, who led the Royals from 2021 to 2025, was traded to Chennai Super Kings in a pre-season move, with Ravindra Jadeja coming in as part of the deal.

"If you talk about Sanju bhaiya, we never think about replacing the kind of player he is," Parag told

reporters in a pre-season press conference here.

"We can perhaps look for someone with a similar skill-set or have someone bat in his position...It's like there is no replacement for Virat Kohli or Rohit Sharma... In the same way, there is no replacement for Sanju bhaiya because he is such a good player," Parag said, referring to the two superstars who only play the ODI format now.

Having represented the franchise for 11 years across two stints, Sanju was RR's most successful captain and leading run-scorer, having guided them to the IPL 2022 final and the playoffs in 2024.

His stature has grown manifold following a stellar T20 World Cup campaign, where



Rajasthan Royals captain Riyan Parag, left, with team's Head Coach Kumar Sangakkara, during a pre-season press conference ahead of the Indian Premier League (IPL) 2026, in Jaipur

he struck three successive match-defining knocks to power India to a historic title defence. He was adjudged player of the tournament for the phenomenal performance.

Rajasthan Royals had a forgettable last season, enduring 10 defeats to finish ninth in the 10-team standings.

Parag, who has been picked as the captain following Sanju's exit, said RR lost far too many close matches last year and the 2008 winners need better strategy and planning.

"This year, the focus is to plan better and finish games, which we couldn't do in the previous edition," he said.

"We need to plan well. Last year, there were about 5-6 games which we lost in the

last over or even on the last ball. Had we been able to convert those, or had we calculated better, this question (if RR would try anything new) would not have been asked because we would have qualified (for knock-outs) by winning those matches," he explained.

"I think that in every T20 game, there are 3-4 decisions that you have to make which change the course of the game. If we take those small decisions with strategy and planning, this year will be different," Parag added.

He further expressed gratitude towards the franchise for keeping faith in him despite several seasons of struggle.

"I was here when I was just 17 and I have seen all the ups

and downs, though more downs than ups till now. I want to thank Rajasthan Royals for supporting me and understanding the cricketer I am," Parag said.

Sangakkara backs skipper Parag: The Royals' director of cricket and head coach Kumar Sangakkara said he has always "admired" Parag as a cricketer and he was picked as a skipper after a robust round of interviews with other candidates.

"It was about trying to find the best person who can lead the Rajasthan Royals. I (first) met Riyan when he was a teenager and have admired him as a cricketer. He's right (when he says) he has gone through a lot and seen a lot," Sangakkara said.

Sanju Samson had become face of RR, losing him is massive: Faf du Plessis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Sanju Samson was arguably the face of Rajasthan Royals — much like MS Dhoni with Chennai Super Kings or Virat Kohli with Royal Challengers Bengaluru — and his departure is a significant moment for the franchise given the impact he had, says former South Africa captain Faf du Plessis.

Samson spent 11 seasons with Rajasthan Royals across two stints, emerging as their most-capped player and leading run-scorer. He has now been traded to Chennai Super Kings with Ravindra Jadeja joining the RR ranks.

"If I look at the IPL and the iconic teams we see around

the league, all of them have one marquee Indian player in common — someone who has been the face of the franchise for a period of time, (such as) Rohit Sharma, MS Dhoni, Virat Kohli. Sanju Samson, for me, was that guy at Rajasthan Royals," du Plessis told JioHotstar.

"Yes, he's of a newer generation, but he had become the face of that franchise. If I think of Rajasthan Royals, I think Sanju Samson. So, the fact that they've lost that face is a massive thing for the fans, for the IPL, and for the tournament, because he's played such a big role there," added du Plessis.

He said Samson's departure would place added responsibility on Yashasvi



Jaiswal, who had the freedom to play his natural game alongside the former RR skipper.

"The thing with Yashasvi Jaiswal is that he's had Sanju

game," du Plessis said.

"Now, you take that away, all of a sudden, people will look at him with more responsibility. For a player like him, you don't want him thinking about responsibility. You want him thinking, 'I want to take the game on. I want to hit as many sixes as possible'."

"There's a learning curve that's going to come into his career this season, 'Am I true to the game that I've always played, or do I take up the senior player role to score the bulk of the runs?' So it'll be interesting to see how that goes. I think he'll still play in the way that he does. It would be silly not to, because he's such an attacking player."

Former India pacer Lakshmipathy Balaji said he was surprised by Royals' decision to appoint Riyan Parag as captain, despite the presence of more experienced players such as Jaiswal, veteran India all-rounder Ravindra Jadeja, and England's Sam Curran.

"I'm a little bit surprised with the call, especially when you have players like Yashasvi Jaiswal, Ravindra Jadeja and overseas captaincy material like Sam Curran. It is kind of a gamble."

He felt the decision to appoint Parag could have mixed outcomes, and the guidance of head coach Kumar Sangakkara could prove invaluable.



Jos Buttler hopes break will help him in IPL 2026

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

England batting mainstay Jos Buttler has said that spending time away from cricket after a disappointing T20 World Cup campaign should put him in good stead as he looks for a fresh start with the Gujarat Titans in the Indian Premier League beginning later this month.

Former England captain Buttler continued to receive the team's backing even as his runs dried up during the T20 World Cup in India and Sri Lanka, a lean patch for one of the country's most prominent white-ball batters.

Buttler managed just 87 runs across eight matches at an average of 10.87, with a forgettable strike rate of 116, while opening the batting for England at the World Cup. England bowed out of the tournament after losing to India in a high-scoring semifinal in Mumbai.

The 35-year-old hopes that the break he took from the game since that semifinal on March 5 should help him heading into the IPL starting on March 28.

"I couldn't have been further away from cricket, which for me at the time was just perfect. It's exactly what I needed," Buttler said on 'For the Love of Cricket' podcast.

"Obviously, the tournament didn't go personally how I'd have liked it to go. I just felt like I needed some space (away) from cricket and not to think about the game, and I could not have been further away from cricket where I was in that week," he said.

IPL 2022 winners Gujarat Titans will get their campaign underway on March 31 in an away game against Punjab Kings.

Buttler said the break was energising, which also gave him time to reflect.



Ai+ Smartphone partners with MI, KKR ahead of IPL 2026

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Ai+ Smartphone will be the smartphone partner for Mumbai Indians and Kolkata Knight Riders in the upcoming IPL season, with both teams expecting the association to boost fan engagement.

Through this association, Ai+ Smartphone, an India-built brand, aims to integrate across team platforms, fan experiences, and digital activations throughout the season, creating new opportunities for fans to engage with both the teams and the brand.

"For Ai+, the partnership represents more than brand visibility, it's when India comes together across cities, communities, and generations. By aligning with two of the league's most iconic franchises, Ai+ Smartphone aims to become part of those moments where competition, celebration, and collective excitement define the national conversation," said

Ai+ Smartphone in a release.

Mumbai Indians are five-time IPL champions, while Kolkata Knight Riders have won the T20 tournament three times.

"Cricket in India brings together fans, communities, and shared moments at an unmatched scale. Our approach to partnerships is focused on creating meaningful engagement and delivering experiences that feel relevant and accessible to fans. With Ai+ Smartphone, we look forward to building initiatives that deepen this connection and add value to the overall fan journey," said Binda Dey, CMO, Knight Riders Sports.

"Ai+ Smartphone's focus on delivering accessible, high-performance technology aligns well with the evolving expectations of today's fans. We look forward to collaborating on initiatives that enhance how fans engage with the game," said a spokesperson for five-time IPL champions Mumbai Indians.

Tendulkar-backed cricket academy to open in Ahmedabad on April 10

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

A Sachin Tendulkar-backed Centre of Excellence Cricket Academy will open here on April 10, promising a battery of former Indian players as mentors and world-class training facilities for aspirants aged 5 and above.

The SRT10 Altevol Centre of Excellence Cricket Academy was to be launched last year, but after overcoming a delay, it is set to commence operations with a training module focused on "technique, fitness, and structured growth pathways."

Located at Shankus Farm



near Vaishnodevi Circle on SG Road, the campus infrastructure includes professional cricket nets, an in-house match-ready ground, high-performance gymnasium, and a running track.

The flagship SRT10 Global

Germany's Alexander Waske Tennis University, along with the Shankus Group, adds both credibility and a strong multi-sport perspective, aligning seamlessly with SRT10's focus on excellence and values-driven development," stated a press release.

"A contingent of former first-class/Team India cricketers will mentor the young talents. Coaches are hand-picked and trained under the SRT10 methodology, ensuring consistency with international training standards. The programme is led by Dr. Atul Gaikwad, Global Head Coach, SRT10 Global Academy," it added.

JPMorgan aims to help athletes avoid bad money habits

KEN SWEET ■ New York

JPMorgan Chase said Wednesday that it will start building wealth advising services that help athletes who come into money as a result of their talents make that money work for them a long time.

The initiative is not aimed just at ultrawealthy athletes of legend. The initiative is aimed at athletes across all sports, ages and income levels, from college athletes earning royalties from their name, image and likeness for the first time, to established athletes who have earned substantial sums but are now looking at retirement in their mid-30s and need to make those sums last for decades.

JPMorgan hopes to reach these athletes early, maybe as early as high school but certainly on college campuses, in hopes of teaching them good financial habits from the start.

"They are coming into a lot of money, and they don't know what to do with it," said Megan Rapinoe, the professional soccer player and Olympic gold medalist.

JPMorgan isn't doing this for charity. Those few who become professional athletes can end up millionaires many times over, and the biggest stars can end up billionaires. Managing those funds through JPMorgan's wealth management arm could lead to millions of dollars in fees for the bank, and athletes' name recogni-



tion can bring future customers to the bank.

There have been numerous stories of athletes running into financial difficulties despite coming into tremendous wealth during their careers. Academic

research has shown that one in six NFL players will end up filing for bankruptcy within 12 years of retirement. Mike Tyson reportedly made half a billion in his boxing career but had to file for bankruptcy, and there are similar

stories for legends like boxer Evander Holyfield and basketball player Antoine Walker.

The stories are often the same: athletes come into tremendous wealth but are not given the education to make it last as long as it needs to.

Peloton Instructor Ally Love said she often felt embarrassed or scared to ask for financial advice, even after she found success with Peloton. She remembered one of her first meetings with a bank where her interactions with financial advisers left her with more questions than answers.

"I was like, 'Who's Roy?' I thought Roy was spelled with a Y," Love said in an interview with The Associated Press. Only later

did Love learn that "Roy" was not a person, but an abbreviation for return on investment, or ROI.

Love is one of nine athletes who will sit on JPMorgan's new Athlete Council. The council also includes Dwayne Wade, the two-time NBA Hall of Famer from the Miami Heat, Ues Bird, the WNBA champion, and legendary NFL quarterback Tom Brady. Other athletes and personalities include Jalen Brunson from the New York Knicks, World Cup Champion Alex Morgan, Kayvon Thibodeaux of the New York Giants, and A'ja Wilson, the four-time WNBA MVP winner.

Love talked about how she often felt bankers talked down to her, and she felt intimidated. (AP)

Philippines beats Uzbekistan 2-0, clinches World Cup spot

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Gold Coast (Australia)

Angela Beard and Jaclyn Sawicki scored in a six-minute span to help Philippines secure a World Cup spot with a 2-0 victory over Uzbekistan on Thursday in Women's Asian Cup playoffs.

Philippines had nine shots at goal in the first half without being able to break the deadlock, but Beard needed only two minutes following the



interval to make it 1-0.

The ex-Australia youth international perfectly timed her run to the edge of the box and leaped to drive a left-foot volley into the net off the crossbar after Jael-Marie Guy's long, high cross from the right.

Guy crossed from the right again for Sawicki to double the lead with a header from edge of the box in the 52nd to ensure the Philippines qualified for the 2027 Women's World Cup in Brazil.

The Philippines bench

cleared at the full-time whistle as the substitute players sprinted onto the pitch and joined their teammates to celebrate back-to-back World Cup qualification. Philippines placed third in Group A behind South Korea and Australia and had to wait until the last group-stage game to know if they'd advance to the quarterfinals as one of the two best third-place teams. Six teams were guaranteed Women's World Cup places from the continental championship.

Saurav Ghosal appointed sports commissioner of World Premier Squash

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's squash icon Saurav Ghosal was on Thursday appointed as the sports commissioner of the World Premier Squash, a new global professional competition scheduled to be held later this year.

India's only male player to reach the top 10 in the PSA World Rankings, Ghosal

boasts 11 titles, nine Asian Games medals, and two decades of elite competition.

He has also served as the men's president of the Professional Squash Association (PSA) and as co-chair of the joint Athletes Commission of the PSA and World Squash, the sport's global governing body.

"As Sports Commissioner for World Premier Squash

(WPS), Ghosal will set and oversee the league's complete sporting framework, spanning competition formats, player qualification pathways, and officiating standards," said a WPS statement on the league whose inaugural edition will be held in August. "WPS combines elite professional competition with an open global pathway using multimodal AI on the edge.